this is me (trying)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25581634.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Light Hope/Mara (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - College/University, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Friends to Lovers, Fluff, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Angst with a Happy Ending, Comfort/Angst, Minor Character Death, Mentions of hospitals, Physical Therapy, Implied/Referenced Character Death, Everyone Is Gay, Trans Bow (She-Ra), Trans Perfuma (She-Ra), Canon Non-Binary Character, Slow Burn, Non-Binary Entrapta, Autistic Entrapta (She-Ra), Emotional Manipulation, Minor Violence, Misgendering, mentions of transphobia, Mentions of homophobia, Aged-Up Character(s)

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English

Series:
Part 1 of take my hand, wreck my plans

Stats:
Published: 2020-07-29 Completed: 2021-03-07 Words: 64,565 Chapters: 25/25

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by goldiegaytime

Summary

Etheria University; a place where friendships are formed, enemies are made, and brains are turned inside out. But for some students, life decided to make things just a little more exciting (and not always in the fun way). Even more so when these students' lives are intertwined. When the adventures of a jock, an artist, a future politician and a historian in training get tied together, things are sure to get interesting.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

dazed and confused

Chapter Summary

> She had checked her gym bag three times, and had lost count for her suitcase. But no matter how many times she checked them, or how many times she read through her course work (well ahead of time), or did extra training to take her mind off things, Adora didn't feel ready. Would she ever?
> ---
> "Etheria University. Please," she told him, promptly slipping in her headphones before he started asking her any more questions. As the car pulled away from the curb, Catra watched as the dingy old building she had called home fade into the distance. Yeah, it was a dump, but it was all she knew. Until now at least.

Funny how a day that you've counted down for months can still take you off guard when it arrives. One was the first day of college. Adora Grayskull, for once in her life, managed to be normal in at least that regard, heart rising and stomach dropping as she uncapped a marker and crossed off yesterday's date. *MOVE IN DAY* stared at her in bright red letters.

"No going back now, huh?" she mumbled, fiddling with the marker between her fingers. Letting out a shaky exhale, Adora tossed the marker onto her open suitcase before taking the calendar off the wall and doing the same.

"Adora? Are you ready?" a muffled voice called from behind the bedroom door.

“Almost!” Adora replied, taking a few steps forward and opening it. There stood her guardian, Hope, her perfectly pressed navy suit contrasted by the small smile she gave Adora.

“Everything packed?” she asked, clutching her briefcase with both hands.

“Just about, I need to double check my gym bag, and then I should be ready,” Adora replied, crouching by her suitcase and zipping it up. “Well, packed, I’m not sure if I’m entirely ready for all of this, because y’know it’s college, it’s a big deal and-”

“Adora.”

She looked back, seeing Hope in her room with a vague look of concern.

“It’s okay to be frightened.”

“I’m not frightened, I’m just-”

Adora sighed, standing up and turning to face the business woman.

“Are you sure me living on campus is a good idea?” she asked quietly. Hope sighed, taking a few steps closer and gently placing a hand on Adora’s shoulder.

“I know that the university is close enough to home that you could stay here,” Hope started, giving her another soft smile. “But, after- after the events of the past six months, both your grandmother and I think it’s a good idea for you to have a change of space. A clean slate if you will.”

Adora gave a raised eyebrow, reaching up to grasp the sword pendant dangling from around her neck.

“You mean after Mum,” she breathed, looking up at Hope. Her guardian gave a sad smile, squeezing her shoulder a touch.

“It’s a lot for anyone to go through,” Hope started. “Let alone when you’re 18 and about to start college.”

“Don’t remind me,” she chuckled under her breath.

Hope’s smile faded but nodded.

“We’re only a phone call away. And your grandmo-”

"Nana Razz said to visit on weekends because she'll be in town for the markets," Adora finished with a small smirk. Hope gave her a small smile, removing her hand from her shoulder.

"I'll be in the car, don't take too long."

After the door closed behind Hope, Adora sighed quietly, fiddling with the pendant and gazing at the empty room around her. She had checked her gym bag three times, and had lost count for her suitcase. But no matter how many times she checked them, or how many times she read through her course work (well ahead of time), or did extra training to take her mind off things, Adora didn't feel ready. Would she ever?

It doesn't matter. I'm in. I need to make the best of this chance I've been given. I can't afford to throw this away, scholarship or not.

"I can hear you thinking from here, dearie. Do you need anything?"

Despite the odds, Adora managed to smile at the voice through the door.

"I'm alright, Nana Razz," she called back, throwing caution to the wind and slinging her gym bag over her shoulder. "I'm bringing

my stuff down now, I'll be there in a second."

"Alright, dearie. Don't forget Mara!"

Adora's heart sunk just a touch, but despite it, she smiled.

"Never," she mumbled, hand dipping into her pocket and pulling out a polaroid. It was from a few years ago now, Adora around 16 if she remembered correctly; she could tell by the fresh chip in her front tooth. The lighting was soft and ethereal, Adora clad in her favourite jacket that she still wore (red with the white piped stripes down the side), her mother, Mara wearing the same in baby blue. She had pulled Adora into a fierce, side hug, gray eyes bright with yellow cake icing smeared across her forehead, traces of it in her brown braided hair. Adora had the same icing spread across her cheek, leaning into her mother's embrace. She could hear the two of them laughing, the memory replaying in her mind.

"Happy birthday to me, huh peanut? You know I'm still quicker than you!~"

"Mum, you're meant to eat the cake, not fight me with it!"

She would have turned 40 a few days ago.

Gently running her thumb over the photo, she smiled to herself, and slid the photo back into her pocket.

"I'm so proud of you, Adora. You're going to do such wonderful things."

Steeling herself with a deep breath, she walked through the bedroom door with bags in hand, and headed into the unknown.

"I'm leaving."

Duffle bag slung over her shoulder, Catra watched the older woman with scathing eyes. But she stared, unrelenting at the fireplace that was already crackling, black hair hiding any part of her face. Typical. As far back as she can remember, Sister Zylah had disliked Catra from the start. For any particular reason? No idea. All that Catra knew was that she was glad to be getting out of her hair for the next few months.

"Very well," she drawled eventually, still looking straight ahead. And once again, absolutely not a flicker of emotion. Whoever thought this hag should be around kids was clearly on something.

“I won’t be back until winter break. Looks like you’ll actually have to do something around here when I’m gone,” Catra said, her snarl thinly veiled.

“Have you forgotten that you have aged out of our program?”

The woman turned to face her with cold, dead eyes, mouth and nose covered by the black fabric mask she was never without.

“You turned 18 last year, Catra. You will be 19 at the end of October. I was gracious enough to let you stay an extra year, but after you have left, you will not be permitted to return.”

Catra gave a short laugh, clutching the straps of her bag.

“Aw, you remember my birthday? Don’t go all soft on me Sister Zy-”

“Silence.”

Catra didn’t have the patience to deal with this right now, biting her tongue to stop the surge of insults from escaping.

"Be sure that all of your things have been removed from your room. This will be the last we see of each other."

Catra glanced at her bag that contained all of her worldly possessions. Yeah, that was everything, crammed into a dusty, old bag. But it was something at least.

"Goodbye to you too," she scoffed. When Sister Zylah didn't respond, Catra shook her head with a sigh, and stalked out of the room.

Slamming the door behind her, Catra took a deep breath of the fresh air. One of the many things she was not going to miss about Weaver's Foster Agency was how musty the stupid building always was. Plus, how Sister Zylah always seemed to have a stick up her-

HOOOOONK!

The taxi driver sat out front, and Catra could smell the entitlement from here. Big talk for someone who made a living driving around strangers, but Catra could care less about starting an argument with a pot-bellied, balding, likely divorced loser. So she climbed into the backseat, closed the door and took out her headphones.

"Etheria University. Please," she told him, promptly slipping in her headphones before he started asking her any more questions. As the car pulled away from the curb, Catra watched as the dingy old building she had called home fade into the distance. Yeah, it was a dump, but it was all she knew. Until now at least. After the best University in town offered her a scholarship for her art, there was no way in hell she was going to say no. Getting paid to draw *and* getting out of that dump? Two birds down with one stone.

Except now you need somewhere to live before winter break , dumbass.

Sure. Whatever. That could wait. Besides, it was only September, December seemed like forever and a half away. With a bit of luck, the dorms might have heating. Hell, they might actually let her stay there over the break.

If you don't get kicked out first.

Rolling her eyes at her own, stupid thoughts, she dug through her bag until her hands landed on her sketchbook, retrieving it from the depths of the 4 shirts she owned. She did not have the patience to deal with this right now. Her trusty charcoal pencil found its way into her hand, short steady strokes flicking along the page as she tidied up a design for a piece she'd been working on for months now. Music up, charcoal in hand and on her way to a new start, Catra let the world pass her by. Just for a little while. She'd figure out the rest of what to do as it came.

“Are you sure you haven’t forgotten anything?”

“100% sure, Hope,” Adora replied for the fourth time since they had left, the question forgotten as the car approached the ornate brick building. Crowds bustled beyond the packed car pack, full of students and families, their arms piled high with books and bags, folks with *EU* shirts escorting various people in different directions. This was it.

“Get excited, dearie! Your adventure is about to begin,” Nana Razz chirped as all three women excited the car. While Hope opened the boot to retrieve Adora’s suitcase, the elderly woman wrapped her arms around the teenager’s waist.

“Now, you make sure you be good. Have you got your evil eye charm?”

Adora chuckled in response, hugging her grandmother close. Instead of replying to her question, one hand dug through her pocket to pull out the small charm of a blue eye attached to her keys.

“Right here, Nana Razz.”

The white haired woman looked up to see it, nodding with a smile as Adora tucked it away.

"Good, now I have something else for you," she beamed, unwrapping the young girl from her embrace and digging through her satchel.

"Nana Razz, you don't have to give-"

"Ah ah ah! Too bad, here you go!"

Before she could protest, a small bag was shoved into Adora's hands. Bringing it up, she scanned through the sheer fabric, making out the sight of a few familiar ingredients that Nana Razz tended to use in almost everything. The salt was easy to spot, as was the lavender. Rosemary was in there as well, and possibly mint if the smell was anything to go by, the herbs swallowing a small yellow stone.

"It's to keep the nightmares away," the grandmother hummed. "I made your mother the same one when she started here."

The two shared a sad smile, and Adora tucked the small bag into her pocket.

"Thanks Nana Razz," she hummed, feeling a hand on her shoulder. Turning, Adora saw Hope with her suitcase and a small

barely noticeable to anyone but Adora.

"Are you sure you don't want us to help you get settled?" she asked, Adora slinging her gym bag strap across her shoulder and taking her suitcase.

"No, I'll be okay. But thank you, Hope. Really," she answered, smiling up at the woman towering over her.

Hope gave a single nod, followed by a brief flicker of a smile.

"Take care of yourself, Adora."

The blonde nodded, giving her grandmother one last hug before taking her bags and letting the ushers coax her away.

"Name?"

"Catra Weaver," she drawled, picking at the black, chipped nail polish.

The brightest green eyes Catra had ever seen blinked up at her, the student flicking a platinum blonde braid behind their shoulder, scratching one of their shaved sides as they flipped through a series of pages.

"Major?"

"Art."

"Oooh lovely, we've had a drought of creative types around here. Good to see some fresh meat coming in," they purred, sending Catra a wink and a wide grin. Their teeth were almost unnaturally white, canines more prominent than usual.

They look like they walked straight out of the goddamn Feywilds , she thought to herself. *They'd make a good model if they shut up for long enough though.*

"Ah, here we are!" they sang, pulling out a paper from the stack with a flourish. "Catra, darling, have you got some photo ID for me?"

Rolling her eyes, Catra pulled out her Proof of Age card, tossing it onto the counter. Perfectly manicured nails picked it up, checking it against what she assumed was her file.

“Perfect, all checks out,” they mused, handing Catra back her ID and the file. “You’re in F Block, Room 26. It’s a triple, and both of your roommates have been moved in already. Just follow the signs to your block, and your room will be on the second floor. Key is in the file, make sure you write your name, major and pronouns on the sign on the door.”

Catra gave a single nod, tucking the file under her arm.

“Cool, thank you-” she trailed off, looking at the sticker on their shirt.

Hello! My name is: DT

My pronouns are: they/them

“DT. Thanks,” she finished, giving them a small smile.

“My pleasure, darling. See you around~” they sang, waving goodbye as Catra exited the building.

Well, that was interesting. Now for the biggest potential problem of them all; roommates.

crush culture

Chapter Summary

Adora really had hoped that her moving onto campus would give her at least some sense of normality. But as Glimmer's words refused to slow down, asking question after question without even pausing to take a breath, she knew that normality had chosen that exact moment to fly out the window.

Not many students were out and about now. Catra guessed that they had retreated into their dorms, not that she was complaining. Time alone in the sun drawing with a low chance of anyone seeing or disturbing her? Yes please.

Chapter Notes

tw; mention of minor character death

"B Block," Adora mumbled to herself, following the several signs scattered around the campus path. "B Block, B, B- aha!"

Double checking her file, she scanned through to find her room number and retrieve her key.

"Room 11, got it," she mumbled to herself, heading towards the building, eyes set on the first floor, where (somewhere) her new room was nestled.

Apparently, she was in a triple room. This meant not just one new roommate, but two new people that she would share a room with

for at least a year. This could go super well, or crash and burn. Adora hoped for the former.

Before she had enough time to mentally prepare herself, there she was. A brass 11 stared down at her, stormy eyes flicking down to a crisp, white sheet, two spaces filled with violently different handwriting styles.

Name:	Major:	Pronouns:
Bow Fletcher	History!	He/Him
Glimmer Brightmoon	Political Science :)	She/Her

Digging through her pocket, she whipped out a pen and clicked it, filling the last space left open on the paper.

Name:	Major:	Pronouns:
Bow Fletcher	History!	He/Him
Glimmer Brightmoon	Political Science :)	She/Her
Adora Grayskull	History	She/Her

Alright, stop putting off meeting them. Just rip it off like a bandaid, or a wax strip on your eyebrow that's about to take off more hair than intended. Wait, that's stupid.

Resisting the urge to facepalm at her own brain, she let out an exhale as she swiped her key, and slowly opened the door.

Immediately, Adora was met with a visual assault of overwhelming colour. Both beds were covered with bright patterns, one purple with gold stars, another a red and yellow plaid. Fairy lights were hung around the entirety of the room, a large flag of dark pink, purple and deep blue hung on the right wall. This was a lot.

As she walked in, Adora faced a window, with one of the made beds tucked into a corner either side, facing the door. The corner to her right was taken by an empty bed, a large closet in the left one, already covered with polaroid photos. A large closet that two people were currently digging through.

"Uh, hi?"

Adora watched both figures stiffen, the two slowly turning their heads and peering at their intruder. She guessed these were her roommates.

The girl, Glimmer, stood below her chin with broad shoulders and wide hips, but she held her head high, pastel pink hair fluffed out and framing her face, with eyes piercing through Adora. The boy, Bow, was only an inch taller than Adora, rich dark skin over a lithe figure and deep eyes that watched her curiously. After a moment, he broke into a gleaming grin.

"Hi there! I'm guessing you're our roommate, huh?"

Adora closed the door behind her, fiddling with backpack straps.

"I guess so," she shrugged, a constrictive feeling in her chest making itself known. Mentally shaking the feeling aside, she extended a hand to the pair. "I'm Adora."

Bow took her head immediately, his hand warm and calloused with a firm shake.

"It's so nice to meet you, Adora! I'm Bow, but I guess you got that from the sheet on the door."

"I did, we actually share a major," she admitted sheepishly. Bow's eyes immediately lit up, and Adora wondered why she had the overwhelming urge to hug this man.

"A fellow history nerd! See, I told you Glimmer." He nudged the smaller girl with his elbow, and Adora offered her hand.

"It's nice to meet you, Glimmer," Adora tried, hoping the smile she gave wasn't as awkward as she felt. Soft eyes scanned over Adora's figure, before Glimmer took her hand and shook it.

"You too," she hummed, crossing her arms and giving her a slight smile. "You don't really look like a history major."

“What does a history major even look like?” Bow interjected. “Like, button up shirts and glasses?”

“That’s not what I meant, Bow, because you don’t look like one either,” Glimmer retorted, lightly shoving him. “I just meant that she looks like the real sporty type.”

Three voices clashed, all speaking at the same time.

“Glimmer, *you* don’t look like the sporty type either but-”

“Y’know, like Mara Grayskull! The jackets are almost the same-”

“Well, I am here on a sports scholarship so-”

Adora wished the silence would swallow her whole.

Glimmer paused for a moment, looking Adora up and down before murmuring “Hold on,” and opening the door, peeking her head outside. When Glimmer went silent, Bow furrowed his eyebrows,

slotting himself beside the smaller girl and following suit, but offering nothing but silence to Adora still inside.

After an eternity, they finally spoke.

"Holy shi-"

"Language!"

Both heads popped back inside, Bow's eyes staring with curiosity while Glimmer's were blown wide.

"Grayskull?" Glimmer asked.

Oh fudge.

Roommates. Two of them. Catra could taste the sarcastic joy in her mouth without even muttering a "woohoo". Still, Catra was going to be in and out. Drop off her bedding, do all the pleasantries that she was supposed to, then disappear to find a quiet place that she could draw in peace.

Unable to put it off any longer, she saw the brass 26 and a white sheet of paper staring down at her.

Name:	Major:	Pronouns:
Entrapta Dryl ¯_(ツ)_/¯	Engineering (Mechatronics!!)	She/They
Scorpia Stevenson	Business	She/Her

Well, this was certainly going to be interesting. Sighing, she dug out her pencil, scribbling in the empty space so she didn't get an upperclassman on her back. It was only the first day.

Name:	Major:	Pronouns:
Entrapta Dryl ¯_(ツ)_/¯	Engineering (Mechatronics!!)	She/They
Scorpia Stevenson	Business	She/Her
Catra Weaver	Art	She/Her

Let's get this over with .

Opening the door, the sight Catra was presented with gave her whiplash. Two people, of violently different appearance, sitting

together at the table by the window on the far wall. The two made beds were tucked into the left and right corners against said wall, the empty bed in the left corner closest to the door, a large closet in the right one. One large woman, with shaved sides and a platinum quiff, sat with two metal arms resting on her lap, watching the smaller person with a smile. The other one, with the longest hair Catra had ever seen (pastel purple of all colours, and in pigtails), wore a set of goggles and tinkered with the metal arms on her lap, reeking of fascination.

Right. This was definitely going to be interesting. The larger woman looked up to face Catra, and broke into a sickeningly sweet smile.

"Hey there! You're our last roomie, huh?" she beamed. "Welcome! I'm Scorpia, this is Entrapta. I'd give you a hug, but-" Scorpia shrugged, looking to her arms currently trapped by Entrapta's grip. "My hands are a little preoccupied right now."

"That's fine," Catra replied. "I'm just in and out anyway." She threw her bag on the empty bed, digging through to find her sheets before pausing. She should at least try to be polite. Catra turned to face them both, giving a slight nod.

"I'm Catra," she started. "You're studying Business, right?"

"Correct-a-mundo!" Scorpia replied. "What about you? Wait! Let me guess." The blonde looked Catra up and down, a wrinkle between her eyebrows and slightly pouting in thought.

This woman is like a giant human marshmallow.

"You kinda look like one of those skater types that don't wanna talk about their feelings, so I'm gonna guess...art?"

Crap. She's intuitive too.

"Ding ding," Catra drawled with a slight smirk, turning back to her bed and finding the sheets in her bag. "Though I haven't skateboarded in years."

"That's super cool! What mediums do you use?"

"Charcoal."

"Did you know that charcoal's burning temperature is almost twice as high as the melting temperature of iron?" a new voice chimed, somewhere between squeaking and nasal.

Catra glanced over her shoulder, seeing Entrapta still focused on Scorpia's prosthetics.

“Uh, no, I didn’t,” Catra answered, retrieving her sheets and tossing her bag on the ground, tuning out Entrapta’s rambling as she made her bed. The two voices fell into the white noise at the back of Catra’s mind, and she felt an odd sense of ease. Maybe, life could finally be normal. As her hands finished slotting her pillow into its case, she tuned back into the voices.

“I hear they’re having some kind of party tomorrow night! Help everyone get to know each other, meet people you share a major with, all that jazz! What do you think, Entrapta?”

“Will they have tiny food?”

“Uh, I think so?”

“I’m in!”

“Sweet, how about you, Catra?”

After a brief moment realising Scorpia was talking to her, Catra turned back around with a shrug. A party could either be an awesome idea, or a horrible one. Hormonal young adults with almost nothing in common mixed with alcohol sounded like a recipe for disaster.

“Sure.”

“Awesome!” Scorpia beamed. “Ooh, we can get ready here together, and listen to music and have some drinks! It’ll be so much fun!”

As Scorpia rambled on about her plans for the party, Catra managed to catch Entrapta’s eye.

“I’m heading out, I’ll be back later,” she told her roommate quietly. Entrapta gave a thumbs up to her in response, still eagerly listening to Scorpia’s ideas. Sketchpad and charcoals under her arm and room key in her pocket, she slipped out of the room, and found herself wanting to smile.

Adora really had hoped that her moving onto campus would give her at least some sense of normality. But as Glimmer’s words refused to slow down, asking question after question without even pausing to take a breath, she knew that normality had chosen that exact moment to fly out the window.

“Of course you’re the sporty type, you’re Mara Grayskull’s daughter! What’s she like? Do you train together? Is she a cool mother? Can we meet-”

“Glimmer, slow down,” Bow interjected, slapping his hand over Glimmer’s mouth. After a few muffled protests, Bow removed his hand and gave Adora a smile.

“You know, you don’t have to tell us anything if you don’t want to. It’s a big thing, having a parent be in the spotlight, and we get that it can be kind of draining. So if you’d rather that we didn’t talk about her or-”

“She died.”

Adora didn’t even realise she had said it until the room fell silent. Glimmer gave a wide eyed stare, hands covering her mouth, while Bow gave a small frown, and Adora wished that she could take it all back, wished she could bury herself under her blankets, wished she could be back home with her grandmother, with her mother.

“Adora I-” Glimmer started. “I’m so sor-”

“Don’t be,” Adora cut in before Glimmer could finish that stupid word. “It’s no one’s fault. It was a blood clot that the doctor’s didn’t pick up. Got into her heart, and-”

She let out a slow sigh, giving her new roommates a sad smile. “There’s nothing anyone could have done.”

“Can I ask how long ago?” Glimmer questioned softly, and the blonde could tell that she was trying to give her a reassuring smile.

“Almost 6 months ago,” Adora murmured. “March 15th.”

“Ides of March, huh?” Bow hummed, giving Adora a small smile. Adora gave a single, near silent laugh.

“She always had a tendency to be dramatic,” she mumbled, feeling her eyes well up. Shaking her head, she opened her eyes. She couldn’t do this now, not on her first day. Bow and Glimmer gave each other a look before turning back to the blonde.

“Hey, if you need anything, just let us know,” Glimmer assured her. “If you need us to leave the room for a bit, or you need someone to talk to, we’re here.”

Adora nodded, smiling for a second. The room felt suffocating, and she knew it wasn’t their fault, but every second she spent in here, the harder it felt to breathe.

“I might go train for a bit, clear my head.”

Retrieving her phone and headphones, she exited the room before her roommates could say another word.

Catra could feel the first breath of fresh air heal her lungs. It was weird. After years of the dust filled halls of the agency and the mouldy walls of a public high school, the clean air was a change she would be happy to get used to. Plus, the campus seemed kind of cool.

Large brick buildings, some dorms and some classrooms, were framed by tall trees, the leaves a myriad of green and gold that hadn't quite fallen yet. Not many students were out and about now. Catra guessed that they had retreated into their dorms, not that she was complaining. Time alone in the sun drawing with a low chance of anyone seeing or disturbing her? Yes please.

Spotting an abandoned set of bleachers by an empty field, Catra felt her lips twitch up into a smile.

"A moment alone? I must be dreaming," she mumbled, taking in her surroundings and finding the perfect spot. A dry spot of grass under the bleachers, with enough sunlight to keep her warm and enough shade to stop her from being burnt. She could see the entire field, and could stay hidden. Clambering her way over to the spot she was about to claim, she saw brightness out of the corner of her eye. Looking at what had caught her eye, Catra felt the breath leave her lungs, and she somehow didn't find the energy to care that she was no longer alone.

A girl, on the field, clad in a red track jacket and matching shorts, blonde hair pulled back into a ponytail. From here, Catra could just make out her eyes, halfway between a bright blue and a soft gray. She was beautiful.

"Holy hell," Catra breathed, setting down her sketches and charcoal to peer through the gap in the bleachers. Looking wouldn't hurt, right? It was a big campus, what's the likelihood she's even going to see this girl again?

Unable to tear her eyes away, she watched the blonde bend down to stretch her hamstrings, appreciating the muscles flexing and relaxing as she moved. Eyes appreciating the stranger's figure, Catra's train of thought then decided to immediately crash.

The athlete shed her jacket, revealing a white muscle tank and a pair of *very* defined arms.

Man, God really is a woman.

Aware of her staring, Catra shook her head, half of her functioning brain cell controlling her arm enough to grab her charcoals and pad. She needed to practice dynamic posing anyway.

As if the stars and planets aligned, the athlete chose that moment to begin jogging around the track, a laser focus in her eyes as she willed her muscles to do her bidding. Strong legs carrying with each stride, muscles defined and figure shapely, and, *Catra you gotta keep it in your pants before you start drooling* .

Exhaling, she flicked to a fresh page, and narrowed her focus to the charcoal in her hand, flicking her gaze up every so often as

the figure came to life on the paper. Catra paid no attention to the fluttering feeling in her chest every time she looked up at the girl.

No crushes.

fever dream

Chapter Summary

> Catra was never one of those 'knight in shining armour' types, the ones that always tried to help everyone around them just because they liked playing the hero. That wasn't her style. But the girl hit the ground and didn't move, and Catra didn't think twice.

For the second day in a row, Catra had found herself under the bleachers in the afternoon sun. But oddly, it wasn't to avoid her roommates, or even because she felt the need to have time alone. Either Catra had set the bar really low, or her roommates were actually kind of cool. If a little intense.

She had never seen someone so passionate and fixated on something as Entrapta and her electronics. Almost every moment Catra was in their room, the table was buried under numerous books and tools, the faint scent of smoke escaping through the open window.

"Are you even allowed to have that in the dorm?" Catra had asked, seeing her roommate welding metal with a blow torch while clad in her pyjamas. Entrapta had only given a comically large grin and kept working.

Scorpia on the other hand, was overwhelmingly maternal. Scarily so. During their first night in the dorm, Scorpia had snuck out with a smile and returned with hot chocolate for the three of them.

"To help you sleep!"

She did something similar this morning, bringing three cups of black coffee, copious amounts of sugar packets and three cartons of different types of milk.

"I wasn't sure which kind of milk you two preferred, so I tried to cover all my bases!"

Catra couldn't remember the last time someone had done something like that for her, just because they wanted to. Surely she had an ulterior motive. Catra just hadn't figured it out yet, it was only the second day after all.

The morning was filled with orientation, students scoping out the different buildings and facilities, and introducing different majors to their teachers. It honestly wasn't horrible.

Boring enough that her brain cells suffered slightly, but not terrible enough to warrant hiding away under the bleachers and drawing to avoid her responsibilities. Yet here she was.

Her page was open on yesterday's sketch. Short strokes of charcoal refined the details of the figure, and Catra's gaze continued to flick up to the field, only to find no one there, let alone the girl she had seen yesterday. She groaned to herself, her head falling back and resting on a supporting beam. This was

stupid. It was a big campus, and this was one of many places that this mystery girl could train. Why would she come here?

Her train of thought came crashing to a halt, hearing footsteps. Looking to the sound, the artist's eyes widened when she saw it was her. Headphones in with that same red jacket and hair pulled back with a stupid poof at the front. This time, she headed towards a set of metal bars dug into the ground, which were (thankfully) still in Catra's line of sight from where she sat, seeing the athlete shed her jacket and begin to stretch once more.

Catra didn't bother fighting the slight smile.

Adora's first day on campus had been *interesting* . Luckily, she had managed to keep a somewhat low profile, not that she expected many history majors to recognise her last name. Aside from Bow, who already knew.

She'd woken up to him and Glimmer chatting on his bed, greeting her with a small smile and a breakfast wrap. Glimmer squeezed in another small apology before Adora could protest, before admitting she's been in Adora's shoes, if only a smaller level. Turns out, Glimmer's mother was the headmistress of the university and her Aunt was head of the science department.

"I know it's not entirely the same, but I know the feeling of having a last name link you to someone with a lot of influence."

Her smile was sheepish, and she seemed genuine, right down to the "Sorry!" she had whispered afterwards. It was still a little early to tell, but Adora had a gut feeling that she would end up warming up to Glimmer.

Bow had stuck by Adora's side the entire time they were meeting the other history majors. It was a little odd at first. Adora wasn't sure why Bow had taken it upon himself to stick with her, but she wasn't going to take it for granted; it was nice to not be alone. As the day progressed, she found out more about Bow, and in turn Glimmer. The pair had known each other since they were children, grew up practically attached at the hip, and went through all their schooling, and now college together. When Bow came out, Glimmer bought him his first binder. He still had it, although now he wore it on hot days if he felt self conscious about his scars.

"It must be really nice, to have a friend," Adora had mumbled to herself. Bow simply smiled.

Even after a relatively uneventful day, she had still found herself at the same abandoned field as yesterday. Everyone else seemed to use the newer, bigger ones with better bleachers, long jump pits and better running track. But Adora preferred this one. The wind whistling through the field and the faint creaking from the old bleachers were the only sounds around, and with her headphones in, she could tune out the world and focus on the feeling of her aching muscles.

The drills came without thought, unable to practise actual vaulting on campus so settling for inversion practice on a high bar. Dangling with straight arms on the bar, she went through each rep the way she had always done. Starting with a slight swing in her arms, she brought her legs up and kept her torso upright, ankles making contact with the bar before lowering, over and over again. Then, she swung her entire body up, tucking her knees to her chest and letting her ankles hit the bar, hanging upside down for a moment. Roll back down and start again. She remembered the first time she had hung upside down like this, a small part of her brain replaying her mother's laughter.

"You did it, peanut!"

The next drill should have been easy. Skin The Cats, they were called, which Adora had always thought sounded stupid. It was the same as before, only flipping through her arms, then back through and back to the start. She had done this a million times before. On her flip back around to the start, she hung upside down with her knees tucked to her chest, the sensation of stabbing in both of her shoulders, and it took a moment to realise that the short scream filling her ears was hers. Her hands lost their grip.

It wasn't the first time that Adora had fallen from a high bar, far from it. But laying flat on her back with every breath a struggle, stabbing pain in her hips and shoulders causing whimpers to leave her mouth? This was new.

A small part of her brain whispered *you're just winded, it's okay* , but it was deafened by the sound of her heart beating in her ears. The shoulder pain subsided, but her hips *ached* , enough for

Adora to squeeze her eyes shut with a yelp, manually forcing her lungs to breathe in and out slowly, waiting for the stupid pain to go away. Then a voice appeared, in the distance but growing closer and closer.

"Shit. Hey! Are you okay? Can you hear me?"

Adora took a deep breath, letting out a shuddering exhale before opening her eyes. Her heart decided hanging out in her throat was a great idea.

Two different coloured eyes stared down at her, one of molten gold and the other a bright ocean blue. Freckles were dusted across caramel skin, wild brown hair framing her face and several piercings in both ears. She was too beautiful for words. Did she seriously die and go to heaven from falling from a high bar?

"Ground control to major jock?"

Blinking, Adora gave the woman staring down at her a sheepish smile.

"Heya," she murmured. *Seriously? That's the best you got?*

The woman gave a short laugh, her lips twisting into a smirk, and holy *shit* did Adora like the sight.

“Hit your head too, blondie?”

“You saw that, huh?” she asked, planting her hands on the ground to push herself up. *Oh Gods, please tell me she didn't actually see it, please, please, please-*

“Uhh, yeah. Heard it too,” the brunette responded, offering a hand. Adora exhaled, pushing her stubbornness aside and taking it, a noise of surprise sounding as the woman hauled her upright in one swift tug. She was a few inches shorter than Adora, with the energy of someone 6 feet tall.

“Thanks,” Adora breathed, giving her a soft smile and squeezing her hand. Wait, what? They were still holding hands.

The two ripped their grips away from each other in the same second, a sudden urge of ‘what do I do with my hands?’ striking Adora as she rubbed the back of her neck with a sheepish grin.

“Are you concussed?” she asked, bicolour eyes staring intently into her own. “Your pupils have gone really big.”

“N-No! Maybe? I honestly have no idea,” Adora admitted. “I - uh- should probably get that checked out.”

The woman gave a short nod, still eyeing Adora closely. “Are you gonna be able to get there without passing out?”

“Oh, yeah! Sure!” Adora lied, teeth gnawing on the inside of her cheek. “Totally got this, but uh thank you!”

She didn’t give the stranger a chance to reply, grabbing her jacket, giving her a finger gun and heading in the direction of the nurse’s office. At least, that was the plan.

Three steps was all Adora managed. The sharpness in her hips returned, coaxing a yelp out of her. Her knees buckled and spasmed under her weight, a shooting pain erupting up her spine as she fought to keep herself upright. Oh Gods, this was painful. *It hurts, it hurts so much, why does it hurt so bad? What did I do, why does everything hurt? Please, make it stop hurting, make it stop, make it stop, make it* -

“Hey, blondie. Can you hear me?”

The voice was soft, somewhere between new and familiar. After a moment, Adora was coherent enough to recognise it; it was the stranger again. She managed to give a small nod.

“Alright. Can you tell me where it hurts?”

Adora kept herself braced on her knees, letting out a shaky exhale before even thinking about speaking.

"Hips."

"Do you think you can walk?"

The mere thought of it sent another shock up Adora's spine, shaking her head with her tongue between her teeth.

"No? Alright, I have an idea. I'm going to help you sit down, okay?"

The stranger knelt before her, offering her hands. She murmured for Adora to lean her weight on her, coaxing her to drop to her knees.

"I'm gonna put one hand on your back, alright?"

Adora gave a short nod, the stranger's warm hand pressed to the small of her back, easing her down to the ground.

"Alright, just sit here for a minute. I'm gonna find something that'll get you to the nurse's office without you walking."

What was even happening to Adora? Why was this stranger still here by her side, offering to help?

"Why are you helping me?"

The stranger was silent for a beat, then two, and Adora cursed her heavy eyelids for refusing to open.

"I'm not that much of an asshole. Just stay put, alright? I'll be right back."

Adora heard the footsteps growing fainter before she had the chance to reply, sighing quietly as she lay on the field. She hoped that the stranger would actually come back.

Catra had started running before she even realised it. She was never one of those 'knight in shining armour' types, the ones that always tried to help everyone around them just because they liked playing the hero. That wasn't her style. But the girl hit the ground and didn't move, and Catra didn't think twice. Her pad and charcoals were cast aside under the bleachers, and that whole... *encounter* just happened. And now here she was, looking back over her shoulder to check on the blonde with the stupid hair poof laying on the ground and searching for anything to help get her to

the nurse’s office. Which wasn’t going well. Was Catra going to have to carry this girl there? Oh God, that thought was both terrifying, exhilarating and really awkward all at the same time. *Let’s just find something with wheels.*

Catra didn’t believe in spiritual shit, but as her eyes gravitated to the ‘Lost and Found’ bin and found a skateboard poking out of it, the only explanation she could think of was that the universe took pity on a useless lesbian and forced all of the planets and stars to align for this one moment.

“Gotcha.”

It was clear this skateboard was abandoned, not lost. The bearings were rusted and squeaky, the cushions were on their last legs, and there was a slight crack in the wood as if someone tried to snap it. But it was still sturdy, and would carry the girl's weight. It would do.

Adora had no idea what she was expecting. Another student, a teacher or a first aid kit were all plausible things that it could have been when her body decided to quieten down enough to let her think. But a skateboard? That was one idea that Adora hadn’t thought of. But as Adora opened her eyes and propped herself on her elbows, the stranger ran towards her with a skateboard under her arm. This was going to be interesting.

“I hope you have a plan,” Adora tried cautiously, seeing a small smirk on the stranger’s lips.

“Absolutely not.” One amber eye winked at her, crouching beside the blonde and setting down the skateboard. “Well, a basic one. Sit you on this, you steer, and I’ll push you to the nurse’s office.”

Blue-gray eyes fixed on the skateboard, flicking up the stranger.

“How do I steer?”

The brunette raised one eyebrow, pinching the bridge of her nose and sighing.

“I’ll- We’ll figure it out. Do you think you can get on the skateboard without hurting yourself even more?”

Adora gave a single nod, sitting up fully and ignoring the stinging in her hips, shifting herself onto the skateboard and crossing her legs.

“Is this right?”

“Is it comfortable?”

Adora gave a single laugh, looking up at the stranger.

"Better than walking after falling off a high bar."

The brunette sighed, but Adora caught the glimpse of a smile on her lips.

"Whatever, blondie. Alright, I'm going push on your upper back to move you forward. That alright?"

Adora nodded, a beat of silence passing between them as two tentative hands rested on her shoulder blades. After a moment, she felt the skateboard under her begin moving along the ground and then on to the path, the stranger's hands keeping Adora steady as they headed towards the centre of campus.

"You won't need to steer for most of the way, but when you do, you just gotta lean all your weight to one side."

"Just tell me when," Adora mumbled.

Sure enough, the stranger did, and Adora was silently thankful when the stranger didn't force conversation aside from the occasional request to lean a certain way. This whole situation opened the door to let in the crushing of Adora's chest. It was a

simple practice, a simple drill that she had done hundreds of times before with no failure, no falling, let alone with pain. What had changed?

Even after everything that happened over the summer, Adora stuck to her training. Maybe she didn’t practice vaulting as often as she wanted to, or her pole plant drills, but she did what she could with the strength she had. What if it wasn’t enough?

And the icing on the pity party cake was the fact that someone saw her. Someone had watched her epically fail at something she had done thousands of times, then lay on the ground unable to breathe and pity her enough to help. It was past embarrassing, it was almost shameful that-

“Hey, Earth to blondie.”

Adora blinked, the stranger coming into focus as she crouched before her, with another figure dressed in teal scrubs. Brown eyes searched her up and down before looking at the stranger.

"I'll get her checked over and run some scans. But she doesn't look concussed or whatever, so that's good. I'll grab the wheelchair-"

"I can walk."

The nurse watched her with a blank face, while bicolour eyes flashed with an emotion Adora couldn't place.

"Dude, did you see how high you fell from? If you-"

"I got pushed here by you, my hips had time to rest. I'm fine," she insisted, punctuating her statement by uncrossing her legs, and slowly rising from the skateboard. The stranger sighed, grabbing the skateboard. The nurse moved around to stand by Adora, about to lead her inside but the blonde was overwhelmed with the need to say something to the beautiful stranger that helped her, to say anything.

"Hey," Adora started, getting the words out before she could think. She exhaled to calm her shaking, giving the brunette a warm, but tired, smile. "Thanks. I really do appreciate you helping me."

Only giving a nod, the brunette disappeared over her shoulder as the nurse began leading Adora into the office, asking for her details.

Catra watched the nurse lead away the athlete, her heart slowly descending. Huffing, she focused on the skateboard. It could use some TLC, and whoever left it laying around clearly didn't care about it enough to look for it-

"Alright, so I need to grab your details or whatever. Name?"

It was the nurse. Her heart leapt into her throat when she heard the blonde respond.

"Adora."

Adora. Suits her, somehow.

new emotion

Chapter Summary

"Earth to Adora! Are you gonna tell us who this mystery chick is, or are you just going to keep staring at her."

Chapter Notes

cw; chapter contains mentions of alcohol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Catra. Hey, Catra. Earth to Catra. Catraaaaa.”

Wait, what?

Catra looked up from her sketchpad, seeing Scorpia eyeing her curiously.

“What’s up?”

“We’ve kinda been calling you for the last five minutes,” she admitted, handing Catra a red cup that reeked of alcohol. “Are you alright? You seemed pretty deep in thought.”

“Uh, yeah. I’m fine,” Catra murmured, bringing the cup to her lips and downing half.

“Are you sure? You were staring at the same page the entire time,” Entrapta interjected, eyes never leaving her notes, taking an elaborate straw between her teeth and drinking.

“Well, if I wasn’t looking at the drawing I was doing, it wouldn’t exactly turn out well.”

“Your pencil wasn’t moving.”

Scorpia, eyes flicking between the pair like a tennis spectator, then turned to face a wide eyed Catra.

“Shouldn’t you be looking at whatever you’re setting on fire instead of me drawing?” Catra grumbled, taking another swig of her drink.

“I am! See? Eyes right here on Emily!”

Catra squinted, looking up at her other roommate. “‘Emily’?”

“The project Entrapta’s started working on!” Scorpia chirped, voice filled to the brim with something akin to pride. “How cool, right?”

All Catra saw was a heap of metal taking up the entirety of their table, and a scary amount of determination behind Entrapta's eyes.

"Yeah. Cool," Catra mumbled. "Will you be okay leaving Emily for the party tonight?"

"Emily is not sentient yet, she won't miss me."

Scorpia and Catra found each other's gazes, a single word passing between them.

"'Yet'?"

A loud slurping came from the table, Scorpia the first to break the silence.

"Either way, there's only half an hour left before the party starts, so we really should start getting ready."

Catra looked down, checking her jeans were clean and sniffing her shirt, pleasantly surprised when she couldn't smell tobacco.

Ready to go , she thought, turning back to her drawing. She didn't even realise she was smiling at the figure on the page until she

heard Scorpia’s voice.

“Can I see?”

Somewhere between reflex and instinct, Catra clutched the pad to her chest, seeing Scorpia a few steps away, with palms facing her, showing her vulnerability. Something that Catra wasn't used to but knew was something Scorpia tended to do a lot. Catra swallowed, searching her mind for any kind of explanation.

“I- uh, don’t like people seeing them.”

Scorpia furrowed her eyebrows slightly, nodding to herself before breaking out in a smile.

“That’s okay! I figured I’d ask, but if you don’t want to show them, that is 100% alright.”

Catra stared at her roommate. Black eyes were filled with warmth, and her frame was open. Honest. Either this girl was a crazy good actor, or she wasn’t telling the truth.

“Now, do I wear lipgloss or lipstick tonight?” she mumbled to herself, prosthetic hands digging through a small bag on her bed, the previous conversation cast to the wind. “Or would it be too

much? Do I just wear lip balm? Is that enough? What do people even wear to a college party?”

“Lipstick with lip balm over the top,” Catra interjected, eyes not leaving the page. “Shine of lip gloss without the stickiness. Plus it tastes better.”

“Sounds like you know from experience,” Scorpia chuckled. “Never pegged you for the makeup type.”

“Never said I was the one wearing it. Not initially at least.”

A beat of silence passed, before Entrapta snapped up from her project.

“SCORPIA, YOU BAGGED YOURSELF A WINGWOMAN!”

The laughter from room 26 could be heard from down the hall.

“Bow, I need help.”

“We all do, Glimmer.”

Adora almost choked on her drink, stifling a giggle once she had swallowed.

“I meant with my eyeliner,” Glimmer whined, hitting his hip with her own. “Geez, two drinks in and you’re already sassy.”

“So he isn’t like this all the time?” Adora asked, watching Bow dig through Glimmer’s makeup bag, pulling out what he needed.

“Only around people I’m comfortable with,” Bow hummed, uncapping the lid and leaning in close to Glimmer. “You know the drill?”

“Don’t sneeze without a warning, don’t flinch, and don’t whine,” she rattled off, eyes already closed.

Adora took another sip, watching Bow apply wings to Glimmer’s eyes with a steady hand, two perfect lines framing the eyeshadow. The room was silent for those few moments, oddly peaceful despite the predicted chaos they were about to enter.

“All done,” Bow announced, moving to stow away the eyeliner before stopping and turning to Adora. “Do you want some?”

“Makeup?”

“You don’t have to!” Glimmer assured her. “Bow just likes having new people to practice his skills on.”

Adora paused in thought, finding herself looking at her reflection on her phone screen. It would do.

"Uh, I'm good. Thank you though."

Bow nodded, stowing it away without another word and grabbing his phone, giving Adora enough time to down the rest of her drink before Glimmer spoke up.

"Okay! Let's go, I refuse to be late to our first party!"

"Wait! Keys," Bow spoke up, nodding when Adora flashed him her room key. He stared down Glimmer until she sighed, rummaging through her purse and pulling it out.

"Now, remember,” He started. "If you're not with a roommate, message in the group chat every hour."

“Bow, it’s a college party, what do you think is going to happen?” Glimmer sighed, tucking the key back into her purse.

“I have no idea! But we need to be prepared!”

“Uh, isn’t bickering about this just going to make us more late?” Adora piped up, already creaking the door open. A beat of silence was followed by the three students scrambling through the door, and down the hall.

Man, I am not drunk enough for this.

Watching the bright lights dance across the emptied out common room, and seeing students drinking and dancing, was frankly underwhelming. The music was a mindless combination of pounding bass and high shrills, the students’ laughter was obnoxious and annoying, and the bourbon didn’t even taste good. At least her roommates were having fun.

Entrapta, surprisingly, was insanely good at beer pong. She had no idea how, and Catra stifled a chuckle, watching her roommate carry herself and Scorpia to victory. Scorpia, unsurprisingly, was excellent moral support. Prosthetic arms were surprisingly less of an issue when hugs were involved. The artist could feel the squeeze just from watching.

Catra downed what was left of her drink, tapping her fingers against the cup in thought. *Do I get another drink or ditch this dumb party?* The football boys were starting to get far too rowdy for her liking, chatting up girls with no interest in them, but thankfully none of them had been dumb enough to make a move on her. Scorpia had made it clear she would stay with Entrapta, so Catra knew they'd be safe if she left. Then again, when was the last time she'd gotten messed up? Someone else was buying the alcohol, and the thought of drinking spoilt rich kids dry made her smirk. Was that worth it?

Soft laughter made her train of thought crash to a halt, eyes swivelling around to find the sound. Of course, it was her.

She'd swapped her trackpants for grey skinny jeans, a white v neck underneath that same red jacket. Her hair was pulled up into that same ponytail with the dumb poof at the front, one hand clasping a red plastic cup, while the other fiddled with a pendant around her neck. She was with a shorter, stockier girl with pastel pink hair, and a taller boy with dark skin in a white and yellow crop top, the pair huddled around the blonde with wide grins. They were talking to her, that much was obvious. But Catra couldn't hear what they were saying over all the noise, or over the heartbeat in her ears now she'd been caught staring.

The blonde matched her gaze, eyes not leaving as she sipped from a red cup.

Staying it is.

"Who even is that?"

Adora barely registered Glimmer's question until her elbow prodded her side.

"Earth to Adora! Are you gonna tell us who this mystery chick is, or are you just going to keep staring at her."

"Was I staring?" the blonde mumbled to herself, sipping her drink and collecting her thoughts. "Okay. So, remember how I said I ended up at the nurse's office today?"

"Yes, and I'm still slightly mad about it," Bow answered, coaxing a wince from Adora.

"Right. So anyway, I didn't think there was anyone else at the field when I was. But when I fell, she came running over, made sure I was okay, and wheeled me to the nurse's office on a skateboard so I didn't have to walk. Then, she just kinda disappeared."

"Of course you're into the mysterious type," Glimmer groaned, sipping her drink with a sly grin. Purely to stop her laughing at how red Adora suddenly was.

"I never even said I was into her!"

"Adora," Bow mused, slinging an arm around her shoulder and pulling her into a side hug. "Ever heard the phrase actions speak louder than words?"

"Yeah?"

"Well, you staring is practically screaming-"

"Shuddup!" The blonde elbowed her roommate in his stomach, rolling her eyes as he cackled. "It's not like that. I just didn't get to thank her properly, that's all."

"Well, what's stopping you now?" Glimmer hummed.

Adora hated to admit it, but she was right. At least, in a physical sense, there wasn't anything stopping her.

"Now, Bow and I are gonna go dance, and you're gonna go talk to her."

"Glimmer, wait-"

She had taken Bow's wrist and dragged him away before Adora could finish her protest.

Okay, this was totally fine. It's just saying 'thank you' to a stranger that saw you epically fail, then single handedly got you to the nurse's office because you could barely walk, who then disappeared without a trace. Totally normal situation.

"Goddamnit, Glimmer," she grumbled, downing the rest of her drink. Emboldened, Adora took the first step towards the stranger, and the rest followed suit.

She was wearing the same clothes from earlier, a maroon shirt tucked into ripped black jeans. Blue and gold eyes watched Adora approach, one hand holding a red cup, her free one fiddling with a braided leather bracelet. The stranger smirked.

"Blondie's up and walking," she purred, eyes flicking over Adora's form.

"Crazy, right?" Adora chuckled, sheepishly rubbing the back of her neck and trying to find her words over the racing of her heart.

"I-uh, I never got to thank you properly for today."

The smirk faded, the stranger giving a small nod.

"It's cool. Wasn't gonna leave you there."

The blonde gave a small smile, offering her hand.

"I'm Adora."

Her spare hand stopped fiddling with her bracelet, the brunette taking her hand and giving it a firm shake.

"Catra."

"Suits you," Adora mumbled, releasing her hand and giving a smile. "Do you, uh, need a drink or anything?"

Catra tipped her cup upside down. Adora almost found it funny that nothing was inside once her heart stopped racing.

"Pffftt, you should have seen your face! As if I'd do that on the second day. I'd at least wait until classes started."

Catra started weaving her way through the crowd towards the kitchen. After a moment, she turned back to look at Adora, face decorated with a small smirk and a raised eyebrow.

"You coming?"

Adora didn't think twice.

"Remember when your dads taught us how to dance as kids?"

"I remember you having two left feet."

Glimmer gave a scoff as Bow spun her back into him, both of them knowing there was no malice in their words.

"This is why you were always better at leading," she grumbled. The two could read each other like an open body, knowing what every glance, gesture and breath meant. That increased tenfold as they danced. As Bow raised his arm, Glimmer spun through with practised motion, and Bow never missed a beat pulling her back into him as they started all over again. It was nothing fancy, but it was theirs. They just hadn't done it in a crowded room before.

As Glimmer spun, Bow saw the impending disaster of spilled punch and an angry diva before it happened. Glimmer had no idea she was about to bump someone. Bow's hands haphazardly

gripped Glimmer's waist before she spun too far, pulling her into his chest and wincing at the "oof!" from Glimmer as she collided against him.

"You okay?" Bow asked, craning down his neck to look at her.

"I'm fine, what even was that?"

"I kinda sorta almost spun you into a girl holding an overfilled cup of punch," he admitted. "So it was either stop you from bumping into them, or watch you or a stuck up stranger wear said punch and start an argument."

Glimmer's face displayed confusion, realisation, annoyance and acceptance all at once.

"Stupid crowds," she grumbled. "Next time we go dancing, can it be somewhere with a bit more space?"

Bow felt a smile crack, nodding at her.

"Deal."

Mirroring the smile, Glimmer looked up at her best friend before it fell. Had his eyes always looked like that? Her shoulders felt

strong under her palms, when did he stop being the gangly string bean from down the road? His hands were warm against the small of her back keeping her firmly pressed to his defined chest, and Glimmer found herself leaning in.

"Glimmer?"

Glimmer blinked, when did their faces get so close? Bow's exhales could be felt on her lips, the warm breath washing over Glimmer's face.

Kiss him , a voice called inside her mind. Wait.

Bow was her best friend. Through thick and thin, every high and low, he was there. She shouldn't be thinking about him like that.

"I need to go to the bathroom."

Glimmer didn't wait to hear a response before she bolted away.

Chapter End Notes

got myself a gf y'all. enjoy this chapter!

jesus christ 2005 god bless america

Chapter Summary

> For the occupants of Room 11, 3 weeks had passed in the blink of an eye, both a blessing and a curse.
> In Room 26, the sounds of whirring and drilling were missing, replaced by quiet murmurs of things the students would never air outside their room.

Chapter Notes

> Massive thank you to @scarletpiano13 for being my amazing beta!

3 weeks had passed since the party. Etheria University had fallen into a lull of activity, as classes consumed the life of its students. For the occupants of Room 11, 3 weeks had passed in the blink of an eye, both a blessing and a curse.

Glimmer took it as a blessing. She dove into the social scene of the university, signing herself up for the debate team and introducing herself with her head held high. Glimmer, not the headmistress' daughter, not a Brightmoon. Just Glimmer. The side eyes and whispered comments came anyway. A master at tuning them out, Glimmer continued as if all was normal, and only let the comments eat her up in the safety of her dorm room.

"Sorry if this is a bit ignorant of me, but why is being a Brightmoon a bad thing?" Adora asked. The three had piled the empty centre of the room with pillows and blankets, laptop and popcorn long discarded as they stared up at the ceiling.

"It's not a bad thing, I just-" Glimmer sighed, closing her eyes. "I don't want that to be all I am. I'm not ashamed of my family at all, far from it! But when every success I have is rumoured to be something I paid for? Or cheated for? It gets to you. I've gotten myself to where I am, not my mother or my aunt or my father. Me. Does that make sense?"

"You know it does, Glimmer."

Bow gave her a small smile after his response, before promptly looking back at the ceiling.

Bow took the racing pace of the term as neither a blessing or a curse. The books piled at the edge of his bed for assigned reading he really needed to do never left his head, but he didn't mind. His Etheria University hoodie (cropped of course) was really growing on him.

"I get what you mean though, feeling like you're born into something you need to follow," he started. "Like, I love my dads and my family more than anything. But, they were so excited when I told them I was gonna study history like they did, I wonder if they would have been that excited if it was something else."

"What else would you have studied?" Adora asked. Bow paused, shrugging after a moment of silence.

"I'm not sure. I got really into archery when I was younger, but they don't really give out scholarships for it," Bow mused. "I hit high school, and after my top surgery, I couldn't practice for a while. Then, the end of high school was a lot more intense than I thought so I just kinda stopped."

"I think there's an archery club somewhere nearby," Glimmer mentioned. "We could all go after midterms, you can show us the ropes, and maybe get back into it?"

A smile crept onto his lips, slightly nodding. "That'd be fun."

"You're gonna need to teach me a lot," Adora chuckled. "Me and a bow and arrow sounds like a disaster waiting to happen."

For Adora, the breakneck pace of term was a curse. Her mind drowned underneath the same readings as Bow, and the training routine that always brought peace was now tainted with the harsh bite of pain. Every flip on the bar, every drill, caused the stabbing pain to re-emerge. But she didn't fall this time. Not when she knew that Catra was watching. At the party, conversation flowed easily, and Catra began sitting on the bleachers with a notebook and pencil while Adora trained. They exchanged silent smiles every time their eyes met. Catra always joked that she hung out there to make sure Adora didn't hurt herself again. But every injury she felt was pushed aside, not until she was off the high bar and alone. She wouldn't show it to anyone. And certainly not with the looming thought of *what would my mother think?*

"Whatever you say, miss sports prodigy," Glimmer piped up. "It's literally in your blood."

Bow snorted, meeting Glimmer's hand in a high five effortlessly.

"Again, Mara isn't my biological mother," Adora reminded the duo. "She adopted me when I was 3, and you two know the rest."

"You could have fooled me! I wouldn't think you were adopted, you and Mara actually kind of look alike."

"Glimmer's right, you know," Bow hummed. "Is it okay if we see the photo of you two again? So we can show you what we mean?"

The room went quiet, save for the rustling of Adora's jacket, pulling the photo out of the pocket and holding it out for all three to see.

The same polaroid from her mother's birthday, with matching cake icing smears and wide smiles.

"I can see it," Bow mused quietly. "Your smiles are the same. Plus your noses are similar, except for the bump in your mother's."

“She broke it when I was a kid,” Adora started, falling into a chuckle. “Apparently, she’s not great at breaking pinatas.”

Glimmer gave a slight snort, eyes still fixed on the photo.

“Adora, do you ever take that jacket off?"

Room 11 then dissolved into fits of laughter.

In Room 26, the sounds of whirring and drilling were missing, replaced by quiet murmurs of things the students would never air outside their room.

"What was it like growing up at Weaver's?" Scorpia had asked. An innocent question, but Catra simply scoffed.

"Shit," she told her roommate, idly fiddling with her pencil. "Perfect for suppressing any kind of individuality or potential from a kid, teaching them to conform and force feeding them religion. Only bad things come out of Weaver's."

Scorpia frowned, soft eyes fixed on Catra.

"Well, you turned out a lot better than bad. So, that's at least one good thing to come out of there."

"What about that Adora person? Wasn't she also from Weaver's?"

Both girls turned to look at Entrapta, clutching a pillow to her chest and watching them with wide, innocent eyes.

"How did you know that?"

"I heard you two talking at the party. She wasn't exactly quiet."

Catra snickered under her breath, vaguely hearing Scorpia mutter something about how Entrapta really shouldn't eavesdrop on people.

"Well, Entrapta did hear right," Catra admitted quietly.

"Did you know her?" Scorpia asked.

"Nope. Apparently, she was dropped there as a baby and got adopted when she was really young. I ended up there just before

she left, and I was way too young to remember anything about her, even if our paths did cross."

"It is certainly interesting how your paths have crossed again now," Entrapta mumbled to herself. "Almost like it was meant to happen! Maybe it was a part in a series of fixed events in the time space continuum!"

Catra snickered once more, slightly smiling at the scientist.

"Not that we don't like hearing all your science talk," Scorpia started. "But have you tried finding someone else on campus that can actually understand it all? Y'know, talk with them about it, maybe even make a friend!"

Entrapta's eyes were no longer as wide, fixed on the pillow she fiddled with.

"I don't know if I can do that."

"Why not?"

Entrapta clutched the pillow tighter, taking a deep breath and exhaling.

"I spent my whole life in boarding schools. When they noticed I was different to the other kids, teachers kept a closer eye on me, and the kids kept their distance. They didn't find out I had autism until I was a teenager."

Scorpia and Catra wirelessly looked at one another, before turning their gaze back to Entrapta.

"And my brain is something I'm super proud of, even with all its ticks and hyperfixations! But some people don't think so."

The room fell silent, and Scorpia watched as Entrapta squeezed the pillow and watched them with wide eyes. Catra smashed the silence.

"Honestly? People are weird. So your brain works a bit differently and your reactions aren't the same as other people? Big deal. Anyone that calls you weird can go suck a giant d-"

"What Catra is trying to say is," Scorpia butt in. "If anyone thinks that you being autistic is a bad thing, isn't worthy of being your friend. Besides, we're already your friends! Right, Catra?"

The scientist turned to face the artist with pleading eyes, and Catra couldn't find it in her heart to lie to her roommate.

"Right."

Entrapta's grin shone brighter than the sun, squealing with unbridled joy as she flapped her hands excitedly.

"I have friends! You're my friends!"

Abandoning the pillow and all remaining restraint, Entrapta bolted to Scorpia's side of the room, before stopping in her tracks.

"Wait, am I allowed to hug you?"

Her response was wrapping strong, metallic arms around Entrapta and pulling her flush to Scorpia's chest.

"Yes, you are allowed to hug me," she chuckled before extending an arm to Catra.

"C'mon, this is a group hug. You need to get in too, if you're comfortable."

Catra looked at the scene in front of her, placing her pencil down on the closest table and rising from the bed.

"Alright, alright, but just this once," she grumbled under her breath, taking a few steps forward before Scorpia gently took her arm and yanked Catra closer.

"Sheesh, Scorpi, what was that-"

Catra fell silent as her two roommates embraced her, feeling two sets of bodies close enough to hold her, but still leaving room for Catra to wiggle out. They were giving her an option. Something that had been few and far between in Catra's life. The artist felt her eyes sting.

"Catra? Are you alright?" Scorpia asked in a whisper. Catra wound one arm around each of her roommates, and allowed herself to pull them just a touch closer.

"Yeah. I think I will be."

"And then there were two."

Bow and Glimmer stayed in their makeshift nest, a space where Adora had wiggled out with a mumble about training.

"Do you think she's gone to see that Catra chick?" Glimmer asked, looking to Bow with a playful smirk. He thought for a moment, facing her with furrowed brows.

"I don't think so. She seemed too focused for that, like she was gonna try fight a dragon or something."

"Doesn't she always have that face?"

"Only when she's stressed out of her mind."

Glimmer snickered, pulling her eyebrows together and pouting in an animated impression of their missing roommate. Bow gave a mock serious stare, before nudging her ribs with his elbow and coaxing a small laugh from her.

"You literally have not changed since we were kids, I swear," Bow mumbled, a smile creeping up his lips.

Glimmer's memory flashed back to bright lights and loud music, to warm hands pressed to her back and a pounding in her chest.

"Some things have changed."

The room fell into silence, the pair wirelessly shuffling closer.

"Glimmer?" came the soft whisper, and Glimmer's heart leapt into her throat.

"Yeah?"

Bow paused, closing his eyes and sighing.

"Are we gonna talk about what happened at the party?"

Glimmer's breath hitched in her throat, searching desperately for the words. She couldn't tell him what went through her mind, not if she wanted things to stay the same. What would he even think? Should she have even though about him like that?

"What do you mean?"

Bow was quiet for a moment, turning on his side and propping himself up on his elbow to face Glimmer.

"There was that moment, near the start of the party. We were dancing and then you just- you just froze. Then you just ran off to the bathroom, and didn't come back for like 10 minutes. And when you did, you didn't say anything about why you ran off."

Oh.

"I just got overwhelmed, needed somewhere quiet," she mumbled, a beat of silence passing between them before she felt Bow's arm snake around her stomach.

"Why didn't you just say something silly?" he chuckled. "You really had me worried there."

"I'm sorry," Glimmer breathed, letting Bow hold her and settling into the familiar embrace. "I didn't mean to worry, I just needed to be somewhere quiet for a bit, get my thoughts together."

Bow smiled softly, a hand reaching up to fluff her pastel hair.

"You don't need to be sorry. But you know that you can tell me everything, right?"

Not this. I can't tell you this now, maybe even ever.

"I know," Glimmer lied.

pleaser

Chapter Summary

> "Okay, Scorpia, just try to relax," she muttered under her breath. She took a long inhale, exhaling slowly. "You're gonna be fine. I am smart, I am capable, and I give great hugs."
> ---
> Catra narrowed her eyes at the blonde walking towards her. She was limping.
> ---
> Entrapta stood outside an empty lab, really hoping that the student teacher hadn't decided to pick today to be cruel.

Classes, that was kind of the whole point of University, right? With midterms quickly approaching, Scorpia found her heart beating out of her chest. Did she know anything? Was she even going to pass these exams? What would her mothers think if she didn't? They were nothing but supportive in every aspect of her life, but Scorpia knew how much the family business meant to them, and as an only child she was the only option to take over once her mothers retired. But how much time did Scorpia have? This degree was going to take a few years at least, would failing a subject even be an option?

"Okay, Scorpia, just try to relax," she muttered under her breath. She took a long inhale, exhaling slowly. "You're gonna be fine. I am smart, I am capable, and I give great hugs."
Repeat, repeat, repeat, her mind fixed on her mantra, eyes fixed on her feet as they carried her step by step towards the classroom. It was the first term of her first year. It was still very early days, and Scorpia's high school GPA assured her that these classes were going to be something she could pass, and easily. But the gnawing in her chest didn't subside.

“I am smart, I am capable, and I give great hugs. I am smart, I am capable, and I give great hugs. I am smart, I am-”

Thwack!

Scorpia’s train of thought went up in flames, a plethora of books scattered at her feet, with a lithe figure scrambling to pick them up.

“Oh gosh, I am so sorry! Are you okay?” Scorpia immediately dropped to her knees, metal hands reaching for the books. “I was just thinking a lot and I wasn’t looking where I was going, and- oh gosh, I’m such a klutz, I hope none of these books are damaged-”

“No, no, you’re fine! I shouldn’t have tried to carry so many.”

The voice sounded like the soft winds in spring, and Scorpia finally looked up. The lithe figure was covered with tan, freckled skin, light blonde hair falling over her shoulders as brown eyes stared at the books, before flicking up to Scorpia.

Scorpia’s words went out the window.

“Hi,” the girl hummed with a smile, clutching a book to her chest.

“H-Hi!” Scorpia responded, scrambling to retrieve the scattered books. “I’m sorry about all this again.”

“Tsk, no need to apologise! Accidents happen, and no one got hurt.”

“Are you sure you’re not hurt?” Scorpia asked. “It looked like you took quite the tumble. Here, let me help.” Tucking the collected books under one arm, she offered her free arm. The small blonde eyed Scorpia’s hand, smiling softly and taking it. Scorpia underestimated how light this woman was.

“Eeeek!”

The blonde was only a book’s width away from colliding into Scorpia’s chest, almost tucked under Scorpia’s chin.

“Sorry,” Scorpia mumbled, feeling her cheeks warm. “Don’t know my strength some days.”

“Oh, no you’re fine,” the lady breathed, deep brown eyes framed by pink dusting across her cheeks. “I’m Perfuma.”

“Perfuma.” Scorpia let the name fall off her tongue, before shaking her head. “I mean, I’m not Perfuma, that’s you, I’m Scorpia and gosh, you’re pretty. I mean, your name is pretty! Not that you’re not pretty, you are, I just- oh jeez I need to stop talking-”

Perfuma’s soft laughter sounded like wind chimes in the breeze, and Scorpia’s stomach did backflips at the sound.

“It’s lovely to meet you, Scorpia,” she hummed, giving her a warm smile that made Scorpia’s knees jelly.

“So- uh, do you need a hand carrying these books anywhere?” Scorpia started, rubbing the nape of her neck with a sheepish smile. “You know, so you don’t accidentally get bumped into? Not that I’m saying it’s your fault! I just want to make sure that you don’t get hurt, or drop them all again. How can you even carry all of those? There’s so many and- ”

“If you’re willing to help me carry them, I would really appreciate it,” Perfuma gently interjected. “I need to take these back to the library and then head to Statistics class.”

Scorpia paused for a moment, eyes raised in realisation. “The one on the second floor? I’m in there too!”

Perfuma’s smile turned Scorpia to butter. “What a lucky stroke of fate.” Two pairs of hands retrieved the remaining books, cradled underneath arms as the two fell into step together towards the library.

Catra basked in the afternoon sunlight, sprawled out against the bleachers and balancing a pencil on her nose, sent tumbling by a heavy exhale. Where was she? She was never this late.

Since the party, Catra had formed a strange *bond* with the blonde klutz known as Adora. She could come to train at this field every afternoon, whether on the high bar, free weights or laps, the blonde had never missed a day of training. This field was always empty, save for the two girls. Catra would spend the afternoon on the bleachers, sketching dynamic poses and watching Adora closely. *"Someone's gotta make sure you don't break something,"* Catra had told her once. But as the sky was painted with shades of orange while the sun began to hide behind the horizon, there was still no sign of Adora.

"Alright, something's up," the artist huffed under her breath, hauling herself up and digging out her phone from her flannel pocket. She tapped into contacts, finding the first thread of messages.

[Text to: Blondie🤸‍♀️ die 🤸‍♀️

dude are you alive?

Adora's typing bar appeared almost immediately, a red clad figure appearing in the corner of Catra's vision.

[Text from: Blondie 🏃‍♀️ ♀️]

yeah I’m here now!!! ^^;

Eyes rolling at the blonde’s almost constant use of emojis, Catra stowed her phone back into her pocket, standing with a faint smile as Adora approached the bleachers, but it was slower than normal. Catra narrowed her eyes at the blonde walking towards her. She was limping.

“Sorry to keep you waiting!” Adora called, placing her gym bag on the first step, grinning up at Catra. She didn’t know Adora super well, but Catra knew her well enough to know at least some of her mannerisms. The way she drew her eyebrows together and stuck out her bottom lip when she was deep in thought, the two fingered salute she gave friends when she said goodbye for the day, the slow inhales of when something wasn’t right. The same ones happening now.

“Why were you limping?” Catra asked, jumping the small talk and diving straight in. “You don’t normally limp that bad, even after your leg days.”

Adora stared blankly for a small eternity, before shaking her head and giving Catra another wide smile.

“Limping? I don’t know what you’re talking about,” she started. “I mean, my quads are a little sore, so maybe that was it? I didn’t fall or bump anything so-”

“Adora,” Catra interjected, pinching the bridge of her nose with a sigh as Adora fell silent. “Why were you late? Like, I don’t care, but that’s not like you at all.”

Adora simply shrugged, sitting next to her gym bag and shedding her jacket. “Is it a crime to be late every now and again?”

She was deflecting. Catra could recognise that tactic in pitch darkness. She descended the few steps separating them, sitting on the other side of Adora’s bag and watching the blonde closely.

“It’s not I just- It’s out of character for you, I just wanted to make sure nothing bad happened.”

“Awwww, you’ve gone soft!” Adora cooed with a smirk. “You really do like me!”

“This is not because I like you,” Catra lied.

Adora snickered to herself, her smile falling a touch as she retrieved something from her bag.

“Nothing happened, I promise. I just needed to swing by the nurse’s office real quick.”

Catra narrowed her eyes at what Adora was holding. An ice pack, wrapped in a small towel.

"Adora, what did you do?" Bicolour eyes frantically scanned Adora's frame, searching for a bruise, a cut, a scrape, anything. But she found nothing. How was that possible?

"I didn't do anything, it was just my hips again," Adora admitted.

In the weeks following the fall, there were days when bending over caused the stabbing to reappear in Adora's hips. Over those weeks, Catra and Adora grew closer, and the artist watched Adora begin to struggle through stretches that used to never cause the athlete any trouble. The limits Adora had set herself were slowly falling out of reach. On top of all that, this was the third time this week that Adora had found herself seeking help from the nurse's office, and those were only the times that she had told Catra about.

"Don't you think that this is all starting to get a little out of hand?" she started, watching Adora discard the ice pack to the side and pull out her headphones.

"What do you mean?"

"Dude, this has been happening for how long now? Unless it's a break, or a fracture, or something, that pain should not be lasting this long."

“Catra, I already told you,” Adora started, hands braced on her knees to help her stand. “I went and got an X-ray the day after I fell once the swelling went down. There’s no breaks, no fractures, nothing. I promise you, I’m okay.”

Catra hoped that Adora would never lie to her about something like this, and knew the blonde well enough to know that she was a terrible liar. But her words didn’t give the artist any reassurance.

“Adora, is it even safe for you to practice-”

“Why do you even care so much about this anyway, Catra?”

Catra’s breath left her lungs, seeing a storm beginning to swirl behind Adora’s eyes, the sharpness of lightning striking through her next words.

“Why do you even care about me?”

“Why are you so against people actually caring about you?!”

The admission tied in an accusation fell into the silent air. Adora blinked once, twice, watching Catra curiously. The anger in her eyes was gone.

Catra exhaled with a huff, clutching her trembling hands into two fists and casting her eyes down to the ground.

"Look I-" she sighed, trying to find the words. "The only things I know about your mother is the stuff you've told me. And I get it, she's a big inspiration for you. Even with her excessive amount of events."

"It was only 7." The faintest of smiles crooked Adora's lips. "She was a heptathlete, that's kinda her thing." Catra rolled her eyes but found herself chuckling.

"Adora, I think even one sport is excessive, let alone 7," she stated. "Point being, I know that you're got these really high expectations for yourself. But even your mum needed to rest."

Catra watched the sharp inhale Adora took, stormy eyes beginning to well. Her heart began to race, retracing her steps and what word she said was the one that pushed Adora too far.

"Thank you, Catra," she breathed finally, the ghost of a smile still on her lips, but it was enough to calm Catra's pulse. She mirrored it, giving a small nod.

"I'll have the ice pack if you need it later."

Adora’s smile grew, and so did the feeling of spiders in Catra’s stomach.

“Maybe I should have asked Scorpia to come with me.”

Entrapta stood outside an empty lab, really hoping that the student teacher hadn’t decided to pick today to be cruel. Yes, Etheria University’s Robotics Club had been swept under the metaphorical rug for several years now, but surely that didn’t mean they had gotten rid of all the equipment, right? But the door had been unlocked, and there was a used teabag sitting by the sink. Someone had to have been in here recently. Unless this was all some elaborate prank set up by someone.

“Hello there.”

A squawk left Entrapta’s mouth, the aspiring scientist’s first reaction to point a blowtorch at the intruder.

It was a man, dressed in a white polo and dark grey slacks. Platinum blonde hair and almost unnaturally pale skin was contrasted with bright green eyes, blinking curiously at Entrapta.

“Uhh, hi?”

“Hello there. Are you lost?”

Entrapta shook her head.

“This is the robotics room, right?”

The man blinked once, eyes scanning around the room before looking back to the scientist.

“I suppose it is, yes.”

“Ooh! Do you like robots too?”

“I am afraid I have not interacted with a robot.”

Entrapta was silent for a moment, casting the man a sheepish grin.

“Would you like to?”

The man gave a blink, tilting his head ever so slightly.

"What would 'interacting with a robot' entail?"

Entrapta's grin remained, but it was no longer sheepish.

"Well, I'm still working on the robot. Buuuut if you want, you can help me? We can make cool things, and drink tea?"

The man nodded, a smile ghosted on his lips.

"That sounds acceptable. I will partake in constructing the robot with you."

The scientist's eyes grew wide, squealing under their breath as their hands flapped at their sides.

"Aaaah this is amazing! Wait, what's your name?"

"I am usually referred to as 'little brother'."

Entrapta squinted at the man until he finally finished his statement.

"You can call me Hugo."

Entrapta smiled widely at Hugo, holding out her empty hand to him.

"I'm Entrapta."

Hugo looked at her hand blankly for a moment, before holding it and shaking it.

"It is a pleasure to meet you, Entrapta. May I ask why you have a blowtorch?"

For the first time in years, the robotics lab of Etheria University was awake with the sounds of various equipment, and echoing laughter.

peach pit

Chapter Summary

Glimmer paid no mind to the look Bow gave her, immediately answering the question from over the phone.

"Hi there, I was wondering if my roommate is there at the moment? She hasn't been answering her calls, and we're starting to worry."

“Wait, hold on, I’ve got it!”

“What? Do you think you can end the reign of terror from 8am classes?” Mermista asked, chugging the rest of her coffee.

“Sadly, no. But I think I have an idea to help everyone we know feel a little better; we throw a party!”

Chapter Notes

thank you for tuning in! no trigger warnings this chapter. however, just a heads up that posting may not be as often as the previous chapters for the next month or two. I'm only a few weeks away from a bachelor's degree so it's really time for me to buckle down, but I'll do my best to update when I can.

enjoy the chapter!

“So, how exactly did you two meet again?”

Room 26 was not filled with its usual bunch of misfits. Instead, two aspiring scientists of a different kind were inside, one of which Scorpia already knew. Perfuma. Fiddling with the hem of

her pink sundress, she looked up from her textbook from where she sat on the floor and flashed a smile.

“Biology,” she hummed in a light voice, looking at her companion whose face was buried in her own textbook.

As Scorpia idly flicked through her own textbook, she couldn’t help but notice the differences between Perfuma, and their new acquaintance, Mermista. While Perfuma’s frame was tall and lithe, Mermista was shorter and stockier, soft thighs and stomach covered in teal scrubs. Perfuma radiated a softness that Scorpia still wasn't accustomed to, and while Mermista wasn't rude, her blunt nature was certainly very jarring compared to the blonde.

“I still don’t get why the professor paired the two of us up for this project,” Mermista grumbled. “Like, an environmental science major and a marine biology major don’t exactly have a heap in common.”

“Maybe that’s why we got paired together,” Perfuma hummed, her textbook on her lap as she sat with near perfect posture. “We can use our differences to our advantage, and learn something from one another.”

Mermista raised her head from the floor to look at the lithe blonde, raising a single eyebrow.

“Right. Let’s go with that,” she murmured, promptly laying her head back on her textbook.

“I mean, being different isn’t always a bad thing,” Scorpia chirped. “Like, Catra ended up making friends with someone that’s almost a polar opposite of her.”

“Catra?” Mermista asked. “Wait, really wild hair, heaps of piercings, literally never been seen without a flannel?”

“Yeah, do you know her?”

“She’s in my English class. Sits at the back and draws the whole time. That, and she pushed one of my patients up to the nurse’s office on a dingy old skateboard once. She’s like, basically a regular.”

“Catra’s a regular at the nurse’s office?”

“Not Catra,” Mermista corrected. “The one she brought on the skateboard, some blonde jock called Adora.”

“That’s the girl Catra was telling me about,” Scorpia realised.

“Why does Adora keep coming into the nurse’s office?” Perfuma asked, closing her textbook to look at her study companion. "From

what I've seen of her around campus, she always seems so high energy. She looks perfectly healthy."

“Because she’s, like, almost always in pain,” Mermista started. “She tells me she’s seeing a doctor about it, but I’m not sure what they’re doing with her. Not that I care but, y’know. Need to have some kind of idea of what’s happening so I don't mess up treatment here.”

“Maybe her pain is seeping from emotional into the physical,” the blonde suggested. “I have several essential oils that may be able to help-”

“No offence, Perfuma, but I don’t think essential oils can fix whatever is happening to this woman’s body. I can’t justify seeing a patient that can barely hold themself upright, and settle for telling them to make their house reek of lavender and wait until it goes away. It just doesn’t work.”

Perfuma paused for a moment, eyes wide and downcast, before meeting Mermista’s scowl.
“I’m aware that these kinds of methods won’t cure it, especially when modern medicine can’t. I just thought that it could help your patients try to take care of themselves.”

“Look, flower girl-”

“Okay, let’s just pause for a minute there,” Scorpia interjected. Both girls drew their eyes away from each other, the room falling silent save for Scorpia’s long exhale. “I think everything’s studying is starting to get to everyone’s heads. Maybe we should take a break?”

Mermista cast a quick glance up from the floor to the two girls, idly tapping a rhythm on the floor with her thumb.

“I know a cafe that’s not too far from here. It’s kind of a lame place, but they do student discounts or whatever. Plus the guy that works there can be funny. Occasionally.”

Perfuma gave a light smile, her usual softness returning in full force. “That sounds lovely. I will need to either detour to our dorm or borrow something warm before we go if I can. It’s gotten quite chilly this afternoon.”

“I’ve got a surplus of warm stuff you can borrow!” Scorpia chirped, the taller blonde began searching through the room’s communal closet for something for Perfuma to wear. “The mums are constantly sending me sweaters and things, so I’m never without. Do you need one, Mermista?”

Mermista thumbed the hem of her scrub shirt, sighing at the thinness.

"Ugh, fine. But only because I can't work if I get sick. Have you something that looks cool or whatever?"

"Hey, Glimmer?"

At the sound of her friend's voice and the feeling of one earphone being plucked out of her ear, Glimmer looked up from her notes to see Bow.

"Hi. What's up?"

"Have you seen Adora?" he asked. "She said we were going to work on our history papers together, but she's been gone all afternoon and hasn't been answering her phone-"

"Bow, slow down."

A gentle hand took hold of Bow's, and he felt the crushing in his chest subside. Her thumb drifted back and forth over the skin on his hand, eyes watching him closely as he took a deep breath and exhaled.

"Have you seen or heard anything from Adora in a while?"

Glimmer's shoulders sagged, her hands removing her remaining earphone while she shook her head.

"No, but I think I have an idea on where she might be," she admitted, pulling out her phone and heading to the keypad.

"Training?"

"She would have been finished by now," Glimmer mused. "If she was with Catra she would have answered, which means there's only one place she could be."

After dialling the number, she placed the call on to speaker mode, Bow and herself tuned in once the other end picked up.

"Etheria University Health Clinic, this is Juliet. how can I help you?"

Glimmer paid no mind to the look Bow gave her, immediately answering the question from over the phone.

"Hi there, I was wondering if my roommate is there at the moment? She hasn't been answering her calls, and we're starting to worry."

"Do you have her name?"

"Adora Grayskull?"

The other end was near silent, Bow's face contorting into comical concentration as they waited.

"Yes, she is here. In the ice baths," came the reply.

"Can we ask what's happened to her?" Bow interjected. "Is she safe?"

"She is safe, but I can't give out any information. We take patient privacy very seriously here."

Glimmer tried her best to sound positive as she responded, but her sagged shoulders gave her away. "Of course, thank you so much for your help."

The call ended a few seconds later, the two remaining occupants of Room 11 staring blankly at one another.

"I know you're a different athlete to Adora," Bow started, casting a quick glance to the various ribbons Glimmer had pinned to her side of the room's wall. "But this isn't normal, isn't it?"

Glimmer gave a heavy sigh in response.

"I should have known something was wrong when she asked for rehab tips."

Bow was silent for a moment, hands digging through his satchel and retrieving a small pad and a pen before sitting on his bed and facing Glimmer.

"What happened?"

"It was a few weeks ago now," she started, plopping beside him. "Adora came back from training, said she felt really stiff and asked if she had any tips. I told her when I was stiff after gymnastics, I would have an ice bath for 10 minutes, no more than that. She didn't bring it after that day, so I never really thought anything about it."

As Glimmer spoke, Bow's pencil furiously scribbled over the pages.

"Are there any baths in the girls' bathroom?" Bow asked, underlining something on the page that Glimmer couldn’t see.

"Not that I know of."

"So that's why she's using the ice baths at the clinic," Bow realised. "But the bigger question is why is she using them?"

"Even if it is just from her training, she could be really hurting herself if she's in the water for longer than she's supposed to be."

Bow's pencil stilled, eyes locked on the page as he let out a heavy sigh.

"We can talk to her, tell her our concerns, but at the end of the day that's all we can do," he mumbled. "She's our roommate, but there's no obligation for her to tell us anything, or even for her to like us."

Glimmer managed a ghostly smile.

"Bow, she's brought us burritos how many times this semester? And aside from Catra, who else does she willingly spend time with? I have a feeling she likes us."

Rolling his eyes, Bow let his chuckle escape from his lips. "You're right."

"You are, too," Glimmer reminded Bow, her smile widening as she looked at him. "Yes, we're Adora's friends, but she doesn't have to tell us anything. I just feel kinda...hurt, you know? I thought she started opening up to us over this past month, but now it just feels like it's going nowhere and-"

"I know," Bow hushed, his notebook abandoned on his lap and his hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "We can figure this out, but first you need to stop worrying. When did you last eat?"

The silence and Glimmer's sheepish smile were louder than words.

He sighed, discarding the notepad and pen on the desk and reaching for his jacket. "Get your coat. We'll grab some food and coffee from The Dragon's Daughter?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes, but slung her coat over her shoulders.

"Fine. But it's my shout. And don't tell my mum."

"He seems...enthusiastic?"

Mermista groaned, bringing the mug to her lips before answering.

"That’s Sea Hawk. At least, that's what he prefers to be called," she explained.

"It's always nice to see some high energy people, especially at this stage of the semester," Perfuma hummed, pouring herself another cup of tea. "I just wish there was a way to help everyone feel a little more recharged, like we were at the start of semester."

Scorpia paused, carefully setting her cookie back down on the plate. Deep eyes looked up at Perfuma.

"Well, what if we could do that?" she suggested. "Get everyone feeling a bit less stressed, and hopefully a little better too."

"How are we going to do that?" Mermista asked.

"Well, what was different about the start of semester?"

The scrub clad woman sighed, beginning to list off on her fingers. “We didn’t have any classes, a good number of us moved out of

home for the first time, we had that party, did I mention that we didn't have any classes?"

Perfuma frowned, listening to Mermista list seemingly ordinary and almost mundane things, but ones that all added up to a more peaceful time before the whirlwind pace of the semester had trapped the students in its grasp. However, Scorpia perked up.

"Wait, hold on, I've got it!"

"What? Do you think you can end the reign of terror from 8am classes?" Mermista asked, chugging the rest of her coffee.

"Sadly, no. But I think I have an idea to help everyone we know feel a little better; we throw a party!"

Scorpia was met with silence and two blinking eyes.

"Okay, but think about it," she started. "This Saturday is the last one before Halloween. We can make it a Halloween party, boost everyone's mood enough to last until winter break. Decorations and food will be easy, and everyone loves a Halloween party? It's foolproof!"

Perfuma and Mermista each looked to the other, blank faces melting into slight smiles and raised eyebrows.

“I think if we can pull it off, it could definitely work,” Perfuma hummed, cradling her teacup. “I’m in.”

“Yeah, it’s a cool idea and all, but where are we gonna have it?” Mermista questioned. “The last one was run by the school, and I doubt they’ll let us use a room for an event not hosted by them. Plus we need to figure out when to have it, and who to invite as well.”

“I’m sure we can figure all of that out,” Perfuma assured the woman. “I think it’s best to organise the guest list first, and when we know how many people are coming we can find somewhere to have it.”

The conversation was interrupted by the sound of bells rattling against the opening door. Two figures, both familiar to the group, walked through with eyes and smiles locked on each other.

“Bow! Glimmer! Hello!” Perfuma chirped, waving excitedly. As they waved back, Mermista flicked her eyes between the lithe blonde and the two fellow students entering the care.

“You know them?” she asked.

“Mhmm! I met them in a QSA meeting.”

“Wait, we have a queer-straight alliance?” Scorpia mumbled to herself, before shaking her head and looking to her two companions. “Anyway, are you thinking what I’m thinking?”

Perfuma quirked her eyebrows in response. “Scorpia, I can’t read minds, I have no idea what you’re thinking.”

“Well,” Mermista interrupted quietly. “Hurry up and learn, because Bow and Glimmer are heading this way.”

Surely enough, the two walked towards the tables, small smiles on both of their faces.

“It’s so good to see you two outside of class,” Perfuma hummed, giving them both a warm smile.

“You too! But Glimmer was knee deep in studying and forgot to eat again,” Bow admitted with a chuckle. “So, we figured it was a good idea to take a break and recaffeinate.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes but laughed along with him, looking at Perfuma’s companions at the table. “I don’t believe we’ve met. Glimmer, she/her,” she introduced, holding out her hand to the two strangers. Scorpia reached out first.

“I’m Scorpia, also she/her. It’s lovely to meet you,” she greeted, gently shaking the short woman’s hand, before Mermista jumped in.

“Mermista. She/her.”

Glimmer nodded with a light smile, shaking her hand. “I think we’re in the same mathematics class.”

“8am Wednesdays with the world’s most boring lecturer?”

“That’s the one!”

“Gods, I hate that lecture,” Mermista groaned. “It’s a wonder I haven’t fallen asleep in any of his classes yet.”

“You’d be the only one,” Bow interjected, offering his hand to the two. “I’m Bow, he/him. It’s lovely to meet you both, but we don’t want to keep you for too long. ”

“If you want, you’re more than welcome to sit with us.”

At Perfuma’s statement Scorpia and Mermista looked out the corner of their eyes. The pair exchanged silent words, vaguely

hearing the mumbles from Glimmer and Bow as they took their seats in the two remaining chairs.

"So," Scorpia began. "What are you two doing on Saturday night?"

supermarket flowers

Chapter Summary

> “Say hi to Sparkles and Arrow for me,” Catra hummed, predicting the exact second Adora sighed in response.
>
> “Once again, it’s Bow and Glimmer,” she huffed. “And I will. What time is the party tomorrow?”
> ---
> “You don’t have to answer this one if you don’t want to,” she breathed.
>
> Adora furrowed her eyebrows. “It can’t be that bad, right? What is it?”

Chapter Notes

> cw; mentions of homelessness, minor character death
>
> alrighty: I do not say this lightly. please read this chapter carefully. towards the last section of this chapter, there a scene in which a minor character's death is described. it is not a graphic scene, but please read with caution. the entire scene will be italicised so you can skip it if you wish to
>
> please let me know your thoughts, and enjoy the chapter x

“A party?”

Catra had thrown out the suggestion nonchalantly as the pair walked away from the bleachers, the late afternoon sun setting behind them.

“Yeah, my roommate Scorpia is throwing a Halloween gig tomorrow night,” the artist hummed. “Pretty sure your roomies are invited, so figured I’d ask if you were coming.”

“Wait, how does your roommate know Bow and Glimmer?” Adora asked, adjusting the strap of her gym bag.

“She met them at some cafe. Anyway, are you gonna come or not?”

Adora paused for a moment, eyeing Catra curiously. “Will there be alcohol?”

Catra smirked. “Duh. It’s a party.”

“I don’t know, Catra. I really shouldn’t be drinking-”

“Blondie, you don’t have to drink,” Catra interjected. “I doubt anyone that’s coming will pressure you anyway. I’m getting myself fucked up because I finally have an excuse to, but that doesn’t mean that you have to.”

Adora quirked an eyebrow. “What’s the excuse? You could get drunk any weekend you pick.”

“Yeah, but my birthday is a Monday and Halloween is a Thursday this year, so I can’t exactly use those.”

Gray-blue eyes widened, and Catra found it all too easy to imagine this girl reincarnated into a golden retriever.

“Is your birthday this Monday coming? Are you going to do anything for it? H-”

“Yes and no,” Catra interrupted with a wave of her hand. “Don’t exactly have people lining up to do stuff with me, and no way in hell am I going back to Weaver’s for it.”

The blonde paused, pouting slightly before looking over to the artist.

“So that means you’re free Monday?”

“Yeah, I just said that-”

“Great! I’m taking you out.”

Catra stopped in her tracks, watching Adora continue walking, somehow managing to have a skip in her step even as she limped.

“Uh, what? Blondie, you don’t have to do something for my birthday because you feel bad-”

“Catra, I’m not doing it because I feel bad,” Adora interrupted, turning back to look at the brunette. “I’m doing it because I want to. I’ve had the idea for a while now.”

She fell silent, watching Adora curiously.

“You have?”

As the blonde nodded, Catra searched her face. Those stormy eyes were calm and bright, with not a single trace of dishonesty. The artist felt her stomach doing flips. Crap.

Clearing her throat, Catra walked the few extra steps towards Adora and closed the distance, letting one side of her mouth twitch up in a smile.

“What did you have planned?”

Those crinkles around Adora’s eyes deepened as the blonde grinned.

“Well, I was thinking we could get dumplings at the place that you like,” she started, the two girls falling into step alongside one another. “Then we could go to an arcade or something? I know one that serves alcohol.”

“Tryna get me drunk on a Monday night?” Catra teased.

“You’re perfectly capable of doing that yourself,” Adora shot back. Catra rolled her eyes, swatting Adora’s arm and as the blonde laughed.

“That sounds cool though.”

Adora glanced at Catra with furrowed eyebrows. “Getting drunk on a Monday night?”

“Hanging out with you. Somewhere that isn’t the bleachers.”

The pair fell quiet, matching pace as they walked towards the centre of campus. The silence was comfortable, neither of them feeling the need to say anything to fill it, content to hear the crunching leaves beneath their feet and the sound of their breaths. As Adora began to fall behind, Catra slowed her pace to match. Whether it was to ease the pain Adora felt, or prolong the

moment in the afternoon sunlight, Catra didn't know, but she didn't mind.

"Any new drawings?" Adora asked. "Ones that you're proud of?"

"Y'know you asking me about them isn't going to make me show you them, right?" Catra reminded her.

"I know," she hummed. "I just want to know how you feel about them. That's the most important bit."

Catra gave a small smile. She could let herself do that around Adora.

"My dynamic ones have gotten better," she told Adora. "All the ones of people moving."

"That sounds amazing! I mean, your drawings were already amazing, but they must be on a whole other level now," the blonde beamed, and Catra felt her cheeks colour, muttering a 'thank you' under her breath.

As the sight of F Block came into view, their pace slowed even more.

“Say hi to Sparkles and Arrow for me,” Catra hummed, predicting the exact second Adora sighed in response.

“Once again, it’s Bow and Glimmer,” she huffed. “And I will. What time is the party tomorrow?”

“Starts at 6. I’m gonna be heading into the city to grab alcohol beforehand if you wanna come on an adventure?”

Adora’s smile was brighter than the sun.

“Sounds good! I’ll meet you at the bus stop?”

“5pm sharp. See you round, Blondie.” With her mouth pulled up into a smirk, and a flick of wild hair, Catra headed down her path, and disappeared behind the bricks of F Block.

“Okay, truth or dare?”

The game had been Bow’s idea. The empty common room was covered with streamers in black and orange, with matching balloons strewn across the floor and a B grade horror movie playing in the background. The students sat in a circle, a phone with two options lighting up the screen.

“Dare,” Mermista answered, prompting Bow to tap the phone, a statement flashing across the screen as the room flooded with the sounds of disgust.

“Eat a tablespoon of a condiment of your choosing!” Bow exclaimed, doing his best to keep a straight face.

The nurse huffed, rising from her spot in the circle and heading over to the table by the wall, covered with various cups ranging from full to empty and platters of food. Grabbing a plastic spoon, she reached for the bottle of hot sauce.

“She’s ballsy as hell,” Catra mumbled to the blonde next to her, grinning as she watched Adora roll her eyes.

“Keep it in your pants,” she whispered back, earning a snicker from the artist.

Thankfully, their small conversation was buried underneath the various squeals and groans as Mermista swallowed the contents on her spoon. For a moment, she seemed fine. A few seconds passed, before she let out a single cough, wincing slightly as she wandered back to the circle.

“That was unpleasant.”

Chuckles filled the room, Mermista suppressing another cough as she tapped the phone to bring up the next question.

“Catra, truth or-”

“Dare.”

“You’ve done three dares in a row,” Scorpia piped up. “You have to do at least one truth before you can do another dare.”

Catra huffed quietly. “Alright, fine.”

Mermista quirked an eyebrow at the question on the screen, looking up at Catra.

“Reveal a secret no one in the room knows about you.”

Catra pursed her lips in thought, casting a quick glance to Adora.

“I told you about how I got my nose broken as a kid, right?” she asked.

“Yes, so you can’t use that one,” Adora replied.

Catra blew a stray hair out of her face, staring at the phone in the middle. The room was silent, save for Entrapta snacking on a bowl of corn ships, before Catra eventually looked up to face the students sitting around her.

“So it’s not a massive deal, but it’s the only one I can think of right now,” Catra started, shrugging nonchalantly. “I’m technically homeless. And I have been since I started at EU.”

While the others merely looked on, various degrees of shock plastered on their faces, Scorpia audibly gasped, watching Catra with wide eyes. Catra looked to her roommate, raising a single eyebrow.

“You okay, Scorpi?”

“How can you say being homeless isn’t a big deal? What happened?”

Catra squinted at the larger woman. “Nothing happened. I was at Weaver’s, I aged out of the foster program and now I’m here.”

“So what are you going to do when Winter Break gets here?” Glimmer asked softly. “It’s possible that you could stay on campus, but it’s a lot of hoops to jump through, even if I pull some strings to help.”

Catra shrugged once more, looking back at the phone.

“I’ll figure something out. I always do.”

No one said another word, until the artist tapped the phone screen.

“Perfuma,” she drawled with a smirk. “If we’re playing by the rules, I believe you did three truths in a row. That means it’s time for a dare, correct?”

The lithe blonde gave a sheepish smile and nodded, face turning red as Catra read out the words on the phone’s display.

“Kiss the player you find the most attractive.”

“Oooh get it, Perfuma!” Bow cooed, only deepening the woman’s blush. She sat still, fiddling with her fingers and taking a deep breath.

“You got this!” Adora chirped, giving a reaffirming smile to the visibly nervous blonde, the room falling silent in quiet anticipation, the tension thickening with every second. Right before the students choked, Perfuma gave a heavy sigh, moving quickly as lightning to grasp the collar of the woman sitting next to her, and plant a light kiss to Scorpia’s cheek.

The amputee gasped once more, cheeks flushing red as the rest of the students yelled and cheered in delight.

“Catra the Wing Woman strikes again!” Entrapta cried, but all Catra could hear was Adora’s laughter.

The commotion simmered down to a light hum, Perfuma clearing her throat.

“Alright, whose turn next?” she muttered, tapping the phone. “Adora! Truth or dare?”

“I think we’re all still recovering from that last dare,” the athlete teased, earning a snicker from Catra. “I’ll go with truth.”

Perfuma tapped the phone once more, frowning slightly then looking up at Adora.

"You don't have to answer this one if you don't want to," she breathed.

Adora furrowed her eyebrows. "It can't be that bad, right? What is it?"

"What is your saddest memory?"

Adora hated the smell of hospitals more than anything. She almost considered pinching her nose shut as she walked through the empty halls, counting down the rooms until she found the one she needed.

Room 313.

Adora steeled herself with a deep breath, opening the door as quietly as she could and peeking her head inside. Blinking away the tears, she gave a small smile.

"Hey there, Mum," she murmured.

Mara's head turned ever so slightly, dull grey eyes looking through her as a weak smile crept up her lips.

"Hello, peanut," she breathed. She sounded tired. Looked tired. But it was only temporary; Mara was going to get better.

"Adora!"

The blonde was ripped back into the present, seeing all eyes on the circle on Adora and feeling a gentle hand on her shoulder.

"You don't have to answer this one, Adora," Catra murmured, lightly squeezing. "We can just think of something else."

"It's alright," Adora mumbled, her hand resting on top of Catra's. She took a deep breath, exhaling and looking at the students surrounding her.

"Some people already know this," she started. "But I lost my adoptive mother 6 months ago. There was a blood clot the doctor's didn't find in time, it got into her heart and killed off a lot of the tissue. She held on for a few weeks after it happened but-"

Adora gave a heavy sigh, squeezing Catra's hand on her shoulder as her eyes began to sting.

"I was in the hospital with her when it happened."

The room went silent, Catra's hand moving from Adora's shoulder to intertwine their fingers together, squeezing Adora's hand.

"I'm so sorry to hear that, Adora," Scorpia breathed. "I had no idea."

"I think your mother would be really proud of you," Perfuma offered quietly.

"I *know* she would be," Glimmer spoke.

Adora inhaled shakily, managing a ghost of a smile.

"Thanks," she breathed. The crushing in her chest didn't ease, neither did the shaking of her frame or the tears welling in her eyes. *Not here. Not like this.*

"I've just gotta duck to the bathroom, start the next round without me," Adora lied. Before anyone said a word, she released Catra's hand and darted out of the common room.

The silence was deafening. Drowning. Various pairs of eyes searched one another, some confused and in shock, others in knowing and concern. Bicolour eyes stayed fixed on the door.

“That’s not the way to the bathrooms, is it?” Catra asked, but she already knew the answer. “Someone needs to find her.”

“Is going after her a good idea?” Mermista quizzed. “She just told us about how her mother died, shouldn’t we give her space?”

“This is Adora,” Glimmer retorted. “She has no self preservation on a good day. Will she be safe if we leave her alone?”

“Arguing is not what we need right now,” Bow interjected, standing and looking at the students around him. “She needs support, but not to be overwhelmed with people. One person should go check on her, and see what she needs, and my vote is Catra.”

Catra finally faced away from the door, looking at Bow with evident confusion.

“You’re her roommate.”

“And you know Adora better than anyone in this room.”

The weight of the statement fell heavy on Catra's chest, but she didn't have time to dwell on it. Adora needed her. Catra rose from the floor, bolting through the doors and down the halls, eyes wildly searching for her friend.

Adora's instincts told her to run to the field, the one with her mother's initials engraved underneath the bleachers. But her legs could only carry her to the end of the hall. High ceilings caved down on her, the lights growing brighter and brighter as the smell of disinfectant flooded her nose.

The aching in her jaw did nothing to tie her to the present, her chest collapsing in on herself and her eyes sewn shut to try to block out the memory. Maybe it wouldn't hurt; seeing her mother one more time, if only in a memory.

Adora's back slid down the wall, knees curled to her chest and her eyes searching the stars with closed eyelids.

She let out a shaky exhale, and let the tears escape with the memory.

"How was school today? Is everything alright at home?" Mara asked, voice barely above a whisper. Her hand gently took

Adora's, and the blonde had to fight the urge to gasp. Her hand was so cold.

"It was alright, nothing too out of the ordinary," Adora started, holding her mother's hand in both of hers, wishing the warmth would seep out of Adora's body and into hers. "Hope's getting really into the whole working from home thing and Nana Razz is at home with us every time she's not with you. I'm pretty sure she's saged the house at least 6 times," Adora chuckled softly, smiling a little more as she heard Mara laugh quietly. Her hands squeezed her mother's a little tighter. "She's making sure that everything will be perfect for when you come home."

Mara's smile was almost impossible to spot, but Adora knew her mother. She'd know that smile anywhere. "I'm glad that those two are finally getting along," the older woman breathed. "You should have seen Hope when she met my mother for the first time."

Hope, the stern, refined business woman that only ever smiled around Adora's mother, and Nana Razz, a kitchen witch who permanently smelled of spices and refused to exist without an apron, the idea of their first meeting made laughter bubble in Adora's chest.

"What a sight that would have been," Adora managed, knowing the only thing that she, Hope and Nana Razz had in common was their shared love for Mara, and even the way that they loved her was different.

“Have you heard anything from the university?” Mara mumbled, her eyes now closed but her hand lightly squeezing one of Adora’s. Adora couldn’t help but smile.

“Yeah, I have. I’ve got good news,” she hummed, trying to keep her excitement under control to not overwhelm her mother.

“Oh?” Mara cracked one eye open, giving Adora her signature playful smile. “Well, don’t keep it all to yourself. What did they say?”

Adora grinned, squeezing her mother’s hands as her heavy heart lifted for a brief moment.

“I got in, Mum. They’re giving me a full scholarship.”

Mara opened both eyes, the dull gray regaining the spark Adora was used to for just a moment. Gently removing her hand from Adora’s, she held both of her arms out wide. Adora carefully embraced her, burying her head in her mother’s chest and holding her torso, eyes watering as she felt her mother’s arms wrap around her.

“Congratulations,” she hummed sweetly, pressing a gentle kiss to the top of her head. “For track and field?”

“What else?” Adora lightly teased, smiling as she felt her mother laugh.

“That’s my girl. Do you know what degree you want to do yet?”

“Either history or physiotherapy. Maybe both.”

Mara chuckled softly, one hand gently carding over Adora’s scalp. “Always the overachiever, aren’t you?” She punctuated the statement with another kiss to the top of her head. “I’m so proud of you. I never doubted you for a second.”

“You never have, Mum,” Adora mumbled into her chest, fighting every instinct to squeeze her mother tighter. “I never could have done it without you.”

“Don’t be silly, of course you could have.” Mara ruffled her hair with a light laugh, Adora sitting up slowly with a chuckle to look at her mother. “You’re destined for big things, Adora. But everything in your future is because of what you do, and what you achieve. Not because of what I’ve done.”

Adora rolled her eyes, not wanting to argue with her mother, even though she knew deep down that Mara was right. Mara sighed, reaching up to gently cup Adora’s cheek. Even though it was colder than Adora was used to, she closed her eyes and leant into her mother’s touch.

“I’m so proud of you, Adora. You’re going to do such wonderful things,” Mara hummed, Adora’s heart floating at her mother’s praise and words. “I wish I could be around to see it.”

Adora’s eyes shot open, her stomach dropping. Mara still cradled her cheek, smiling sweetly. Sadly. Adora took in every feature of her mother’s face, and felt her eyes sting.

Her brown hair, braided at the nape of her neck instead of the crown, was dull and brittle, split ends that were never there before now prominent. Her gray eyes were usually so bright, full of life and hope for the new day. Now, they were empty. Her golden skin had lost its glow, and how long had the bags under her eyes been there? Adora felt like she was looking at a ghost.

“Adora?”

Snapping out of her spiral, Adora saw her mother watching her, making no effort to hide her concern.

“Don’t talk like that,” Adora breathed, Mara’s face blurring as the floodgates opened behind her eyes. The rest of her words drowned in her throat. Adora felt two hands on her cheeks, pulling her forward, she felt her mother’s forehead resting against her own as those hands began to wipe away the tears that didn’t seem to stop.

“Shhh, deep breaths. In and out,” her mother hummed, Adora’s hands clutching the front of her hospital gown.

“Please, Mum,” Adora managed, trying to cease her sobs long enough to talk. “Please don’t say things like that. You’re Mara Grayskull, you’re gonna- you’re gonna kick your stupid body’s butt and get better. You have to get better.”

“C’mere.”

Adora let herself be pulled into her mother’s embrace once more, soaking the hospital gown with her tears as Mara’s arms held her tight. Time lost all meaning, and the only thing that Adora knew was her mother rubbing circles on her back, humming her lullaby into her hair.

“I don’t know if I can do this without you, Mum,” Adora whimpered, feeling a kiss on the crown of her head.

“Adora,” Mara breathed, hands moving to gently cup Adora’s face and bring her gaze up to see her. “You silly little peanut,” she chuckled, prompting a small smile from the young girl. “You are so much stronger than you realise, Adora. Life has never been easy for you, but no matter what the world throws at you, you don’t let it stop you.”

Mara gave her the sweetest smile Adora had ever witnessed, wiping away the tracks the tears left on her cheeks.

"I am so proud of you, Adora," she breathed. "But you're going to have to do this next part without me, okay?"

Adora's heart ached, holding Mara's hands to her cheeks, trying to keep her mother here with her and feeling her heart shatter knowing that there was nothing she could do. The doctors had already told her.

"I know, shhhh. I know," Mara mumbled as her thumb stroked her daughter's cheek, two sets of eyes filled with tears that refused to stop falling. "I don't want to leave you either. You know that, right?"

Adora nodded, watching her closely. They were running out of time, and Adora was trying to imprint the love that she felt when her mother smiled at her onto her heart, to memorise every last detail of her face before she didn't get another chance to see it.

"I am always going to be with you. But Mum's tired, peanut. Mum needs to rest now."

Adora let out a shaky exhale, and mustered a smile for her mother's sake.

"Okay," she whispered. "Get some rest, Mum."

Her smile broke Adora's heart, but not as much as the relief on her mother's face after hearing those words. Wiping her tears, Adora helped her mother lay back, fluffing the cushions and pulling up the blankets to make her comfortable, to try prolong what was about to happen.

Adora could see the energy start to leave her, and maybe in an alternate universe she would have heard the rate on the heart monitor begin to climb and climb and climb. But all Adora could do was sit by her mother's side and clutch her hand.

"I am so, so proud of you, and you better not forget that," Mara chuckled weakly. "Don't forget me, okay?"

"I won't, Mum," Adora whispered, clutching her mother's hand. "I promise you, I will never forget you. Never."

Mara gave a small nod, each breath getting slower and slower, the comforting gray eyes Adora knew so well disappearing behind sunken eyelids. There was nothing more that could be done, but there was one thing left to be said.

“Hey, Mum?”

Mara managed to open her eyes to see her, and gave her a tiny smile.

“Yes, Adora?”

Adora took a shaky breath, and smiled at the woman who had changed her life.

“I love you.”

Mara smiled, and Adora burned the image into her brain.

“I love you too, peanut. To the moon and back, and twice around the sun.”

Her gray eyes drew closed, and Adora gently squeezed Mara’s hand, fingers drawing faint patterns on the skin. “To the moon and back and twice around the sun.”

Mara smiled softly, squeezed Adora's hand and exhaled.

The sound of the flat line pierced the halls, and Adora was alone.

ribs

Chapter Summary

> “What are you doing here?” Adora murmured. Catra managed a small smile and glanced up to finally meet her eyes, a look in them that Adora hadn’t seen before, one that she couldn’t place.
>
> “You’re such an idiot.”
> ---
> “So, uh, truth or dare earlier, right?”
>
> Perfuma quirked an eyebrow, looking at the girl next to her.
>
> “Uh, which part of it?”

She didn’t know how long she sat there. Back pressed to the wall, knees curled to her chest and struggling to breathe, Adora had no regard for anything that was happening around her. She was alone in the hallway, with her thoughts and the aching in her chest. All she could taste was salt. Adora wanted to go home, but she knew it wouldn’t feel like home anymore. She didn’t know if it ever would again.

“Adora!”

The silence was shattered, but the voice calling to her was muffled, distant, but dragging her out of her mind. Concrete eyelids forced themselves open, the sound of footsteps echoing down the hall. A blurry figure sprinted towards her. Clad in red and black, they grew closer and closer, their pace frantic, the

calling of her name desperate. The voice calling to her name was now familiar.

"Catra," she breathed. What was she doing here? Eyes open, she planted her hands against the wall behind her, hauling herself up the wall to stand. The tears rolling down her cheeks cleared her vision, eyes meeting bright blue and gold blown wide. She had never seen Catra like this. Any emotion apart from her standard blank face, or a smirk, or even the small smile that only came out around Adora, it was all foreign to her. But now, Catra almost looked afraid. The artist's pace only slowed when she was within arm's reach of Adora.

She immediately stood before the blonde, gentle thumbs wiping away the tears clouding her vision. Catra didn't look her in the eye yet, but all Adora could do was stare.

"What are you doing here?" Adora murmured. Catra managed a small smile and glanced up to finally meet her eyes, a look in them that Adora hadn't seen before, one that she couldn't place.

"You're such an idiot."

Adora watched Catra's eyes relent and finally take the sight of her in. The blonde was so used to the sharpness of Catra. Her cutting words, her quick wit, her snarls at anyone that looked at her the wrong way. Now, Catra was nothing but soft.

“What do you need?”

Adora’s words got stuck in her throat, the lump refusing to let them escape. She needed something, anything, to bring her back from the smell of hospitals and the sound of flatlining in the empty room, to save her from the echoing of her own wails. Adora stumbled forwards, and flung her arms around Catra’s shoulders.

Strong arms wrapped around Adora’s torso, bringing their frames together as Adora buried her face in the nook of Catra’s shoulder. Adora felt her legs start to give way but Catra held her steady. She lowered both of them to the cold floor of the hallway, Catra dropping to her knees and laying Adora’s torso across them, arms keeping each other close. The artist felt her shirt dampen, and the shaking of Adora’s shoulders. No words needed to be said. Catra’s hand traced along Adora’s spine, coaxing the muscles to soften under her touch. Feeling her chest ache for the woman in her arms, she tightened her grip around Adora’s torso, feeling the broken athlete do the same to her shoulders, as their bodies melded together. The only sounds were the stifled echoes of Adora’s sobs.

Neither of them knew how long they spent curled up on the floor together. As Adora’s cries began to subside, her face stayed buried in the hollow of Catra’s neck, and the artist could feel her fingers playing idly with her flannel. Catra briefly wondered what it would feel like, having Adora hold her like this but under another circumstance. She immediately abandoned the idea.

After a short eternity, Adora finally raised her head and looked up at Catra. The whites of her eyes were clouded by red, the tears

long gone leaving tracks down her cheeks which Catra's thumb found herself wiping away without her permission.

"Gods, I'm such a mess," the blonde murmured, shaking her head slightly and putting on a small smile. "I'm really sorry about that, I-"

"Don't."

The hall went silent once more, Catra's hands sliding to rest on Adora's sides, her eyes full of a gentle intensity.

"Don't you dare apologise for this," she continued. "Look I- I'm not good and stuff like this. Never have been. And I'm never gonna understand what you're going through, so I'm not gonna sit here and lie to you and say that I do. I lie about a lot of things, but not to y- I don't lie about stuff like this."

She felt Adora watching her curiously, and Catra tried to ignore the warmth of the blonde's body underneath her palms. Exhaling, she found her words.

"I'm never going to understand what you're going through, but I'll be damned if that's going to stop me from being here for you."

Adora didn't say anything, and Catra felt her heart drop. She overstepped, she had to. They had never talked about Adora's

mother except in passing, and Catra had no right to say things like that to her obviously grieving friend. The silence was beginning to choke, and Catra scrambled around inside her mind, trying to find the words to patch this all together, to at least try to make Adora feel better. Gods, why didn she even try, she wasn't good at-

Adora fell back into her embrace, and Catra could finally breathe again.

"Thank you, Catra."

It was no more than a whisper, but the small words raised Catra's heart from her stomach and up into her throat.

With Adora's arms secure around her shoulders, Catra held her torso pulled her closer and felt her lips twitch up just a touch.

"For the record, this is not because I like you or anything," she grumbled, and Adora's laugh made the rays of sun feel warmer than they ever had.

"I don't know, it kind of sounds like you're going soft on me."

"I am *not* soft, Blondie," Catra defended, but she could feel.

“Then what exactly do you call all of this?”

Catra rolled her eyes, a hand ruffling Adora’s hair as the blonde tried to wriggle out of her hold. Mumbling a ‘shut up’ under her breath, Catra slowly moved so that she could look Adora in the eyes, feeling her chest constrict her a little less as she saw Adora smiling.

“I freaked out everyone, didn’t I?” the blonde asked, unable to hide the sheepish grin. Catra simply shrugged.

“Nah. They were worried more than anything,” she told the blonde, watching her scramble off Catra’s lap to stand.

“Well, I don’t wanna worry them more than I already have.”

Catra’s response died in her throat as Adora looked down at her, offering a hand. *Gods, she’s pretty.*

Taking the hand before she could spiral any further into a gay panic, Catra was reefed up, her chest almost colliding with Adora’s from the force.

“Whoops! Heh, sorry,” Adora chuckled, taking a step back and dropping their hands. Catra immediately missed the feeling.

Coughing the thought down, she let her eyes linger over Adora's form with a slight smirk, ignoring the crawling feeling in her stomach.

"Don't know your own strength, huh blondie?"

"Something like that," Adora admitted, starting on her way back and knowing that Catra would fall in step beside her.

"Thank you, again," the blonde mumbled after a silent moment. "You didn't have to do that. Especially since you always seem to be saving my butt in one way or another. But, it means a lot."

Catra nodded, eyebrows furrowing slightly.

"I wasn't saving you."

Adora watched the artist curiously, who huffed quietly, looking at the suddenly interesting pattern of the hallway floor.

"Me letting you cry on my shoulder? That wasn't saving you. That was just making sure you had someone with you when you saved yourself. Or, y'know, something like that or whatever."

She could feel the blonde's smile warming her skin.

“Catra, that’s actually really...nice. You sure you’re not going soft on me?”

“In your dreams,” she lied.

That was the last round of Truth or Dare for the night. When Catra and Adora returned to the common room, the circle had disbanded, with everyone strewn across various couches and beanbags, buried beneath blankets and facing the television. No one said a word about the earlier event. As they diverted the conversation straight to the laughable horror series playing on the screen, Adora knew the unspoken words that were being said. *We’ve got your back.*

The common room was filled with the sound of overly dramatic screams and raucous laughter, everyone unaware of the hours ticking by with each episode.

Catra was consciously aware of Adora’s thigh pressed to her own, glancing to the side every now and then to see her. She was smiling. Catra could only see if because the two were so close, but she counted that as a win. Her eyes were half covered by her drooping lids, and only then did she notice the two purple marks underneath Adora’s eyes.

“Hey,” she breathed. Adora’s eyes forced themselves open, tilting her head closer to Catra.

“Hmm? You okay?”

“Yeah,” Catra responded, turning to face Adora’s profile. She allowed herself to look for a little longer before she finally whispered a reply.

“You can take a nap if you want.”

Adora was silent for a moment, before her eyelids lowered slightly and she nodded.

“Wake me up if anything exciting happens,” she mumbled. Catra couldn’t speak over her heart in her throat as Adora put her head on her shoulder. Those damn flips in her stomach were back. She hesitantly leant to the side, resting her head on Adora’s, sighing in relief when the blonde didn’t stir. To Catra, the rest of the movie was simply white noise.

“Uh, P-Perfuma?”

The end credits of an episode played on screen, and a quick glance around the room was met with the sight of everyone

asleep, bundled under blankets. Everyone, except for Perfuma and Scorpia.

"Yes?"

Scorpia swallowed the lump in her throat, eyes fixed on the blanket strewn over her lap.

"So, uh, truth or dare earlier, right?"

Perfuma quirked an eyebrow, looking at the girl next to her.

"Uh, which part of it?"

Scorpia raised her gaze from her blanket, turning to see the blonde beside her, breath briefly stolen as she was met with those deep, gorgeous eyes.

"The, u-uh, the dare you did."

Perfuma's eyes widened, the light from the television showing the dusting of pink across her freckled cheeks.

“Oh. *Oh* . I’m- uh- did you not l-like it? Scorpia, I’m so sorry-”

“Oh, no, no, no!” Scorpia interjected quietly. “I did! I-uh-”

Scorpia cleared her throat, her heart beating out of her chest with Perfuma looking at her. Her soft smile, her flowing hair, her kind heart. All of it sent Scorpia spiralling into a whirlpool that she didn’t mind being trapped in.

“I r-really enjoy you as a person, and I really like spending time with you. And I think you’re really pretty- no, beautiful! And if you want to, I-I was thinking we could maybe go on a date? I-I mean, only if you want to! If I misread anything or you don’t want to, that’s okay-”

“Scorpia.”

The buff woman went immediately silent, watching Perfuma smile widely before leaning forward and planting a feather light kiss to Scorpia’s cheek.

“I would love to go on a date with you.”

Scorpia matched her wide grin, the crushing feeling around her chest easing but her heart still racing.

“We can plan everything tomorrow? When we’re a little more awake?”

Perfuma nodded, shuffling a little closer to Scorpia and resting her head on her shoulder. Cheeks hurting but grinning ear to ear, Scorpia’s head rested on Perfuma’s, her hands creeping slowly towards where Perfuma’s sat on her lap. Every inch felt like a mile, but it was cut short. Perfuma reached forward and closed the gap, intertwining their fingers together. The prosthetic could only pick up on so much sensation, but it didn’t matter. Perfuma was next to her, head on Scorpia’s shoulder, holding her hand, and they were going on a date. She knew that she would be pinching herself in the morning, but for once, it would be the good kind of surprise to realise all over again.
Scorpia squeezed Perfuma’s hand and smiled.

she

Chapter Summary

This was Adora, someone that wormed her way into Catra's life with bad jokes, creaky joints and a stupidly sunny disposition. She had made herself a part of Catra's life now, and she couldn't imagine it without her.

Adora didn't realise how beautiful Catra was until she really looked. Am I even allowed to look at her like that?

Chapter Notes

cw; slight internalised homophobia, repressed emotions

song of the chapter is she by dodie

"Ugh, I already told you; it's *not* a date!"

Scorpia stared wide eyed and grinning at the artist, while Entrapta hummed under her breath with a pad and pencil in hand.

"Are you sure? You do have some very handy wingwoman tips for Scorpia," the scientist mentioned. "You going on a date with an attractive person that you spend a lot of time with isn't out of the question."

Catra's gaze narrowed in on her purple haired roommate. "You think Adora is attr-"

“I think what Entrapta is trying to say is,” Scorpia interjected, placing a gentle hand on Catra’s shoulder and coaxing her to turn back around. “You and Adora spend a lot of time together, and we can see that being around her has made you...well-”

“Made me what?” Catra asked, voice bordering on a snarl. “Soft?”

“Happier.”

Catra’s words left her. Those stupid flips in her stomach were back, and she still didn’t know why. This was getting ridiculous. Finally looking up, she saw her roommate looking down on her, the close proximity that once made Catra’s hands tremble now filling her with ease. Scorpia was smiling, somehow even softer than usual.

“I think she’s good for you,” the blonde hummed, nodding slightly. “I think you’re good for each other.”

Catra exhaled and gave a half-hearted smile. A few months ago, she would have never entertained this kind of conversation with Scorpia. Now, it was all too easy. “Thanks Scorpi. I’m super grateful for her but- we’re just friends.”

Scorpia’s smile stayed as she nodded. “It’s good to have a friend. Now get ready! You’re going to be late-”

“I’m already good to go,” Catra defended, stepping away so Scorpia could look at her. “This look okay?”

It wasn’t too far from her usual outfit but for some reason she felt the need to check, with a red tee, ripped black jeans and an oversized black jean jacket.

“Looking good, wildcat! What time are you meeting Adora?”

Before Catra could respond, a firm three knocks sounded on the door.

“That would be now,” she hummed, as Scorpia reached forward to open the door.

Surely enough, it was Adora. A white turtleneck was covered by the same red jacket as it always was, with gray jeans tucked into combat boots and the same sword pendant dangling from the blonde’s neck. The mere sight of Adora with her eyes fixed on Catra caused her to smile.

“Hey! Ready to go?” she chirped with a wide grin, clutching a colorful paper bag by the handles.

“Sure am. Remember your key this time?” Catra asked with an easy smirk.

“Did you have to bring that up?” she huffed, brightening up once more at the sight of Catra’s roommates, one tucked next to the table and the other opening the door.

“Hello Entrapta and Scorpia!”

A shrill “Hi!” sounded from inside the room, while Scorpia’s response was (as expected) softer.

“Hey there, Adorka. Make sure you bring her back in one piece, okay?”

Catra’s eyebrows furrowed. *Adorka?*

“Don’t worry, I will,” the blonde hummed, storm blue eyes falling over Catra’s form. “Shall we?”

Catra nodded, walking through the door with a glance back at Scorpia.

“Don’t wait up, Scorpi. I’ll see you later.”

The door closing behind them couldn’t muffle the cheeriness of Scorpia’s response, but Catra’s and Adora’s gaze focused in on one another. Exchanging smiles, they fell into step as they headed down the hallway, the endless possibilities of the night stretching out before them.

“You look nice.”

Adora’s words knocked the air out of her chest. She thought Catra looked nice? Catra knew she wasn’t unattractive, but she didn’t think her worth as a person was based on her facial structure or the clothes she wore. Yet, the compliment made her stomach bubble.

“Thanks,” she mumbled under her breath, looking over at Adora and immediately feeling warmer. “You clean up well yourself. But do you ever wash that jacket?”

Adora rolled her eyes, bumping her hip into Catra’s and knocking her off balance while the artist simply laughed.

“Every day, thank you very much!” the blonde defended. “At least my flannels don’t smell like smoke constantly!”

Catra was about to grumble a reply before her stomach beat her to it.

"It speaks!" Adora chuckled, stepping onto the path that wound through the buildings and into town. "I was gonna say, I hope you're hungry, but it seems like I already have my answer."

Catra shoved her hands in her pocket, smirking slightly. "Yeah, at least I remember to eat."

"Okay, that was *one* time. One time!"

"Adora, you didn't eat for 28 hours."

"I forgot! Besides, I ate an entire pizza afterwards, so it cancels out."

"It doesn't work like that. Anyway, did you remember to eat today?"

The silence was telling.

"Adora!"

“I was waiting for dumplings! They’re so goooooood,” Adora whined with a pout, and Catra could only manage to stay a little annoyed at her.

“Do I need to call ahead and tell the chef you’re about to eat them dry?”

“Oof, Catra!”

The slightly concerned waiter left the table, their order filling two pages for the kitchen to deal with.

“Don’t you think that was a little excessive?” Catra asked, swilling her bourbon around the glass.

“Not really,” Adora replied, with a sheepish smile. “It’s your birthday, and anything we don’t eat we can just take home and have for leftovers!”

Catra raised an eyebrow but soon relented with a smile.

“Alright. You know, you didn’t have to pay for all of that either.”

“As if I’m going to let you pay on your own birthday! That would just be mean. Also, speaking of birthdays,” she trailed off, retrieving the deep purple bag from beside her and sliding it across the table towards Catra.

“Adora, you-”

“Uh uh uh, you’re not pulling that same argument on me for not getting you a present,” she interjected, sitting back in her seat with a wide grin. “I just hope you like it.”

Catra began sifting through the bag, retrieving a sealed envelope first, her name in cursive scrawled across the front. Ripping it open, the card she pulled out made her raise an eyebrow.

“‘Where do cats go after they die’? Where did you find this card-”

“Just trust me!” Adora chirped, her grin not faltering for a second. Relenting, Catra sighed and opened the card, scoffing under her breath at the answer.

“Purr-gatory.”

Adora trying to hold in her laughter was funnier than the actual joke. While the blonde fought with her own sense of humour, Catra found the message scribbled on the blank side of the card, allowing herself a smile.The handwriting was familiar to her now, scribbled on the corners of pages with crossed out drawings, small phrases of encouragement or stick figures that Catra guessed were supposed her and Adora. The message on here was short, sweet. Something Catra let herself read over at least three times before finally looking up at the blonde.

"Thanks, Adora," she mumbled, hand digging through to grasp the present in the bag. It felt like a book? Her eyebrows drew together, pulling out a rectangular shaped present and promptly ripping open the paper keeping it a secret. Catra almost dropped it.

A new sketchbook, burgundy covers bound by spiral wire, with the initials "C.W." burnt into the front cover with beautiful cursive writing. Then, a metal tin. Charcoals. More of them than Catra's ever owned. Charcoal sticks, pencils, even a kneaded eraser especially for them.

"I know you didn't say anything," Adora started softly. "But I noticed that your other sketchpad was starting to fall apart. That, and you use the same charcoal stick all the time. So I asked Scorpia what brand you used and-"

The table fell silent as Catra's hand reached across the table to grasp Adora's. She didn't even mean to do that. But Adora's hand was warm and calloused, and Catra really didn't want to let go.

“Adora, this is-” she sighed, looking up to see the blonde watching her with a nervous smile. “I think this the kindest thing someone’s ever done for me.”

Adora exhaled in visible relief, with stormy eyes still fixed on Catra.

“So you like it?”

Catra allowed herself to smile.

“Yes, you idiot. I love it.”

She watched every ray of light in the room shine ten times brighter when Adora smiled. *Damn she’s pretty.*

Wait.

This was Adora, someone that wormed her way into Catra’s life with bad jokes, creaky joints and a stupidly sunny disposition. Straight hair, straight A’s, straight forward. Straight girl?

On their adventures together, Catra had always drawn Adora’s attention to girls that she found attractive, even guys and more

androgynous folks, to try to gauge her sexuality based on her reaction. But there was nothing. Every suggestion was simply met with a simple compliment you'd give a passing stranger.

They have a nice smile. She is kind of pretty. I guess he's attractive? I'm liking the hawaiian shirt, though.

Maybe Adora was ace? She always does go super red whenever something sexual gets brought up. But she could still like people romantically if she was- okay, getting even more distracted.

Adora was *perfect* . But most importantly, Adora was her friend. She had made herself a part of Catra's life now, and she couldn't imagine it without her. She couldn't afford to mess this up. She'd be okay to just admire her from afar, right? Totally platonically?

"Catra? Are you okay?"

The warm voice and the squeeze of her hand brought her back. Gray blue watched her intently, swimming with concern, her thumb rubbing back and forth over her hand and Catra still didn't want to let go. So she didn't. She squeezed Adora's hand in response, slightly smiling.

"Yeah," she told Adora, and for the first time in a while, it wasn't a lie.

“Are you sure that playing arcade games after 4 bourbons is a good idea?"

Catra didn't look drunk, not yet at least. But as Adora watched the artist feed coins into the pinball machine, a small smile plastered on her face, Catra almost seemed relaxed.

"May I remind you that getting drunk on a Monday was your idea?" she drawled in response, the machine buzzing to life.

"It was not!" Adora protested. "All I said is that you didn't need my help for that."

"And you were right, as usual."

Bicolour eyes didn't budge off the small ball bouncing around the insides of the machine, the entirety of Catra's body coiled tight like a spring, focusing her energy through her fingers and onto the buttons.

The sight was familiar to Adora. Catra, fixed on her task of the day, eyes never moving from it and her bottom lip between her teeth in focus. Even with the flashing lights of the machine

lighting up Catra's freckles, the sight didn't catch Adora off guard. The butterflies in her stomach did.

Okay, this was definitely new. Was it the alcohol? It couldn't be, Adora was a lightweight for sure, but she was only half a cider in. She took another look.

Adora didn’t realise how beautiful Catra was until she really *looked.* Caramel skin, high cheekbones dotted with dark brown constellations set off by bright blue and gold eyes. Soft lips tilted up in a lopsided grin. Wild brown hair was swept back, tucked behind pierced ears, and Adora clenched her fist at her side to fit the urge of running her fingers through the soft strands.

Am I even allowed to look at her like that?

Okay, this was *definitely* the alcohol talking now.

Adora was just a physically affectionate person, wanting to do that was totally platonic, right?

“You alright?”

Adora snapped out of whatever weird train of thought she was in, looking to whoever called her name. Catra, now focusing on Adora

instead of the pinball machine, eyebrows drawn together and eyes searching through Adora's own.

"Uh, yeah!" she replied, giving what she hoped was a reassuring smile. "I think the alcohol is hitting harder than I thought it would."

Catra's eyebrows relaxed, then raised, before erupting into giggles.

"You've barely touched your cider!" Catra laughed, moving away from the pinball machine and into another part of the arcade. "C'mon, keep up, blondie!"

Their hands brushed as Catra walked past. Neither of them know who first took the other's hand, but as their fingers effortlessly intertwined, neither of them complained.

The butterflies in Adora's stomach grew.

"You should have seen your face!"

“I didn’t know there was a kid with a freaking air horn outside the photo booth!”

Six squares filled the photograph, and the sight of each one filled Catra was a warmth she wasn’t used to. The square in question was Catra’s favourite.

The one before was when the air horn sounded, capturing the moment Adora’s soul momentarily left her body, while Catra was only wide eyed and blank faced. The next frame showed the two bursting into laughter. Catra’s arm held Adora around her waist, Adora’s own draped across her shoulder. The blonde’s free hand pressed to her racing heart, eyes closed and grinning wide. In the split moment when Adora’s eyes closed, Catra really looked at her. Catra looked at Adora like she was everything.

“You’re actually smiling in this one,” Adora chirped.

"Don't get used to seeing it," Catra grumbled, the night's bourbons messing with her balance. She squeezed Adora's hand a little tighter, feeling the blonde squeeze back and yanking her away from the edge of the path.

"Jokes on you," Adora slurred. "I have photo evidence that Catra Weaver has gone soft-"

"M'not soft!"

The blonde’s cackles echoed through the campus.

"Catra, you've literally been holding my hand this whole time."

"Because I'm drunk. Duh," the artist reminded her. "Also, you're tipsy and your body is a bag of shit. Gotta make sure you don't fall and break your ass or something."

"Mhmm, sure. Whatever you say," the blonde teased, an uncharacteristic smirk on her lips. Catra simply rolled her eyes. By some miracle, even at differing levels of functionality well below normal, the two shambled up the stairs to Room 11 without any disaster.

"This isn't your room, Catra," Adora mumbled.

"I know, dummy," she hummed. "You picked me up, so I'm dropping you off."

Catra felt Adora slow beside her, stopping to turn and look at the blonde.

Okay, this can't be wrong. Not when she's so nice to look at.

"You're really sweet, Catra," she hummed, and Catra wondered if it was the alcohol talking. "I like soft Catra."

Catra gave a single chuckle. "You're such an idiot," she hummed fondly, watching Adora fumble with her keys.

"Shut up," she grumbled, finally finding the right key.

"Make me."

Soft lips pressed to Catra's cheek, and she fell silent. Suddenly, it was super convenient that the lights in this hallway didn't work very well, drowning the girls in dim light. Adora moved away, smiling softly and opening the door.

"Goodnight, Catra."

Catra smiled, still swimming in the faint scent of apple cider and peaches Adora left behind.

"Goodnight," Catra breathed. She watched the sun disappear behind the closing door of Room 11, and exhaled.

Maybe Catra had gone soft after all.

if you're too shy (let me know)

Chapter Summary

"Can I tell you something?"

Perfuma opened her eyes, fixing her eyes on the blanket draped across them.

"Sure."

Scorpia let out a slow exhale, bringing Perfuma closer.

"You have a brother?"

"Two," he hummed, a small smile creeping up before it was suppressed.

"What are they like?"

Chapter Notes

cw; mentions of transitioning, slight mention of dysphoria and prosthetics

enjoy the chapter!

"I had a really fun time tonight."

Scorpia didn't realise that one sentence could cause her smile to get so big. Oddly enough, she liked it.

"I did too," she admitted.

Their date had begun hours ago, but the two didn't even entertain the thought of having it end yet. The common room was empty, saved for the two girls curled up in the corner of a couch, arms draped lazily around each other and fingers intertwined.

Scorpia wished she could feel Perfuma's thumb rubbing across her skin.of her hand

"You're thinking very intently."

Scorpia looked up from their hands, watching the girl beside Scorpia eye her closely. She gave what she hoped was a reassuring smile.

"Sorry," she chuckled, but Perfuma didn't budge.

"You know, we can talk about it if you want to. Get it off your chest," the blonde offered, squeezing Scorpia's hands between both of her own.

She sighed quietly, shaking her head.

"Nah, it's okay," Scorpia started. "It's old wounds, and they've healed. I just daydream sometimes, how things would be different without them, you know?"

Perfuma gave a soft smile, and squeezed a little tighter.

"I think I do," she replied softly.

"You do?"

Perfuma nodded once, eyes leaving Scorpia's view to stare at their intertwined hands.

"I transitioned when I was really young. And I got really lucky. My family were supportive, all of my treatments were paid for, and I moved to a new school right afterwards so that I didn't have to say anything if I didn't want to. I was happy. I didn't think I had anything to complain about, so I just didn't."

Perfuma's words were the only sound filling the room, whispered only to Scorpia as the two sat side by side.

"And even now, that's what I've always been known for. Just constant optimism out the wazoo. I've never had any reason to complain about anything so I never did, but I wonder if that would have been the same if things had worked out differently."

Scorpia watched Perfuma raise her head, soft deep eyes meeting her own. Perfuma gave a soft smile, giving a half hearted shrug and opening her mouth to change the subject.

“Hey, you know that you don’t have to have a reason,” Scorpia butt in.

Perfuma furrowed her eyebrows.

“What do you mean?”

“Even if you think you don’t have any reason to complain, that doesn’t mean you have to be happy all of the time,” Scorpia started. “Sometimes, bad things just happen. And even when life is really good, if something little goes wrong, it doesn't mean that you should just ignore how it made you felt."

Perfuma blinked once, twice, eyes falling down in a thousand yard stare.

"But, I have so much to be grateful for. It isn't fair for me to focus on the negative," she mumbled.

“But it isn’t focusing on that, it’s just acknowledging it,” Scorpia retorted.

“I just don’t like feeling those kinds of things, okay?!”

The common room went silent.

"Wrench, please!"

Hugo diligently handed Entrapta the wench, watching the purple haired scientist get to work on various hunks of metal. Over the past few weeks, it had begun to take shape. The hunks were formed into what looked like a torso, and four long cylinders that almost looked like limbs were set to the side.

"Will 'Emily' be sentient soon?" Hugo asked.

"Well, define 'soon'," Entrapta grumbled. "I have to still finish putting the framework together, then send through all the wiring so that Emily will be able to move, THEN I have to do all the programming so that Emily will *actually* be able to move, and that's if everything works the first time! Does that make sense?"

Hugo blinked twice, head tilted to the side.

"Not exactly but I trust your knowledge, little sibling."

Entrapta set back to work, retrieving tools from all over the table, eyes not leaving the project once.

“Why do you call me that?”

“Call you what?” Hugo asked.

“‘Little sibling’, I’m pretty sure I would know if we were related.”

Hugo pulled up his usual chair, sitting ramrod straight and watching Entrapta work.

“My oldest brother uses it quite often,” he explained. “Even for people that we are not related to, but are close to. I am not sure why.”

“You have a brother?”

“Two,” he hummed, a small smile creeping up before it was suppressed. “Hunter and Heath. Hunter is the oldest, Heath is older than myself, but younger than Hunter.”

Entrapta paused their work for a brief moment, turning to look at the young man sitting beside her. He was vacant, with a ghost of a smile on his face. Hugo sat perfectly straight to the point where it looked painful, knees bent at a perfect angle and hands crossed over his knees, with a white pressed shirt and perfectly slicked hair. Even in the mess of the robotics room, that the two had declared to be their safe space, he looked out of place.

"What are they like?" they asked, turning back to the project and taking up the blowtorch.

"Hunter is extremely successful," he started, somehow straightening up even more. "He is a businessman, runs the family company and has brought nothing but pride to the name."

"What company?"

"Prime Industries."

The name didn't ring a bell, but then again, Entrapta was never the best with names.

"So that's what he does, but what is he like?"

Lime eyes blinked once, Hugo's head tilting to the side once more.

“He brings nothing but pride to our family.”

Entrapta raised an eyebrow, turning on the blowtorch, and lining up the flame with the end of one of the limbs, now lodged in a hole of *Emily’s* torso.

“Alright, well, what about your other brother?”

“Heath? Well, he is certainly...different. Big Brother thinks that he is falling down the wrong path, not living up to his full potential that he can bring to the company. He says that Brother is quite selfish.”

Entrapta set down the blowtorch for the moment, but kept their eyes locked on Emily’s framework.

“‘Different’, huh? In a bad way?”

“I am not sure. But, speaking of Heath, I believe that is him at the door.”

Entrapta turned and saw the man in question. His skin was a pale, milky colour in some places, and warm tan in others, blotched around what they could see of his frame. His hair was a bold royal blue, either side of his temple shaved short with various lines

etched into them. Entrapta could spot the blotches of his skin through his ripped jeans, hands shoved into the pockets of his leather jacket.

"Hello, brother!" Hugo greeted with an enthusiastic wave. "Would you like to join us by partaking in the construction of a robot?"

He had gotten the words out before Entrapta could wrangle up an excuse or greeting or absolutely anything rather than standing there. Instead, Entrapta gave a sheepish smile. Heath's eyes found Entrapta's, flicking down their frame and then back up to find their eyes again. He gave a small shrug.

"Sure."

"I'm sorry I yelled at you," Perfuma mumbled.

The blonde was tucked under Scorpia's arm, head resting on her chest with Perfuma's arm slung across Scorpia's stomach. She didn't dare open her eyes yet.

"I know you didn't mean to," Scorpia replied in a whisper. "It wasn't exactly a light topic that we were talking about." That managed to coax a small laugh from Perfuma, lifting the tension from the room just a little. "Can I tell you something?"

Perfuma opened her eyes, fixing her eyes on the blanket draped across them.

"Sure."

Scorpia let out a slow exhale, bringing Perfuma closer.

"I can't entirely relate to what you've been through, but I have been somewhere kind of similar," she started. "My arms weren't from an accident or anything, I was born with them like that. On top of that, we lived in a small, close minded town, with both of my parents being openly queer women. So both of my mums' wanted to do everything they could to give me a life without any harassment."

Perfuma shifted up, resting her head on Scorpia's shoulder and angling her face to look at the woman. The arm across her stomach, hugged her a little tighter, a silent reassurance that didn't go unnoticed.

"So, as long as I can remember I've had prosthetics. And considering how different things could have been if we couldn't afford to keep getting them every time I grew, I'm really grateful. But that doesn't mean I miss the little things I've missed out on."

Scorpia dropped her gaze, moving her free hand to intertwine her fingers with Perfuma's.

“The nerves in my arms help me control the prosthetics and move them how I want. But I can’t feel anything with them. It’s kind of handy in some situations, like getting something hot out of the microwave or stuff like that. But I can’t check if my friend has a fever without a thermometer. I can’t feel like an animal’s fur when I pet them.”

Perfuma watched Scorpia visibly concentrate, then felt her squeeze her hand gently.

“I don’t know what your hand feels like in mine.”

She took a deep breath, and exhaled with a light smile.

“Those are all things I’ve missed out on. And even as lucky as I am, I still have to acknowledge that they’re there so I can be thankful for the things I haven’t missed out on.”

Scorpia raised their intertwined hands to just below the chin, watching Perfuma’s face carefully before pressing a feather light kiss to the back of her hand.

Scorpia’s heart sank as Perfuma released her hand. But it began to soar when her palm cradled Scorpia’s cheek.

“I think I understand what you were trying to say now,” she mumbled, offering a small but bright smile. “And in line with that, I haven’t actually done this with anyone before, and I probably won’t be very good at it but- what I’m trying to say is,” Perfuma stopped for a moment, rubbing her thumb across the soft skin of Scorpia’s cheek, and mirroring the smile it drew from her.

“Can I kiss you, Scorpia?”

Scorpia’s heart beat a mile a minute, and the only thing convincing her this wasn’t a dream was the steady sensation of Perfuma’s thumb running along her cheekbone.

“Yeah,” she breathed. “Yeah, you can.”

Scorpia’s hands held the small of Perfuma’s back as Perfuma’s remaining one found her other cheek. Both sets slowly but surely tugged on each other, their faces growing closer and closer until they could feel the breath on each other’s lips-

The common room light turned on, a grumpy looking janitor emerging from the shadows.

“S’after curfew,” he grumbled, loudly chewing on a piece of gum. “You two better get to ya dorms ‘fore I call the headmistress.”

Scorpia couldn’t find any words except for ‘dang it’ muttered under her breath.

cry baby

Chapter Summary

> It can’t be any worse than Weaver’s, Catra told herself over and over again. She kept repeating it, hoping eventually it would sink in and that maybe soon she would believe it.
> ---
> Glimmer’s heart dropped. This was bad; really bad. The one person in the world she couldn’t have, and she had to go catch feelings for him.

Chapter Notes

> sorry it's been a while since my last upload, the final weeks of my degree kicked my butt, but I am back! have almost 3k words of pure pining to make up for it x

“Do you honestly think me moving in is a good idea?”

Catra clutched her life’s belongings to her chest. A single, fraying bag stuffed with clothes, textbooks she could barely afford and art supplies. This felt wrong. She couldn’t quite place her finger on it, but the fact that she was here, standing at Scorpia’s front door and only hoping for safety was a jump she didn’t want to take. But there weren’t many options.

“Catra, I already told you,” Scorpia started. “The mums’ are fine with it. The spare room is on the other side of the house so you’ll have plenty of privacy.”

Catra exhaled deeply, eyes dropping to the doormat guarding the front door. The house was entirely brick, with sweeping arches

forming the front of the patio, a gorgeous redwood door that held the cause of Catra's anxiety behind it.

"Hey."

Catra looked to Scorpia who stood beside her, a soft smile above her.

"I know it's a big change," she started, placing a prosthetic hand on Catra's shoulder. "But you can stay for as little or as long as you like. This is just something that's in place so you can find your feet and start getting stable. You're not trapped here, I promise. As long as you let someone know where you are and that you're safe, you can come and go as you please."

The brunette gave a heavy exhale, picking with the fraying strands of her bag. It would be better than Weaver's. Mind you, the standard wasn't exactly very high. Raising her knuckles, Catra rapped them twice against the door.

Silence carried through the air, sending a shiver down Catra's spine. She had to admit, there was a part of her that was grateful for Scorpia's offer and her determination to see her safe. A big part, if she was being honest. But that didn't help the pit in her stomach gnawing away at her.

Scorpia was chronically considerate, always giving Catra options whenever she could, for decisions as small as what to eat that

night and big ones like where to go before the homeless shelter was her only option. But until now, every option and choice came with a cost. Every good thing in life came with a price.

The creak of an opening door sent Catra's stomach plummeting.

A woman poked her head around the open door, with stark white hair falling around her shoulders, dark eyes glancing at the two figures and softening.

"Hello girls," she hummed, opening the door fully. The woman wasn't much taller than Catra was, her lithe frame dressed in a blouse and pencil skirt as she held her arms wide. Scorpia immediately filled them. Watching Scorpia wrap her strong arms around the shorter woman, Catra could hear her laugh as the woman stood on her toes to hold her properly.

"Good to see you, Mum," Scorpia mumbled, releasing her mother and stepping aside. "Mum, this is my friend, Catra. The one I told you about?"

The woman moved her glance from Scorpia to Catra, dark eyes piercing through Catra's lungs. Silence fell over the group before the eyes staring Catra down softened.

"It's a pleasure to meet you, Catra."

The woman opened her arms wide with a warm smile, walking to close the gap between them. Catra’s entire body flinched.

Scorpia placed a hand on her mother’s shoulder, who immediately stopped, turning to look up at her daughter.

“Catra isn’t really a hugger,” she lied.

The woman dropped her arms back to her side, nodding silently and looking back to Catra.

“My apologies,” she started. "My name is Veronica, thank you for being such a good friend to Scorpia."

Catra gulped down her initial response of *you must be blind to think I'm a good friend* , nodding slightly.

"Scorpia is good to me," she muttered.

Veronica smiled widely, turning slightly to face the still open door.

"Dinner will be ready shortly. In the meantime, Scorpia can show you your room and help you get settled. Do you have any more bags?"

Catra took the strap of her bag and slung it over her shoulder.

“Just this.”

Veronica’s smile faltered just a fraction, but nodded once more before turning and walking through the front door. Catra could practically taste the pity.

It can’t be any worse than Weaver’s , Catra told herself over and over again. She kept repeating it, hoping eventually it would sink in and that maybe soon she would believe it.

Knock knock knock

“Glimmer? Are you in here?”

Glimmer took out one earbud, turning to face the closed door.

“Yeah, come in.”

The door squeaked open to reveal Glimmer’s mother, Angella, straight from the university. Her pale blue blouse wasn’t even crinkled, and still neatly tucked into her pencil skirt, lavender hair swept up and out of the way.

“There you are, darling,” the woman sighed, a tired smile on her face. “I was just about to get started. Is there anything you wanted?”

Glimmer turned back around to face her notes.

“I’m not really hungry,” she admitted. Angella didn’t buy it, sighing quietly before walking further into the room.

“Are you sure? You didn’t come down for lunch either-”

“I said I’m fine, Mom.”

Angella saw Glimmer, hunched over a notebook and fiddling with a pen.

She wanted to ask about whatever she was working on, to know what went through her only child's mind. Years worth of hours spent being cooped up in the office of Etheria University meant that Angella wasn't always home, and the times she were was tainted by her patience run paper thin.

Angella took a deep inhale, quietly sighing.

"Alright," she started. "Don't work too hard, alright? Come down whenever you like, I'll be making hot chocolate in a bit."

Glimmer heard her mother's heels click towards the door, a pit settling in her stomach as the door closed beside her.

Pushing her debate notes aside, she grabbed her phone. Flicking through the meaningless notifications, a familiar name appeared on the screen.

[Message from: Bow 💘]

are you settling back into home okay?

Glimmer smiled to herself, opening her message tab and typing away.

[Message from: Glimmer ✨ 💖]

I guess so, weird being back around mom tho

[Message from: Bow 💘]

Glimmer, she's headmistress at the uni we go to

you literally see her everyday

[Message from: Glimmer ✨ 💖]

first of all, don't remind me

second of all, u kno what i mean

[Message from: Bow 💘]

asdfghjk yeah i know

is there anything I can do to help?

Glimmer's chest began to ache, in a way that wasn't strange to her anymore, the way that made her heart beat a little faster and her hands shake just a little.

[Message from: Glimmer ✨ 💖]

I'd ask you for mother advice but you literally have two dads

[Message from: Bow 💘]

yeah no I think that one is adora's forte

but it's 3 weeks without school work, so enjoy it!

legit just drag your mom along to game night at mine

the dads miss her

also I miss you already, it’s so weird not seeing you everyday 🥺

Glimmer held her breath, reading the message over and over before eventually shaking her head. She could overthink that later.

[Message from: Glimmer ✨ 💖]

i miss you too 💖

Dinner was over with, and Catra had now met both of Scorpia’s mothers; Maeve and Veronica. Joint CEOs of Black Garnet Industries, a large chain business that dealt with the distribution of diamonds, sapphires, rubies and every other precious stone you could think of. The business Scorpia was training to take over for. Either way, this place was shaping up to be better than Weaver’s, not that the standard was very high. For the first time in a while, Catra actually felt normal.

“So did you kiss her or not?”

Scorpia groaned into her hands.

"No! And I really wanted to as well, but the stupid janitor showed up and the moment was gone, so I walked her back to her room and gave her a kiss on the cheek and- Catra, why are you laughing at me?!"

Catra was doubled over at this point, clutching the folded bed sheets to her chest and struggling to breathe.

"You get so nervous around Perfuma, it's hilarious," she exclaimed. "Dude, you are so smitten it's honestly kinda gross. Like, every time you even hear her name you get instant heart eyes."

"I mean, yeah," Scorpia shrugged. "Because I like her a lot. But, i-if you want me to stop talking about her I-"

"Scorpi, relax," Catra assured, unfolding the bedsheets. "It's chill, I promise."

Scorpia sat in the spinning chair by Catra's new desk, feet planted and pushing her side to side, watching her friend unpack.

"Besides, it's not like you don't get nervous around Adora, so you can't talk."

“What?” Catra questioned, casting a quick glance over her shoulder at Scorpia. “I don’t get nervous around Adora. Why would I?”

“Alright, maybe ‘nervous’ is the wrong word,” Scorpia corrected. “I just don’t know the right one. But just look at the date you went on with her-”

“I told you it wasn’t a date. We were just hanging out for my birthday,” Catra injerected. “Besides, I’m not Adora’s type. Even if I was, having a crush on her would be a recipe for disaster! She’s so...so- she’s just *good.* She’s warm and bright and kind and *beautiful.* Someone like me as anything more than a friend? She’d be burned into the ground trying to fix them.”

Scorpia opened then closed her mouth a few times. Eventually, she settled back into the chair with a soft smile.

“How was it?”

Catra paused, casting another glance to Scorpia while grabbing a pillowcase.

“Our d- hangout?”

“Yeah!” Scorpia confirmed. “Tell me all about it.”

Catra softened, the ghost of a smile creeping up her lips.

“It was actually really fun,” she admitted. “She got me that new artbook I showed you, and this card with the dumbest joke in existence on it.”

She chuckled slightly at that, watching Scorpia perk up as she did.

“Then Adora bought us way too much food, we went to the arcade and played games, got drunk.She dragged me into a photo booth, something about getting a memento of the night, and there was this kid outside with an airhorn? You should have seen her face when the kid blew it, she jumped like 3 feet in the air-”

“There.”

Catra paused at Scorpia’s interruption. She sat on the now made bed, watching Scorpia intently.

“There what? What are you talking about?”

Scorpia shrugged.

“There’s just something different about you. Whenever you talk about Adora, or whenever you’re around her, something changes in a good way.”

“Haven’t found the word yet?”

Scorpia shook her head, but the smile didn’t falter.

“Not yet. But I’ll figure it out soon.”

“Is there any hot chocolate left?”

Angella turned from the stove.Her eyes softened,smiling slightly as she saw her daughter standing in the hallway. Clad in baggy pyjamas and hair fluffed out, Angella could almost pretend she was still a child.

“You have perfect timing, it’s just finished,” she hummed, turning off the heat and retrieving two mugs from the overhead cupboard. “Marshmallows are in their usual place.”

The sight of Glimmer's smile warmed Angella's heart, watching her toddle towards the pantry and retrieve the already opened bag of marshmallows.

"Gotta check they're still good," Glimmer hummed, popping one into her mouth. Angella rolled her eyes; Micah had taught her that trick when she was only small. Glimmer had done it ever since.

A silence fell over the pair, Angella skillfully pouring the hot chocolate from the pan into the two mugs and Glimmer popping two marshmallows into each.

"Thanks," Glimmer mumbled, taking the mug her mother handed her and taking a small sip, humming in delight.

"Is it good?" Angella asked, clutching her own mug between her palms.

"Yummy as always," Glimmer hummed, taking another sip before setting it on the bench. "How's all the work stuff going?"

Angella sighed, taking a quick sip from her mug.

"It's...tedious," she admitted. "It's a lot to organise and the lecturers, bless their heart, are trying their best to get everything sorted by the end of break. But, from where I am, there's only so much I can do."

Glimmer nodded briefly, taking a sip from her hot chocolate once more.

"Bow says hello," she mentioned before the silence grew too long. "He invited us around for game night, apparently the dads miss you."

Glimmer watched her mother smile softly, the first in a while.

"I think that would be lovely," Angella mused. "Tell George and Lance I miss them terribly as well. How has Bow been?"

"Good! I think he might be taking up archery again," Glimmer started. "He, Adora and I had a late night chat a while back, and he brought up missing it. I think I'm gonna get him a membership for the range for Christmas, try get him back into it."

Angella's smile deepend.

"That's very thoughtful of you, Glimmer. I won't be working too much tomorrow, so if you like we could head over there that afternoon and get it sorted for him."

Glimmer found herself smiling, just a touch. Talks with her mother like this, late at night and reminiscing on the simple things, made

her realise how much she missed these moments when she went without them.

"That'd be nice," she admitted softly.

"He certainly isn't the scrawny boy from down the road anymore, is he?"

Glimmer thought back to a night she thought the exact same thing. Bright lights surrounding them, chests pressed together, his warm hands holding the small of her back and his breath ghosting across her lips.

"Definitely not," she mumbled into her mug. Angella was silent for a moment, watching the pink dust across Glimmer's cheeks. She raised an eyebrow, and mirrored Glimmer's movements, taking a sip from her own mug.

"Hey, Mom?" Glimmer started. "How did...When did you know you had feelings for Dad?"

Angella paused, glimpsing down at the rings on her left hand, smiling sadly.

"When I asked my closest friend when she knew she was in love," Angella responded.

Glimmer's heart dropped. This was bad; *really* bad. The one person in the world she couldn't have, and she had to go catch feelings for him. She had spent the entire term burying it under the stress and demands of university, the debate team, even going back to gymnastics training to keep her mind of the feelings she felt creeping up. But they were still here, and Glimmer couldn't shake them.

"We danced around it for a while," Angella continued, snapping Glimmer from her spiralling internal monologue. "And I had a feeling he felt the same before he told me. But even after he did, we were always the best of friends first, and partners second. Like you and Bow."

"I don't have a crush on-"

"Glimmer, I've known you your entire life," the woman interrupted. "I know your lying ticks. Besides, I figured if it was going to be anyone you would catch feelings for, it would be him."

Glimmer was silent, staring at the bottom of her empty mug, the weight of a question starting to drown her.

"But what if he doesn't feel the same?"

Angella set down her mug, walking towards her daughter and gently setting her hands on her shoulders.

"You'll never know until you say something," she started, bending down to meet her daughter's eyes. "That's the wonder of falling in love, Glimmer. The moment you confess feels like the end of the world, but as soon as there's an answer, you start all over again with that person. Either as friends or something more."

Glimmer looked up, seeing her mother's comforting eyes and feeling her heart rising up into her throat.

"Gods, this is terrifying," she laughed humorlessly, feeling her eyes begin to sting. She couldn't lose Bow, she couldn't, she *wouldn't* .

"It always will be, my dear," Angella assured her. "But it will always work out alright as well."

Glimmer's heart stayed tucked in her throat, but she didn't mind as much now. With her mother's arms wrapped around her, the ghost of a kiss on her forehead and hot chocolate in her belly, she didn't feel as hopeless anymore.

side effects

Chapter Summary

> "Catra?"
>
> "Don't sound so happy to hear me," Catra's voice chuckled through her headphones. "What's going on, blondie? You okay?"
> ---
> Scorpia sat in front of her laptop, hands clasped together and staring at the screen. This felt wrong.

12:37am.

It was at least an hour after Adora was usually dead to the world. But that, apparently, was not the case tonight. Adora lay wide awake on her bed, the only sound she could hear being the faint buzzing of the heater, keeping her room tolerable on the winter night. Her entire body ached. Even while laying down, she felt a faint stabbing in her hips, in the middle of her spine, her entire back stiffening and spasming whenever she least expected it. She'd go to the doctor soon.

The house was too quiet, and Adora could feel herself starting to spiral. Hope was asleep, and she didn't think she would be able to handle her grandmother's incoherent rants this late and night, and Mara never talked back.

She needed to talk to someone.

Unplugging her phone, Adora went through her contacts.

Glimmer: Last online 1 hour ago

Bow: Last online 3 hours ago

Catra: Online

"What's Catra doing awake?" Adora mumbled to herself. Catra was a self proclaimed night owl, claiming to love the time on her own, without any responsibilities or expectations. It was just herself and her time. Adora felt guilty for intruding on that time, especially since it was so late. What if she was just about to go to bed? What if she wasn't feeling good?

A smaller voice inside Adora whispered, *what's the worst that could happen?*

In a way, it was right. The worst that could happen was Catra didn't pick up the phone, and Adora tried listening to another podcast. Maybe Catra was grumpy with Adora for a little while, but she could never seem to stay mad at the blonde for very long for some reason. It was, at least, worth a shot.

Here goes nothing.

She tapped on the photograph of Catra, opening her contact and typing. Then deleted. Then typed out another message and deleted that too. Eventually, she sighed, and managed to actually send a message.

[Message from: Blondie 🏋️‍♀️ ♀️]

hey, are you awake?

[Message from: Catra 🖤]

no i’m sleep texting u

[Message from: Blondie 🏋️‍♀️ ♀️]

hilarious

[Message from: Catra 🖤]

I am, should go into comedy

anyway

what’s up? this is late for u

[Message from: Blondie 🏋️‍♀️ ♀️]

this stupid house is too quiet

and i’ve already listened to all my podcasts

so here we are

[Message from: Catra 🖤]

have you got your little nightmare bag?

[Message from: Blondie 🏋️‍♀️ ♀️]

yeah, but it's not from nightmares

I just can't sleep

[Incoming call from: Catra 🖤]

Adora's eyes widened as the notification popped up on screen, fumbling with the phone for a second before thanking her past self for popping her headphones in and answering.

"Catra?"

"Don't sound so happy to hear me," Catra's voice chuckled through her headphones. *"What's going on, blondie? You okay?"*

Adora exhaled, taking a moment to get her thoughts together.

“It’s just weird being back home,” she admitted. “I mean, obviously a lot has changed, but it just doesn’t feel like home. At least, not right now I guess.”

“I’m right there with you there,” Catra hummed through the phone. *“I’ve just moved into Scorpia’s place today.”*

“I remember you telling me about that, how did it go?”

Adora heard Catra chuckle once over the phone, and her body felt a little lighter.

“It was good, kinda weird. Both of her mums are nice enough, but you can smell the pity from a mile away."

Adora furrowed her eyebrows. "Pity?"

She could hear Catra sigh over the phone, but the artist started talking before Adora could take back her question.

"Yep. Ex foster kid that was borderline homeless showed up on their doorstep, so they’re making a point to be extra nice to be right now. I didn't wanna say anything to Scorpia though, we ended up just talking about Perfuma the whole night. She's so smitten."

Adora’s eyebrows furrowed, glancing down at her phone as if Catra was sitting next to her. "Wait. Scorpia and Perfuma are a thing?"

Silence sounded from Catra’s side of the call for a moment, before the sound of squeaking laughter trickled through Adora’s headphones. Adora’s smile deepened, even as her confusion at the situation increased. *Gosh, Catra’s laugh was so nice.*

“Of course they are, dummy!” Catra managed amidst laughter. *“How did you not know?!”*

“I don’t know!” Adora defended, unable to help the faint chuckle that escaped, flopping her head back onto the pillow. “But like, are they officially together? You have to tell me now!”

“Alright, chill out, I’ll tell you,” Catra chuckled. *“Buckle up for this one, blondie. This is wild.”*

Scorpia sat in front of her laptop, hands clasped together and staring at the screen. Her heart alternated between rising up into her throat and dropping down into her stomach, her forcibly slow breathing doing little to calm her racing pulse. This felt wrong.

The whole reason she was going to university was so she could take over her mothers' company. Black Garnet Industries had been in the Stevenson family for generations. Gemstones of every size, shape, colour and kind were dug out from mines with her family name on it, into warehouses where they were cut, polished and sold to suppliers across the country. All of that was waiting for Scorpia. And yet here she was, staring at the Etheria University help page, cursor hovering over a link.

How to change my major

Knock knock knock

"Scorpia?"

Lightning fast, Scorpia hid her recent search with another open tab, hearing her mother's voice outside her bedroom door.

"Come in," she said. Scorpia somehow managed to keep her trembling voice steady, turning in her chair to face the opening door and watching her mother step through the doorway.

"Hey, Ma," Scorpia greeted, shoulders relaxing a little. Maeve, pyjamas covering her tall, broad frame, met Scorpia's eyes and smiled warmly.

“Hey, little one,” she hummed, leaning against the door frame. “You’re up late, is everything alright?”

Scorpia swallowed down the truth, and nodded.

“Yeah, just couldn’t sleep,” she muttered. “What about you?”

Maeve’s smile deepened a little, rolling her eyes fondly.

“Your mother’s come down with a sore throat. Probably from all those meetings at work today,” she explained. “I’m making warm milk and honey. Then I saw your light on up here, so I thought I’d come check on you, see if you wanted anything.”

Scorpia couldn’t fight the small smile, shaking her head slightly.

“Nah, I’m alright. I’ll probably head to bed now,” she reasoned. “But thanks, Ma.”

Maeve gave a single nod, pushing off from the door frame, and walking towards Scorpia.

“Get some rest, okay?” the older woman hummed, pressing a gentle kiss to her crown. “We’re both really proud of you, little

one.”

Scorpia mumbled a ‘thank you’ under her breath, watching her mother retreat out of her room.

“Love you,” Maeve whispered, slowly closing the door behind her.

“Love you too.”

With the door closed safely behind her, Scorpia let out a long exhale, turning back to the laptop and opening the tab she was just looking at moments prior. The same link stared Scorpia down.

Grabbing the mouse, she brought the cursor to the furthest right corner, and clicked.

“Okay, okay, back the heck up,” Adora managed through her laughter, her voice sounding through the headphones. *“Your real name isn’t Catra?!”*

“I mean, it is now that I’ve changed it. But no, I wasn’t born with that name,” Catra replied, rolling her eyes. For as intelligent as Adora was, she really could be dense sometimes.

"So what was your birth name?!"

Catra smirked, seeing a perfect opportunity to mess with her friend.

"Jeez, blondie," she drawled. "That's private information, at least buy me dinner first."

Adora went silent for a solid 30 seconds before Catra couldn't hold in her laughter any longer. She could already picture the blonde, cheeks as red as her jacket and covering her mouth with her hand, eyes wide like dinner plates, and- when did Catra's cheeks get so warm? She better not be getting sick.

"I-I mean, I bought you dumplings!" the blonde tried. *"That was dinner, that counts! Come on, pleaseeeeeeeee-"*

"Alright!" she exclaimed through her laughter. "Alright, I'll tell you, but I'm not sure what you're expecting."

"Why the hell would I have expectations about this? I'm just curious, now hurry up and tell me already!"

Catra exhaled, eyes screwed shut and spitting the word out like the bad taste it left in her mouth.

“Catarina.”

Adora went silent again.

“Lame, huh?” she tried, the silent beginning to choke her.

“I didn’t know you could roll your r’s like that,” Adora admitted, sounding almost breathless?

“Well, yeah,” Catra started. “Latina family apparently. Dropped me at Weaver’s with a note all in Spanish, which basically translated to ‘please take care of our Catarina’. That, and I took Spanish in high school.”

“Let me guess, so you could swear at people without them knowing?”

Catra couldn’t help but grin.

“That would be correct,” she admitted. “But when I got to Weaver's, I got lumped in the same room as the younger kids, they couldn’t say my name properly, so it got shortened to Catra. Sister Zy- the warden still called me Catarina, cuz she knew it pissed me off. The day I turned 18, I snuck out and got it legally

changed. You should have seen the look on her face when I whipped that baby out."

"Well, Catra suits you much better," Adora hummed through the phone. *"Do you still remember much in Spanish?"*

Catra's grin shifted into a smirk.

"Por supuesto que sí, tonta."

"Ooookay, that's definitely a yes then, and why do I feel you insulted me just then?"

Catra let out a single chuckle. "Relax, blondie. Not everything I say in Spanish is an insult."

"Prove it then!"

The artist could hear Adora's smile from here, and the room somehow felt a little warmer, even in the early hours of the winter morning.

"Me gusta tu sonrisa."

Adora paused before finally telling Catra, *"That last word kinda sounded like 'sunrise' so I'm gonna give you the benefit of the doubt on that one."*

Catra rolled her eyes, letting out a soft sigh. That word, in fact, did not mean 'sunrise' but she couldn't help but find the notion endearing. Platonically, obviously.

"Giving anyone the benefit of the doubt sounds like a bad idea."

Catra heard Adora snicker quietly to herself, and the artist was instantly curious.

"My grandmother learned that one pretty quickly when I was a kid."

"No way," Catra started. "Goody two-shoes Adora, a rebel child? Who would've guessed!"

"Okay, that was kinda misleading , " Adora interjected. *"It's honestly not even that bad."*

"Alright, maybe not, but you still have to tell me now."

The artist heard Adora sigh over the phone, before quiet snickers accompanied the athlete's words.

"First of all, I was like 3 when this happened. Nana Razz was babysitting me one day, and she has the worst habit of putting something down and forgetting where she put it. So, it got to midday, and in the 20 minutes she spent looking for where she had put my food, I had eaten an entire jar of peanut butter."

Catra had no idea what to expect, but it sure as hell was not that.

"You did not."

"I did. Me and my tiny hands ate the entire jar. My mum called me peanut ever since."

"Hold on, 'peanut'? That was your nickname?" Catra asked, an easy smile on her lips and one eyebrow crooked. "I figured it was gonna be 'princess' or something like that."

"I mean, it was for a while," the blonde admitted through a yawn. A laugh rose in Catra's throat at the confession.

"Oh my god, of course it was!" Catra teased. "What did you do to get that one? Binge watch princess movies or-"

"I broke a girl's nose in a princess dress."

It was Catra's turn to be silent. She had no idea why her cheeks were so warm after hearing that, but she blamed it on the blanket she was tucked underneath.

"Like, on purpose or-"

"Yes? I mean, no! Kinda?" Adora cried through the phone. *"Okay, let me explain. I think I was around 6 or 7, and the school I was at had an athletics carnival, and for some stupid reason they gave it a fantasy theme and you had to dress up."*

"You, obviously, went as a princess," Catra butt in.

"Yeah, because I couldn't find a knight costume that fit me in time," Adora explained, yawning halfway through. *"Anyway. Went in a bunch of races, won every single one, in said princess dress."*

"Weird flex, but alright," Catra joked, revelling in the sleepy laugh she heard from Adora's end.

"Thanks, I guess? Either way, after my last race, some girl grabbed me by my hair, started dragging me to a teacher and yelling that I had cheated in all my races."

“How the hell do you cheat in a *child’s* running race?”

“Beats me!” Adora replied. *“So she’s dragging me along, I’m mildly freaking out and started swinging my arms around so she’d let go of me. She starts yanking me harder, so I sock her in the nose. Apparently, I hit harder than I thought and broke her nose.”*

Catra had tried not to laugh. She really, truly, had genuinely tried not to laugh. It didn’t work.

“Baby Adora was ballsy!” Catra exclaimed, trying to rein in her laughter to no avail. “You straight up just decked a kid in the face! I’m not gonna lie, I’m actually kinda impressed.”

“This does not mean I condone violence,” Adora drawled. She finally sounded tired, prompting Catra to check the time on her phone.

2:11am.

“Hey, it’s getting pretty late,” Catra started. “You should probably get some sleep.”

The next words caught Catra off guard.

"But I don't wanna stop talking to you yet."

Catra ignored the way her heart raced at the statement, searching her sleep-addled brain for some kind of compromise so Adora was at least somewhat functioning tomorrow.

"Then I'll stay on the phone with you."

"You'd do that?"

The artist couldn't help but smile at how relieved Adora sounded.

"Yeah," she admitted. "But not because I like you or anything, I just don't wanna deal with grumpy Adora tomorrow."

Adora chuckled softly, and Catra could make out the rustling of bedsheets.

"It's alright," she started, pausing mid yawn before starting again. *"I won't tell anyone that you've gone soft."*

Catra didn't know how to reply, instead settling for getting comfortable in her new bed, listening to the faint breathing through her headphones. An odd sense of peace fell over her, and with a bit of luck, maybe she'd actually be able to sleep tonight.

"Goodnight, Catra," Adora whispered.

Catra waited until she heard Adora's breathing even out, and until soft snores echoed in her ears before she replied.

"G'night, princess."

mariposa

Chapter Summary

> "Missed you, bestie," Glimmer mumbled into his shirt. Bow's stomach felt weird at those words, but he couldn't place if it was in a good way or bad.
> ---
> “Took you long enough to show up,” Catra drawled without looking up, knowing exactly who it was.

The few weeks of Winter break, and the holidays they contained, sped by in the blink of an eye. And once the rowdiness of the New Year had come and passed, it was time for the self proclaimed ‘Best Friend Squad’ to move back into their shared dorm.

💖 **Best Friend Squad** 💖

bow: how far away are you two??

glimmer: mom and I just parked now

we’re gonna be there in like a couple mins

see you soon!!!

adora: hope and I just left home

I’ll see you both in about 10

@bow , Scorpia and Catra are already there

in case you two get bored

glimmer: i mean i'm gonna be there asdfghjk

but how did you know they're there??

bow: ^^^^^

adora: cuz I was talking to Catra...?

why do you sound so surprised

At that moment, Bow heard rattling behind the door to their dorm room, along with the muffled voice of Glimmer. Bow, grinning, moved to open said door.

"Welcome back Glim-"

The words became trapped in Bow's throat, seeing how Glimmer had changed over the winter break.

She cut her hair. It must have been freshly dyed when she did it too, the bright colours bringing light into the partly empty dorm room. Instead of the usual bounce and poof of her hair, it was tamed and swept over to one side. She looked beautiful.

“You okay?” she asked, voice like sherbet.

“Uhh- I- yeah! You got your hair cut!” Bow exclaimed. “Why didn’t you post a photo in the group chat?”

Glimmer shrugged as best she could, with her bag slung over her shoulder.

“I wanted to see if people were going to realise,” she admitted, heading through the door and setting her bag down near her usual bed. “I think it was time for a change, you know?”

Bow softened, smiling warmly and walking over to her. She unzipped her bag, turning when Bow approached her and holding her arms out wide.

“Now, where’s my hug?!” she teased.

Bow’s smile shifted into a wide grin, pulling her into his chest, her arms snaking around his waist as his circled her shoulders.

Heck, had she always smelt this nice? Her shampoo was still the same, Bow could tell as his nose buried into her bright hair. She was warm, soft. Was this new, or was Bow just as oblivious as Ado-

"Missed you, bestie," Glimmer mumbled into his shirt. Bow's stomach felt weird at those words, but he couldn't place if it was in a good way or bad. Probably just flattered to be her best friend or something. Right?

"Missed you too," he settled on. The moment was gone too quickly, Glimmer pulling away from their hug.

"Once Adora's here and unpacked, can we go get ramen? I'm starving."

Bow grinned wickedly, and Glimmer noticed immediately.

"Don't you d-"

"Nice to meet you, starving. I'm Bow- Ouch!"

Bow clutched the freshly pinched skin of his arm, unable to stifle his laughter.

"This is what happens when you go home for break! You just come back fully armed with Dad jokes."

"Glimmer, what do you expect?" Bow started, raising an eyebrow. "I literally have two dads. We basically communicate with dad jokes."

The woman snickered under her breath, beginning to unpack one of her bags.

“It’s basically a second language at this point,” she started. “Next test we do, when we have to declare if we speak any extra languages, I dare you to put down ‘dad jokes’.”

“What’s this about dad jokes?”

It was at that moment that Glimmer and Bow realised that the door was still wide open, doorway inviting in any guest that may have walked past. A doorway that Adora now stood in.

“Adora!” Bow cried, moving over to their last roommate and scooping her up into a hug. The blonde’s strong arms wound around his frame, and Bow could feel the moment when Glimmer wrapped her arms around both of them.

“Oh jeez- guys, I was only gone for a couple of weeks!” Adora chuckled, but adjusted her arms to wrap around the both of them.

“We just missed you! Cut us some slack, will you?” Glimmer murmured into Adora’s jacket. As their arms unfurled from one

another, the two childhood friends noticed how the newest addition to their crew had changed over the winter break. The usual ponytail and the hair poof was still there, but an undercut had been shaved away the bottom few layers. Her signature jacket hadn't budged, neither had the sword pendant around her neck. The circles under her eyes were new.

"Hey, are you alright?" Bow asked cautiously, watching Adora's face. Her smile wasn't as wide as it used to be.

"Hmm? Oh! Yeah," the blonde assured him. "Just haven't slept well the past few nights, that's all."

The two hadn't known Adora anywhere near as long as they had known each other, but they knew one thing for certain; Adora was a terrible liar.

They cast each other a quick look, letting Adora enter their room and set down her things. There wasn't anything they could do, for now at least.

"I like the new hair!" Bow piped up. "It's very you."

"Not entirely sure what that means, but thank you?" Adora responded, unzipping her bag and beginning to pile clothes into the drawers of the closet.

“I mean, raging lesbian is the first guess I can think of,” Glimmer mused.

Adora turned from the closet, raising a single eyebrow before turning back to the closet.

“Oh. Okay then.”

Bow and Glimmer stared at each other, visible confusion on their faces. Adora had never disclosed her sexuality to them, but clearly knew a lot about the queer ccommunity. Her adoptive mother was in a relationship with another woman, she always asked for pronouns when meeting new people, and even cuffed her jeans. For Adora to not have had said anything was odd.

“You don’t know?” Bow asked under his breath, but apparently it was loud enough for Adora to hear it.

“Know what? If I like women?”

“Well, yeah,” Glimmer started. “Like, attraction is a different experience for everyone, if you experience it at all, but I guess we were curious.”

Adora closed the closet door, moving back to sit on her bed. "Honestly, I just haven't thought about it," she admitted. "There was always something else going on for me to really sit down and think about it, let alone have a crush on someone.But I do know that I'm demi."

"'Demi'?"

"Demisexual," Bow offered. "It's when you only have sexual attraction to people you have an emotional connection with. It falls on the ace spectrum."

"How did you know that?" Adora asked.

"One of my brothers is demi," he explained. "Also, you do remember that Glimmer and I are part of the Queer-Straight Alliance, right?"

Adora's face went blank.

"So that's where you go on Thursday nights."

"Uh, duh! Bow and I are the resident bi disasters!"

"Okay, *you* are the resident bi disaster. I can actually function, believe it or not," Bow defended.

"If we're gonna argue about all of this stuff, can we please go get some food? I've been craving ramen from the Jasmine Dragon for weeks and I'm starving!"

Adora smirked.

"Nice you meet you, starving. I'm Adora."

Adora barely dodged the hairbrush Glimmer pegged at her, the laughter from Room 11 echoing down the hallway.

Catra exhaled deeply, back flat against her usual spot at the bleachers. Genuinely, she was fond of her roommates. But as the sun began to set, she craved the peace she found in the afternoon silence, alone in the abandoned field as the winter wid. Well, alone with someone. It hadn't snowed much at all this winter, the crunching of the grass in the empty field giving away that someone was approaching.

"Took you long enough to show up," Catra drawled without looking up, knowing exactly who it was.

“Nice to see you too!” Adora retorted. Catra could hear the smile without even seeing her face. “I see you haven’t changed over break.”

“Does anyone change that quickly?” the artist drawled, hauling herself into a sitting position, the rest of her words dying in her throat as she saw Adora.

Her usual ponytail and that stupid hair poof had been discarded. Instead, the top half had been pulled back and tied into a loose bun, the rest falling down around her collar. Her jacket had been zipped up, hands shoved into her pockets with a bag’s straps in her elbow and a warm smile greeting Catra. She was beautiful.

“Earth to Catra?”

The blonde’s voice snapped her out of whatever *that* was, Catra recovering with an easy smirk.

“I see you got rid of the hair poof,” she drawled, enjoying the way Adora sighed and rolled her eyes in response.

“I just have it down so my neck doesn’t get cold!” she defended, sitting next to Catra on the bleachers, and hoisting the hair off her neck, turning away from Catra. “See?”

Surely enough, the underside had been shaved short, and suddenly the mental image of Adora, hair tied up and undercut on show, looming over her, became a lot more pleasant- wait, *what?*

"I see," Catra mumbled, a finger darting up to card through the shortened hair. She only just heard the hitching of Adora's breath over the wind. Drawing her hand away, she gave Adora what she hoped was a casual smile.

"It suits you," she hummed. "It'll be good once it starts warming up again."

Adora groaned dramatically, looking up to the sky. "I literally can't wait. I hate winter so much."

"Why?"

Adora shrugged in reply. "It's just never been my favourite. Everything is so cold, and a lot of the flowers start dying. The only good thing about winter is hot chocolate."

"Well, yeah hot chocolate is good," Catra started. "But consider this; snow days. You literally get told to stay home all day, which means unlimited naps."

Adora scoffed, digging her elbow into Catra's side.

“Of course you would find an excuse to sleep all day,” she teased.

“Hey, I already have the only excuse I need for constantly napping?”

“Which is?”

Catra gave a half hearted attempt at jazz hands, simply stating, “Depression.”

Adora’s smile became a frown instantly.

“Catra,” she breathed. “I am so sorry, I didn’t realise-”

“Dude, chill. It’s fine,” Catra interjected, staring out at the empty field.

Adora was silent for what felt like forever, but was probably only a few minutes.

“You know, you can always talk to me about stuff. If you want to.”

Catra barely heard the mumble, turning to see Adora's warm smile looking back at her. She mustered a smirk, returning the earlier nudge to Adora's side.

"Sorry, Princess. You've gotta be at least a level 5 friend to unlock my tragic backstory," she drawled.

"Well, what level am I at right now?"

Baby blue eyes were wide and curious, a grin twitching at her lips with all of her attention focused on Catra, and her chest was fluttering.

"Not telling."

"Aw, come on!" Adora cried, throwing her arms up in mock protest. "Can't you just tell me? Pleaseeeeee?"

"You can pout all you like, I'm still not telling you," Catra managed.

The blonde gave a final huff, slouching with an almost cartoonish pout.

“Fine, I’ll just ask Scorpia or something,” she grumbled under her breath.

Catra chuckled lightly, Adora mirroring it as the artist’s hand came up to ruffle honey coloured hair, brushing the skin of her neck.

“Jesus, you’re freezing,” she murmured, the sharp contrast of Adora’s skin to hers not being something she expected.

“Uh, yeah. How are you not cold?!”

“Call it thick skin,” she answered, holding out her arm for a side hug. “Scooch in.”

A few months ago, the mere thought of hugging someone voluntarily made Catra’s stomach rise into her throat. Touch in general was never a strong suit of her. But for reasons she couldn’t quite place, she felt safe doing this with the blonde. Adora eyed her for a moment, before shuffling across the seat and wrapping an arm behind Catra’s waist, resting her head on the artist’s shoulder. The brunette’s arm splayed across Adora’s back, hand moving to the back of her neck to fiddle with the shaved hair.

“You like the undercut, huh?” Adora asked, and Catra didn’t need to look to know she was smirking.

“It’s better than that stupid hair poof,” she teased. “Is it a history major thing or something?”

Adora stilled for a moment, leaning further into Catra’s shoulder, arm tightening a fraction around her waist.

“I changed majors,” she admitted in a whisper. Catra glanced down at her, seeing baby blue downcast onto the field. Why did shame stain the colour?

“What to?”

“Physiotherapy.”

Catra’s lips raised in the ghost of a smile.

“Give your competition a harder opponent once you go back?”

Adora shook her head.

“I was going to do a double major when I started,” she admitted. “But after Mum passed, I didn’t think it would be a good idea. And I love history, but I can't see myself working in it. And going into physio means I might be able to figure out what’s happening to my body.”

Catra frowned, bending to try to meet Adora’s gaze.

“The pain still hasn’t gone away?”

Adora shook her head once more, and Catra’s stomach dropped.

"It comes and goes most days. But it's always worse after training, and I've had to slow down so much. Heck, my whole back aches just trying to hold myself upright sometimes."

"Meds aren't helping?" Catra asked.

"Not as much as I would like. It's not worth destroying my liver for how little it helps."

Catra gave a soft smile. "Bugger, you could have joined the 'Destroyed Livers' gang. I was gonna make t-shirts and everything."

Adora snorted at the comment, and the artist could immediately breathe easier.

"You're such a dork, Catra," she chuckled, nestling further into her neck. "As soon as I get better, I'm going to kick your butt."

Catra tentatively rested her head on Adora's, relaxing when the blonde hummed softly at the contact.

"Looking forward to it, Princess."

generation why

Chapter Summary

> “Another party?”
> ---
> “You have a weird definition of fun.”
>
> “I mean, it beats watching Sparkles and Crop Top make heart eyes at each other.”

Chapter Notes

> stim warning! Entrapta briefly stims during the middle of the chapter, please be mindful if you are prone to stims to not damage yourself or anything you own. also, all characters are over the drinking age in this AU, and alcohol is mentioned x

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Another party?”

Adora had found the flyer taped to the door of Room 11, managing to find the day amongst all the bright colours and patterns on the page. In a weird case of luck or misfortune, it was that night.

“They’re not holding it on campus this time,” Bow mumbled to himself, hands clutching the page and scanning through. “It’s at a bar, right in the city too. Anyone have any ideas why the Student Council changed their minds?”

Glimmer glanced over Bow's shoulder to see the name of the bar; *The Whispering Woods* . It wasn't the fanciest bar in town by any means, but it was one that the university students knew, home to generous student discounts, a never ending stream of fairy lights, and an unnecessarily large dance floor with dancing colours.

"Next time we go dancing, can it be somewhere with a bit more space?"

"Deal."

Glimmer shook her head in response.

"No idea."

"Well, are we wanting to go?" Adora asked the pair, the three roommates looking amongst each other.

"Sure," Bow started, fixing his gaze on the blonde. "Gotta drown away my sorrows for being left alone in history somehow."

"I already said I was sorry!" she cried in response.

“I wasn’t even the first one you told, Adora!” Bow exclaimed, with clearly dramatised heartbreak.

“Hey, at least she told you,” Glimmer piped up from the desk, looking up from her notes and glancing at Bow beside her. “Wanna know I found out Adora had changed majors? Through Catra. Catra! Of all people!”

“Since when do you talk to Catra?”

Bow had asked the question before Adora could, but the blonde was visibly more attentive now that it was in the open.

“Since Mrs Spinner brought up trying to drag her into the debate team,” Glimmer told them. “She asked me to go talk to her, I said the word ‘debate’ once and we were off topic before I even knew it. And she called me ‘Sparkles’ the whole time.”

The blonde stifled a laugh under her breath. “Yeah, that sounds like Catra.”

“Anyways,” Bow started again. “I think a night out before the semester officially starts would do us all some good. And no, Glimmer, you’re not staying behind to work on your debate notes. Gods know you need a break just as much as the rest of us.”

Glimmer huffed quietly, closing her book and standing from her desk.

"Fine, but you owe me a dance, Bow," she told him with a smile more confident than she felt.

She watched his eyes widen, before his face fell into that smile that made her heart race.

"As if you even need to ask," he hummed. "I'm gonna ask Room 26 if they're coming."

Glimmer raised an eyebrow. "Who do you know from that room?"

"That's Catra's room," Adora piped up, watching Bow curiously. "I didn't know you two talked."

"I don't talk to Catra. She's actually terrifying," Bow admitted, taking out his phone. "But I do talk to Scorpia, mostly about the QSA but still. And Entrapta is kind of weird, but they're cool."

"Well, if Scorpia comes then surely Perfuma will as well," Glimmer told them. "Aren't those two dating?"

“Apparently, not yet,” Adora said. “But does it really matter? This kind of stuff isn’t a race, right?”

Bow sighed. “No, but-”

“You haven’t had to watch them give each other heart eyes from across the table at literally every QSA meeting for the past 2 months,” Glimmer grumbled. “I’m just saying, we’ll get a lot more done when those two aren’t constantly oogling each other.”

Adora watched Glimmer, tilting her head. “What even is ‘oogling’?”

Bow resisted the urge to face palm, while Glimmer burst into laughter.

“Oh, Adora, you’re so innocent.”

“I am not! I have an undercut!”

The laughter only grew.

“Not up for dancing?”

Adora felt the warm breath brush the shell of her ear, her heart rate spiking even after she recognised the voice.

“I am, unfortunately my body isn’t,” Adora mumbled, shifting further along in the booth so Catra could sit next to her. The artist slid into place beside her, their thighs resting together, with one of Catra's hands placing down a glass of bourbon on the table.

“Bad pain day?” Catra asked simply, earning a nod from Adora. She went quiet for a moment, looking from her bourbon back to her friend. “Is there anything you need?”

Adora shook her head, leaning back into the booth and giving Catra a smile.

“Don’t worry about me, go have some fun!”

Catra nodded in response, but didn’t move. Adora crooked an eyebrow.

“I am having fun,” Catra shrugged, reaching for her glass and bringing it to her lips. She never took her eyes off Adora.

Adora chuckled quietly, rolling her eyes.

“You have a weird definition of fun.”

Catra gave a half hearted shrug, downing the rest of her glass.

“I mean, it beats watching Sparkles and Crop Top make heart eyes at each other.”

“Bow and Glimmer?”

“Same thing,” Catra hummed. “For real though, what’s their deal? Are they dating?”

Adora shrugged, looking out onto the dance floor and spotting her roommates covered in the colours.

Glimmer’s heart ran like a bullet train, feeling Bow’s warm hand on the small of her back. Their free fingers were intertwined, hands and bodies pushing and pulling, twisting around each other and coming back together in time with every beat.

“You're not stepping on my feet this time,” Bow muttered over the booming music, breath brushing over the shell of Glimmer’s ear.

“I’m impressed.”

She looked up at him, lips pulling back in a smirk. “I’m barely getting started.”

The music around them changed, the beat racing as the two moved in tandem. The lights, the chatter and laughter around them, even the music seemed to fade into the background of Bow’s focus. All he could see was Glimmer.

Her hand was warm and soft in his, fingers intertwined effortlessly. With every spin, he caught the faint scent of her perfume wafting through the air. Whatever song was playing didn’t come close to being as beautiful as her laugh. The racing in his chest wasn’t new, but the look in her eyes was, somewhere between coy and challenging, just like the smirk on those dusty pink lips.

He draws his arm back towards his chest, Glimmer following suit. Their hands slipped away. Glimmer closed the distance between them, her hands catching themselves on his shoulders as she looked up at him.

“You okay?” he heard from her over the booming of the music. Bow nodded, his hands resting the small of her back.

“Are you?” he asked. Her smirk shifted into a soft smile, nodding back up at him. Even as the pace of the songs shifted again, neither Bow or Glimmer moved from where they were.

The gravity keeping them close grew stronger. Glimmer's hands slid up Bow's shoulders, cupping the nape of his neck and fiddling with the hairs that lay there. She watched the expression on his face change, only catching glimpses in the flashing light. His hands gripped her ever so slightly, pulling her to him until their chests were touching, faces even closer and their breath mixing in the space between them.

He was right there. Surely he could tell how close they were, but Bow didn't pull away. Their faces grew closer.

Glimmer raised onto her toes, Bow's warm hands holding her steady and pulling her even closer-

CRASH!

The sound of shattering glass echoed throughout the room, a shrieking heard from behind the bar. Dance partners across the floor bolted apart, eyes checking the ground for broken glass but finding nothing.

A bartender yelled out that everything was alright, but it was too late. Bow and Glimmer were already a metre apart.

The dancing lights illuminated the blank look of Bow's face, Glimmer barely making out what he was saying.

"Give me a second. Sorry."

Before Glimmer had a chance to reply, he darted off the floor and out of sight.

"So how exactly did you two meet?"

The navy haired woman groaned, gripping her drink before taking a large sip.

"He is *just* my ride, alright?" she groaned, looking to the purple haired scientist across the table from her. Entrapta their name was. At least, Mermista was pretty sure it was. They had met a grand total of once, after the scientist admitted themself to the university clinic covered in various burns and scars. That weird guy was with them as well.

Platinum hair and startling green eyes, he stood ramrod straight as Mermista’s date danced around him.

"His name is 'Sea Hawk', correct?" Entrapta asked, the pair of them watching him dancing around the green eyed man.

"Well, no, but that’s all he really responds to," Mermista admitted. "It's just a nickname."

Entrapta nodded, taking a sip out of an orange crazy straw.

"I don't understand the point of nicknames," Entrapta admitted. "Or why they exist."

Mermista quirked an eyebrow but nodded. "Uh, sure. They can be kind of dumb. Some are cool though, or whatever."

"Yes, but what is the point of replacing one name with another when they both serve the same purpose?" Entrapta asked. "A nickname means having to spread entirely new information, and those who it doesn't reach won't know, which could lead to miscommunication and-"

"Ugh, for Poseidon's sake, can you just drop it already?"

Entrapta went silent. Their eyes fell to their now empty glass, fiddling with the straw.

"I'm sorry," they mumbled, shifting to get up from the table.

"Wait, hold on."

Entrapta looked back, seeing Mermista watching them. They couldn't entirely read her face, but her expression seemed gentler somehow.

"You don't need to apologise, I do," she started. "It's been a rough week starting back at the clinic, and I used all my social energy dealing with patients."

Entrapta sat back down, head tilted slightly and listening intently.

"It's not an excuse, it's an explanation or whatever. So, I'm sorry I snapped at you, and that I'm not great at conversation."

The scientist smiled.

"Well, I'm not great at conversation either," they hummed. "Social cues aren't my strong suit, so I can ramble about things and not realise people want me to stop."

Mermista nodded, giving a slight smile.

"That's cool. I'll try to be more clear next time. Is there any cues that you have for me?"

Entrapta brightened, releasing their drink and holding their hands in a T shape.

"I'll do this when I get overwhelmed," they started before reaching for their drink. "That and being in loud places or feeling a lot means I tend to stim more, so try not to freak out-"

"Dude, it's chill," Mermista butt in. "Stimming is super common. It's literally just emotional regulation, you don't need to warn people about it."

Entrapta's smile somehow widened, their hands clasped in loose fists and waving happily.

"Thank you, Mermista," they hummed. "Do you wanna come get more drinks and tiny food?"

"I mean, sure- wait, where's Hugo and Sea Hawk?"

Sea Hawk had dragged Hugo to the middle of the dance floor, arms linked together and skipping in circles. Catra could hear at least one of the pair yelling sea shanties.

"Adora, look," she chuckled, nudging the blonde with her elbow and directing her gaze to the dance floor. She watched Adora's expression brighten, knowing the blonde could hear them singing.

"I think I've seen that guy before, the one with the moustache," she said. "Apparently his name is Sea Hawk? He comes into the clinic a lot when Mermista is working."

"Of course you're a regular there," Catra teased. "I've seen the other one before, Hugo. He's working with Entrapta on their project. Well, he hands them the tools and stuff."

Adora laughs under her breath, and the sound is warm and light over the pounding bass. The artist watched her and smiled.

"Where is Entrapta? I haven't seem them all night," Adora asked.

Catra paused, scanning the bar before spotting purple hair, and a bright orange crazy straw.

"Right there," she purred, gently grasping Adora’s chin and turning her head until she was facing them.

She watched Adora's sky eyes widen, grinning as she waved at Entrapta and Mermista from across the room, seeing the scientist wave back excitedly.

"Well, that explains why the two boys are together," the athlete hummed. "That just leaves Scorpia."

Catra simply shrugged.

"I'm not worried. Scorpia’s a big girl, and she wouldn't go far. Besides, I have a feeling she's not alone."

A quick scan of the room confirmed Catra's suspicions, spotting the lithe blonde stepping through the door leading outside of the bar.

"Scorpia?" Perfuma called, seeing the taller woman leaning on the brick wall of the building. She watched Scorpia turn her head in response, smiling warmly at the sight of Perfuma.

"Hey there," she hummed, pushing herself off the wall and walking towards the smaller woman. "How's the party going?"

"Not as fun without you in there," Perfuma admitted, cheeks tinting pink.

Scorpia paused, smile growing and mirroring the blush.

"Oh jeez," she mused under her breath. "That's really sweet of you to say."

Perfuma smiled, walking over to Scorpia and leaning against the wall beside her.

"I'm just telling the truth, no need to thank me."

Scorpia slotted herself beside Perfuma, weaving one arm around her lithe waist and pulling her to her side. The smaller woman turned red, leaning against Scorpia's shoulder.

"Is this o-"

"Yes, Scorpia," she assured the taller woman. "This is definitely okay."

Perfuma could feel Scorpia sigh in relief, leaning further into her warm embrace against the chill of the early spring night.

"Ready for this semester?" she asked.

"Absolutely not," Scorpia admitted with a laugh. "But I am definitely ready to hang out with you more, if you want to."

Perfuma paused, eyes fixed on the ground as she replied.

"I mean, I did ask if I could kiss you last semester. So, I do want to hang out with you more. But not just as friends."

The second before Scorpia replied was the longest of her life, broken by the sound of deep, melodic laughter.

"Oh, thank the Gods," she breathed. "I thought about it every day over break. About *you* ."

Perfuma looked up from the ground, turning her head to see Scorpia's deep eyes watching her own, a warm smile on soft lips.

"So, if you would like to," Scorpia started again. "We don't have to hang out as just friends. We could- I mean, you could hang out with me as my girlfriend?"

Perfuma’s heart fluttered, cheeks aching as she grinned.

"You want me to be your girlfriend?" she breathed.

Scorpia nodded.

"Yeah. And I wanna be your girlfriend. If you'll have me."

Perfuma stood on her toes, pressing a soft kiss to Scorpia’s cheek.

"I would love that."

Scorpia beamed, both hands moving to hold Perfuma’s hips, holding her steady and pulling her close.

"Well, *girlfriend* ," she started, pausing as both she and Perfuma chuckled quietly. "Can I kiss you?"

Perfuma responded and cradling Scorpia's cheeks and kissing her softly.

The sharp wind whipped around them, they both tasted of the fruit punch served at the party, and their lungs were beginning to ache as their lips connected over and over again.

But they were here, alone, in each other's arms and kissing each other slowly and sweetly.

It couldn't have been more perfect.

Chapter End Notes

just as a quick note, I myself am not autistic, and Entrapta's habits and behaviours are taken from my close friends and family that identify as autistic. if there is ANYTHING in Entrapta's interactions at any neurodivergent folk find offensive or inaccurate, please let me know so it can be changed x

hot rod

Chapter Summary

"Hello, Big Brother!"

Entrapta looked up, watching the figure emerge through the laboratory doors, the blinding light of the hallway surrounding his silhouette. When he finally came into view, the sight wasn't what Entrapta expected.

[Message from: Catra 🖤]
alright, so since tall bald lady didn't really give a explanation before she came and picked you up
mind giving me one?

Chapter Notes

tw; manipulation, transphobia, misgendering, touched (non-sexually) without consent, minor abuse
the above subjects are shown or mentioned briefly, but please read with caution and stay safe <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Entrapta, do you have the time?"

Entrapta set down their blowtorch, checking their watch and picking it back up again.

"It's 10:43."

Heath was silent for a moment, but Entrapta paid no mind and kept welding. *Emily's* wiring was almost finished, but they needed to finish this framework before they could start programming, even though Hordak had already made a head start on it-

"Entrapta, I do believe brother is trying to get your attention."

Frowning, Entrapta set down the blow torch, turning to see Heath standing next to the table clutching a mug.

"Heath?"

He didn't respond to Entrapta's question. Instead, he set down the mug next to them, with freshly brewed tea inside.

"It's late," he started, his voice low and quiet. "Have this. I'll pack up everything, then we can lock up for the night."

"But, I'm not tired-" Entrapta started, before ironically being cut off by their own yawn. Heath gave a single laugh, before turning back to the table and sorting through the chaos of scattered tools, Hugo at his side. They watched the two brothers, finding the pair fall into the pattern that Entrapta had created. The same order of which tools went away first, each into the same spot in Entrapta's toolkit, the same sheet draped over Emily in the same way. Entrapta watched the scene unfold, and smiled.

They were just at the bottom of their cup of tea, when Hugo broke the silence.

"Hello, Big Brother!"

'Big Brother'?

Entrapta looked up, watching the figure emerge through the laboratory doors, the blinding light of the hallway surrounding his silhouette. When he finally came into view, the sight wasn't what Entrapta expected.

The eldest brother, Hunter, looked eerily similar to Hugo. If Entrapta didn't know their difference in age, they could have easily mistaken them for twins. His eyes were the same bright green, but were as sharp as Hugo's were soft. They had the same platinum hair, but his was much longer, the top layer tied back into a bun while the rest flowed around his shoulders.

Hunter smiled, and Entrapta's stomach sank.

"Hello there, my little brother," he purred. From the corner of their eye, Entrapta watched Heath's once loose posture immediately stiffen at the simple words. Hunter had closed the gap between Hugo and himself, cradling the youngest brother's cheek in his palm. The student leaned into the touch of the businessman, with closed eyes and a beaming smile, and the stirring in Entrapta's stomach only grew.

“Ah, Brother,” Hunter started, releasing Hugo’s cheek. Burning green eyes drifted to Heath before falling on the figure next to him. “Who’s your new friend?”

Entrapta kept their gaze fixed on the ground ahead of them, feeling Heath shift a half step closer to them.

“I-I’m Entrapta,” they mumbled. Hunter’s steps grew closer and closer, a predator on the prowl. When he spoke again, his voice may as well have been inside Entrapta’s own head.

“Entrapta,” he started, his breath on the shell of their ear. “It’s extremely rude to not make eye contact when speaking to someone.”

They watched his hand rise to their chin, and Entrapta immediately recoiled.

“Don’t touch me.”

Hunter didn’t say anything for what felt like forever, but his feet didn’t shift at all.

“You should really teach your friends better manners, my brother,” he finally said, and it was clear that he wasn’t speaking to Hugo, but to Heath. “Starting with her-”

“They.”

Entrapta looked to their right, seeing Heath’s face out of the corner of their eye. His expression was set in stone, facing firmly forwards towards Hunter.

“That is not correct grammar, brother-”

“It is,” Heath interrupted. “Entrapta uses they/them pronouns. So don’t refer to them as ‘she’ or ‘her’.”

Hunter went silent once more, and Entrapta gathered enough guts to look up from the floor. Their gaze flicked between Heath and Hunter, back and forth, back and forth, when Hunter began to laugh.

“Oh, Heath,” he chuckled. “Trust you to make friends with the outcast.” He turned to walk away from the pair, heading back towards Hugo, who’s eyes looked as if they hadn’t parted from Hunter’s form the entire time.

“You may have strayed from this family’s glorious path, but I refuse to let you drag our little brother into the same mess.”

Hunter stood behind Hugo, placing a hand on each of his shoulders, and Entrapta watched him squeeze a little firmer than necessary.

“You don’t have to put up with this shit, Hugo,” Heath argued. “You’re an adult for fuck’s sake, you don’t have to listen to a single lie he tells you.”

Hunter squeezed harder.

“Big Brother doesn’t lie to me,” Hugo replied, his voice oddly even. “I will spend time with you at school, and on this project, but I will still happily live with our brother.”

Hunter’s grip relaxed, removing his hands from Hugo’s shoulders.

“Come on, little brother,” he cooed, turning towards the door. “Let us go home. You can tell me about this little *project* of yours on the way.”

A dog to it’s master, Hugo grabbed his back and followed hurriedly after Hunter, the door banging closed behind them. The robotics room plummeted into a deafening silence.

“Are you okay?”

Entrapta opened their eyes, seeing Heath watching them with careful eyes. He stood an arm’s length away, energy coiling to

step closer if needed, white knuckled fists held at his side. Entrapta nodded, watching Heath soften with an exhale.

"You didn't have to do that," they mumbled.

"Do what?" he started, walking across the room to the open windows and heaving them closed. "The guy's a prick, that was me being polite-"

"Correct the pronouns he used for me."

Heath looked back to Entrapta, who smiled ever so slightly.

"I use both," Entrapta admitted. "I use she or they."

"But you prefer 'they'," Heath retorted. "You told me yourself. And I get that you use both, but Hunter would use that to make up some shit about your identity not being real, and I wasn't going to let the bastard get away with that-"

"Heath."

He stopped his tirade, seeing Entrapta with their backpack slung over their shoulders, holding his satchel in their hand.

“Thank you.”

Heath fought the urge to smile, even just a small one, choosing to nod.

“Don’t mention it. You’re good for Hugo,” he informed them, moving away from the windows and back to his lab partner. Taking his bag, the pair left the room behind. “And it’s nice to have someone around that understands what I talk about. Whatever ‘outcast’ crap my dick of a big brother starts rattling on about isn’t worth listening to.”

Locking the robotics room behind them, Entrapta stuffed the key back into their coat pocket. Turning to Heath, they grinned.

“I like being friends with you, too.”

Heath, for the first time since Gods’ know when, smiled.

Right from the get go, Catra and Adora had made the abandoned bleachers their place. Somewhere the pair could talk about anything and everything that was on their minds, regardless of how serious or silly it may have seemed in the moment. So it was a surprise when Adora showed up that afternoon with a packed backpack, and got picked up by a tall, lithe bald lady only minutes later. The only reason Catra didn’t call the police or run after the

car was because Adora seemed calm, but the encounter was still plain *weird* . Even hours later, Catra still couldn't make sense of it.

[Message from: Catra 🖤]

alright, so since tall bald lady didn't really give a explanation before she came and picked you up

mind giving me one?

just so I know you won't be murdered or whatever

[Message from: Princess 🏋️ ♀️]

yeah i'm sorry about that

well

first off, 'tall bald lady' is my guardian I guess??

her name's hope

she was mara's partner

but i don't like calling her my mum

Catra let out a heavy exhale, laying back on the bleacher seat. Now she knew that Adora was safe, she could actually spare enough mental energy to focus on what the athlete was talking about.

[Message from: Catra 🖤]

one, don't apologise

two, gotcha

three, thats valid

mara was your mum

[Message from: Princess 🏋️‍♀️ ♀️]

adopted mum

[Message from: Catra 🖤]

dude blood doesn't mean shit

she raised you

loved you

did all that other parenting crap

she’s your mum

[Message from: Princess 🏋️‍♀️ ♀️]

point taken but anyway hope’s taking me home because

it’s my birthday tomorrow

Catra almost dropped her phone. Abruptly sitting up, she looked back to where the car was moments ago, consciously trying to

process this information and figure out why the hell her stomach felt empty after reading that.

[Message from: Catra 🖤]

i'm sorry WHAT

and you didn't tell me??

[Message from: Princess 🏋️‍♀️ ♀️]

i’m sorryyyyyyy

honestly I didn’t tell anyone

I promise it’s not just you

you probably would’ve been the first one i told

[Message from: Catra 🖤]

why not

aren’t you like a massive extrovert?

[Message from: Princess 🏋️‍♀️ ♀️]

I mean kinda

and i didn’t wanna make a big deal out of it

it’s the first one without mum

plus I figured hope would do something like this

I didn’t wanna make plans and get excited then yeeted home

Even in a conversation as serious as deceased parents and ignored birthdays, and even through text, Adora still managed to make Catra laugh. It was only to herself, but it was a lot more than it had been a few months ago.

[Message from: Catra 🖤]

adora

you are the ONLY person I know that uses yeeted in a serious context

anyways

does hope always do stuff like this?

[Message from: Princess 🏋️‍♀️ ♀️]

I mean yeah??

mum always used to talk her out of it

obvious reasons that doesn’t happen anymore

so yeah hope’s been doing it more often

she always means well

i just don’t always understand why i guess

[Message from: Catra 🖤]

means well or not it’s still your choice

you’re an adult

you should have a say in what you do for your own birthday

[Message from: Princess 🏋️ ♀️]

catra it’s only for a weekend

besides home isn’t too far from campus

I might be able to borrow the car and we can meet up or something idk

Catra paused, fingers hovering over the keyboard and brain running a mile a minute. Adora was constantly going out of her for other people. Whether it was reminding them about homework, buying her friends food so they ate that day, or just because she wanted to, being the shoulder for others to cry on when the reality of university became too much. No matter how big or small the need, Adora was there with open arms and her heart on her sleeve. The artist started typing once more. It was about time that someone showed Adora the same love she gave everyone else.

[Message from: Catra 🖤]

how far is not too far

[Message from: Princess 🏋️‍♀️ ♀️]

right on the outskirts of eternia

It’s like 15 mins drive from campus

Perfect. It was a crazy idea, insane even, but it was possible.

[Message from: Catra 🖤]

gotcha

we’ll figure it out in the morning alright?

text me when you’re home safe

y’know so i know you’re not dead or whatever

[Message from: Princess 🏋️‍♀️ ♀️]

I doubt a car ride on a quiet road will do that

but i will 🧡

Giving the last message a heart reaction, she exited the conversation and found the pencil icon she was looking for. *Here goes nothing.*

[Catra Weaver added Bow Fletcher, Glimmer Brightmoon, Scorpia Stevenson, Entrapta Dryl and Perfuma Plumeria to the group]

[Message from: Catra]

aight. it’s adora’s birthday tomorrow

@bow @glimmer before you throw hands i only JUST found out

anyway

she’s gotten dragged home for the weekend to spend it with her mum’s partner

she didn’t sound keen to be p much alone, but there’s a bus route all the way to hers

so who’s thinking what i’m thinking?

Chapter End Notes

> happy holiday season! whatever you celebrate, be sure to stay safe and relax, it's been a big year and we all deserve some down time x
>
> this chapter is a little shorter than my usual because the next one is almost done and it is a DOOZY. hope y'all enjoyed and i'll see you next chapter!

garden song

Chapter Summary

> "I'll be down in a minute, Hope," she called back, eyes still fixed on the bed. Instead of a reply, she heard the sound of the bedroom door squeaking open, and Adora really didn't want to be angry on her birthday but-
>
> "The resident grandma emerges."
>
> Adora looked up.

Chapter Notes

> buckle in, folks.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The winds of the winter day felt colder than usual. January was here, already. Adora could hear commotion from downstairs but made no effort to leave the warmth of her covers. Her body wasn't aching in the way it had been recently, but the sinking feeling in her chest refused to leave her, eyes constantly flicking to the door and waiting for the figure to appear.

"Happy birthday, peanut!" she would say, gray eyes sparkling as she ripped the covers off Adora, wrapping her in her strong arms and spinning around the room. But she wouldn't this year. Or the next. It had almost been a year without her, but the gaping wound in her heart was taking a long time to heal. If it ever would.

She took a deep breath, shakily exhaling and forcing her body to sit up. Immediately, her body protested. She bit back the yelp, deeply inhaling and focusing on anything else but the stabbing sensation in her hips and the aching along her spine. After a

moment, it eased. Flinging the covers aside, Adora heard two knocks sound on her door.

"I'll be down in a minute, Hope," she called back, eyes still fixed on the bed. Instead of a reply, she heard the sound of the bedroom door squeaking open, and Adora really didn't want to be angry on her birthday but-

"The resident grandma emerges."

Adora looked up. The artist leant against her door frame, heterochromatic eyes shining.

"Catra?!"

Adora didn't bother fighting the grin, leaping up from her bed and rushing towards her. Catra stood there waiting, arms open and catching Adora in her embrace, holding her strong and steady.

"Happy birthday," she mumbled into Adora's hair, squeezing tighter as she felt the blonde shudder in Catra's arms.

"What are you doing here?" Adora mumbled. "I mean, I'm happy to see you, but-"

“We wanted to surprise you, dummy,” Catra interjected softly, pulling back to look into her friend’s eyes. She was met with the usual softness that came with looking at Adora, along with a pair of furrowed eyebrows.

“We?”

Catra rolled her eyes, releasing the embrace and reaching down to intertwine their fingers together.

“C’mon,” she hummed, and gave no more explanation. But Adora squeezed their hands slightly, and followed Catra out of her room. Catra began to pull ahead, their arms reaching when Adora couldn’t keep up. Catra felt her cheeks begin to ache, smiling as she waited for Adora to catch up.

“This better not be some kind of prank,” Adora started, before the living room came into view. Her eyes welled at the sight. Bow, Glimmer, Scorpia, Perfuma and Entrapta stood before her, all holding bags and boxes of various sizes, sharing a wide grin with their eyes fixed on Adora.

“Happy birthday!”

Adora let out a shaky laugh, her friends setting down their items to all wrap their arms around her. Swamped in the embrace of her friends, she turned her head to try to see all of them, but the feeling of their arms around her made it all settle in. This was happening.

"What are you all doing here?" she asked them.

"We wanted to surprise you!" Bow said with a wide grin.

"We know you were spending your birthday with your family," Glimmer started. "But we all wanted to be here for at least part of it, we checked with Hope to make sure it was okay and everything!"

"Your Nana Razz is absolutely lovely," Perfuma hummed, mostly to herself but still coaxing a smile from the blonde.

"This is-" Adora sighed, unable to find the words and trying to hug back as many of her friends as she could. "This is so sweet. Thank you, all of you."

"Hey, we're just here for the ride along, this was Catra's idea," Scorpia hummed from above her, pressing a quick kiss to Adora's crown.

“Confirmed!” Entrapta’s voice sounded from outside of the group hug. The embrace began to falter away, arms unravelling and presents being retrieved. Adora turned to face Catra, eyebrows raised with a smug smile.

“Oh really?”

Catra rolled her eyes, lightly bumping Adora with her hip. “Payback for my birthday, not because I like you or anything.”

“Sureeee.”

“Happy birthday, Adora,” Hope hummed, handing Adora two envelopes and a bouquet of white flowers.

“Camellias,” she mumbled, smiling at the symmetrical petals. They had been her favourite ever since she was a child, and there was always some growing in several colours in Nana Razz’s front yard. She’d always pinch one after a visit with Mara, and Razz would always pretend not to notice the missing bunches of flowers, or the trail of leaves following as Mara and Adora walked home. “Thanks, Hope.”

“Open the marked one first,” Hope said as Adora set down the flowers. The blonde thought nothing of it, furrowing her eyebrows

briefly. Until she turned the envelopes over.

One was completely blank, but the other was labelled with Adora's name, handwritten.

"It's-"

Adora fell silent, staring at the envelope. She could vaguely hear movement around her, but she didn't care enough to look. All she could do was look at the envelope.

"Adora?" Catra mumbled, Adora coming back in to focus to see the artist slotting herself beside the blonde. "What's going on?"

She tried to tell Catra, three times in fact, but each attempt only came out as a shaky gasp. A gentle hand, Catra, held Adora's chin, lifting her gaze from the envelope just an inch and putting herself into view. Bicolour eyes were warm and safe, they weren't rushing or expecting another of her, and the sheer relief let Adora take a deep breath.

"It's Mum's," she breathed, clasping the envelope with shaking hands, her eyes beginning to well. "Mum's handwriting."

The air fell silent, except for the quiet noises of the students rising from their spots, and sitting back down, surrounding themselves around their friend. Glimmer sat to Adora's left, Catra mirrored on

the right as Bow sat behind the blonde's back, Scorpia, Perfuma and Entrapta all finding a place to sit close to the blonde.

"We're here," Bow hushed, placing a gentle hand on her shoulder. "We've got you."

Adora managed a smile, steadying her hands to carefully open the envelope. Pulling out the paper inside, she felt Catra's warm hand rest on the small of her back.

"Take as much time as you need," she breathed. Adora mumbled a 'thank you' in reply, unfolding the paper and letting out a shaky exhale, her eyes taking in every familiar line and curve of the words.

My dearest Adora,

Happy birthday. If you're reading this, then I'm deeply sorry to say that I can't be there with you. Please know that I wish I could be, more than anything, but fate is a silly thing sometimes. I am sadly unable to fight it for you, even if every bone in my body screams for me to.
You have grown so much as a woman, an athlete, and a person, and words will never come close to expressing how proud I am of you. Being able to call myself your mother will forever be the greatest joy in my life. Since the day you came into my life, you've made my world so much brighter, and I will always thank whatever deity that gave you to me, in this life, and the next.
I don't know what I did to become blessed with a daughter like

you, but I promise you that I never took it for granted, even during the time that we were apart.

The next envelope will come as quite the shock to you, and I'm sorry if me saying that makes you panic. I wanted to tell you this news in person on your 21st, but circumstances mean I have to do it this way instead of the way that I wanted to, but I promise you it's a good surprise. No more nasty ones. Regardless of how you react to the truth, know that my greatest achievement is, was, and always will be having you as my daughter.

I love you, peanut. To the moon and back, and twice around the sun.

Mum x

Adora moved the paper away as the tears began to fall. She couldn't ruin this. The writing was still fresh, and if she focused hard enough she could smell the perfume Mara wore every day. She wouldn't stain it with her stupid tears.

"Geez, Mum," Adora mumbled with a teary laugh. "I already know I'm adopted, you didn't have to be so dramatic."

Her friends gave a light chuckle around her, and coupled with the small circles Catra drew on her back, it made the ache in her chest subside a little. Pressing a kiss to the folded paper, she tucked it back into the envelope. A silent response. *I love you, too. To the moon and back, and twice around the sun.*

Reaching for the remaining letter, Adora's hands were a little shakier, but the messier tear of the envelope didn't matter. It was inside that mattered.

She pulled out another folded piece of paper, and opened it, a photograph tumbling to the ground as she did.

"Whoops," she chuckled, discarding the folded paper for the moment and reaching for the photograph, bringing it up to look at it. It was old, Adora could tell by the quality, looking at the contents of the photograph. Mara sat in a hospital bed, dressed in a gown and smiling tiredly at the camera, a small figure wrapped in blankets cradled in her arms.

A baby.

Adora's eyes narrowed in, trying to find any feature on the baby that she might recognise. Mara had a child? How long ago did she give birth? Why did she never say anything?

She flipped the photograph over, scanning for any kind of clue. She found one, a date one in the top right corner. 19 years ago to the day. Familiar handwriting was scribbled just beneath the stamp.

Adora Grayskull - born 19th January at 10:18am.

happy birthday peanut x

“Adora?”

Her heart lodged itself in her throat, cutting off circulation. Her thoughts were drowning, eyes fixed on the photograph, even as it began to grow blurry. Was this some sick prank? This couldn’t be right, could it? Could she be Mara’s?

Frantically, her eyes searched for her grandmother, the lighthouse in the storm that held the answers she needed.

“Nana?” she whimpered. The older woman moved to kneel before Adora, gently taking the discarded paper and unfolding with the softness of a butterfly’s breath.

“It’s your birth certificate,” the woman mumbled. “Your mother asked me to hold onto it all these years. But now it’s yours.”

Adora took the paper with trembling hands, reading its contents as her chest choked her from the inside. There, halfway down the page, was what Mara meant in her letter.

Mother

Surname: *Grayskull*

First Name: *Mara*

Age: *21*

Place of Birth: *Mater Hospital Eternia*

Occupation: *Athlete*

Father

Not Applicable; Mother's Request

She was Mara's. After all this time of wishing and wondering, in a backhand to her face, her wish came true. And Mara was gone.

"She never wanted to give you up," her grandmother started. "Taking you to Weaver's broke her heart. But she was young, afraid and in the public eye, and there were a lot of things she had to do before she could give you the life she wanted."

Adora stared blankly at the words, reading them over and over again. She was Mara's. Mara was her mother. She was Mara's. Mara was her mother.

"Why didn't Mara ever say anything?" Catra spoke, knowing the question on Adora's mind. "After all that time, hearing that Adora wished she was hers and knowing the *truth* . How could she keep it a secret?"

Razz sighed, offering Catra a sad smile.

“Mara was many things,” she started, something between pride and misery in her voice. “And she was a wonderful mother. But when it came to the truth about Adora’s birth, she was always that frightened young woman. I couldn’t take Adora, Mara hadn’t met Hope yet, and she didn’t have anyone in the world. No one except herself and Adora. Weaver’s was her only option. She left Adora in Weaver’s care until her contract was over, and she could retire. Even though it was only ever temporary, Mara was terrified that Adora would hate her for giving her up.”

“I could never,” Adora whimpered, voice barely above her breath. “I just- I just wished she would have told me."

“Your mother had her reasons,” Hope spoke. Her *mother* .

“Excuse me,” she mumbled. The arms around her were too much, the ceiling caving down was too much, even Catra’s hand reaching for hers as she left was too much. She needed to breathe, she needed the world to stop caving in around her. She needed her mother.

"Adora? Where are you?"

Three separate footprints trudged through the surrounding grounds of Adora's childhood home. Bow and Glimmer's gaze searched left and right for any trace of the athlete, while Catra’s

was fixed ahead in determination. The air outside was bitterly cold and Adora was alone. Not if she could help it.

Adora couldn’t have gone far, not with the way her pain was flaring recently. That wouldn't have stopped her from trying though, and all three of them knew that.

"Any ideas on where she could have gone?" Bow asked the two girls, eyes still searching the horizon.

"She would have stayed on the grounds," Glimmer mused, but knowing there wasn't much of the grounds left to search. "I think she'd be somewhere with a memory, one between her and Mar- her mother."

"Sounds like her," Bow agreed, turning to the artist. "Did she mention anything? Somewhere she could have gone?"

Catra narrowed her eyes. "What makes you think I'd know something you two don't?"

"Because we never talked about her mother," Glimmer replied. "After the first day, we never asked and she never brought it up."

If Glimmer was telling the truth, Adora, apparently, only talked to Catra about her mother. Catra blinked twice, processing whatever *that* information was. Then, a thought.

"The garden," she breathed.

"But there isn't a garden here," Bow reminded her.

"No, but they tried to start one," Catra started. "They were going to plant it in the summer before university started, before Mara got sick."

Catra paused, looking back from where they came.

"Adora said they buried her ashes there. Where they were going to plant their garden, right near this big tree."

"Find that tree, we find Adora," Glimmer finished.

Surely enough, a few minutes later, they had found her. Adora sat, her back resting against the trunk of the tree Catra had mentioned, eyes staring blankly ahead. As the trio grew closer, they saw what the blonde was staring at.

A granite stone was buried into the ground, snow and leaves gently brushed aside to reveal the writing engraved into the stone.

Mara 'She-Ra' Grayskull

Beloved Friend, Daughter, Wife and Mother

Get Some Rest, You Will Be Missed

Bow, Glimmer and Catra made no attempt to quieten their footsteps, and they knew that Adora had heard them, even if the blonde made no attempt to move. Silence fell over the empty, lifeless garden.

"You guys are gonna get cold out here," the blonde mumbled eventually. "Go back inside, I'll be there in a minute."

Catra, never one to listen, closed the distance between her and Adora, and sat down beside the blonde.

"Yeah, well, you're not exactly rugged up for a winter's morning either," she replied, resting her arm on her bent knee. Bow and Glimmer followed suit, with Bow sitting beside Adora and Glimmer beside Catra, both watching the blonde with curious eyes.

"We're not going to ask if you're okay," Bow started. "Because, it's obvious that you're not. So, instead, we're going to ask this." He gently placed his hand on Adora's shoulder, waiting for glassy blue eyes to meet his before he spoke again.

"How can we help?"

Adora stayed silent, eyes drifting back to stare blankly at the headstone once more. Catra slowly reached her free hand out to where Adora's were cradled in her lap, gently brushing the backs of their hands together. As Adora turned her palm towards her, the brunette intertwined their fingers together, and the blonde didn't pull away.

Alright, this is a good sign, Catra thought. *We just need to take baby steps if we want Adora to open up to-*

"Adora, I know what it feels like to lose a parent," Glimmer started. "My dad went missing when I was little. Every lead turned up a dead end, and there's been no new evidence since he first went missing. The case has been cold for 10 years now, and my mother and I have given up any hope of finding him alive, if at all. I don't remember him, and obviously it's different from what happened to your mum, but I understand what-"

"No. You *don't* understand."

The words were drowned in venom, so much so that Catra barely recognised it as Adora. But stormy eyes never left the headstone.

"Every time I had the chance to make a wish, I wished that in another life I could be hers. That Mara could be a part of me, because I thought from the start that I wasn't, and it was all I wanted."

With every passing word Adora’s volume grew, and even Catra’s attempts of trying to soothe her made no impact.

“And now I found out that I was hers all along.”

Adora gave a single, humourless laugh, letting go of Catra’s hand and slowly standing up, eyes still focused on the gravestone. The three watched her, her shoulders bunched by her ears and shaking ever so slightly, a volcano roaring to life.

“I learn now, after she died holding my hand, that my entire life has been a *lie* . Nana knew this whole time, Hope knew this whole time, and they never told me. They knew that being Mara’s was all I ever wanted, and they lied to me.”

Finally, she turned, staring teary daggers at her shorter roommate, and all three of them could see her hands beginning to shake. She was practically yelling now.

“You've never had to wonder if you were theirs because you knew. You never had to question where you belong, because their world was practically made to fit you. So, no, Glimmer. You don’t understand what it’s like. Because while you live a damn near perfect life, I lost the most important person in the world to me! She was my *mother* , and this whole time I was *hers* , and now she’s gone!”

The winter air was still and silent, save for the trembling breaths Adora forced through her lungs. Glimmer didn't move an inch. Catra, meanwhile, stood from her place on the ground, standing beside the blonde, trying to put herself into the blonde’s view.

"Adora," she whispered, seeing eyes clenched shut and her entire body coiled. Catra gently brushed the back of her hand against Adora's knuckles, never taking her eyes off her tear streaked face.

"Hey, look at me. Stay with me," she tried, gently grasping Adora’s wrist. After a long few seconds, Catra felt the tension under Adora's arm ease, her fist relaxing and moving to intertwine her fingers with Catra's. Catra could hear rustling from where Bow sat, watching him approach slowly.

"Adora, I-" he started, taking a breath and trying again. " *We* will never really understand what you're going through right now. But that isn't going to stop us from helping. So whatever it is that you need, you say the word and it's done. Best Friend Squad sticks together, and yes that includes Catra, because she's stuck with us now."

That managed to get a small laugh out of the blonde, however choked it may have been. Glimmer finally stood, moving towards Adora, staying further away than the others, but mustering the most reassuring smile she could despite her urge to grimace.

"Let it out. You're safe here," the shorter woman assured her. Adora raised her head and opened her eyes, turning back to the simple gravestone that lay within the snow covered ground.

The dam broke.

Adora curled into herself, her sobs barely audible at first, but growing with each passing second. When a Banshee's howl left the blonde’s mouth, Catra snapped.

Tugging gently on their joined hands, she cradled Adora's head into the crook of her shoulder and let her cry into the fabric of her hoodie. The blonde’s arms held her fiercely, so Catra gave the same back. Bow, moved to tears, stood beside the two girls and enveloped them both in his arms, pulling them close to his chest and pressing a soft kiss to the crown of Adora's head. Even Glimmer closed the distance, wrapping her arms around the three as best she could, pressing her forehead to Adora's shoulder.

The athlete felt her knees begin to buckle but she never fell, three sets of arms refusing to let her. *We're here,* they whispered. *We've got you.*

They all did their best to protect Adora from the biting winter breeze, and the breaking in her chest, but they knew they could only do so much.

But at least for now, it was enough.

Chapter End Notes

Y'all expected fluff, and I am so sorry

nothing new

Chapter Summary

> “Are we sure this is going to work, Brother?"
>
> “Only one way to find out,” Heath mumbled.
> -
> As much as Perfuma preached self care, and always took the time out of her day for meditation, yoga and whatever else she could think of to help better herself, therapy was something that still terrified her.
> -
> “I know you can help with this.”
>
> “What makes you so sure of that, Sparkles?”
>
> “Because just like me, you have feelings for someone you can’t have.”

Chapter Notes

> sorry for the longer wait for this chapter, hope it's worth it! I'm going to be aiming to update every weekend until this story is finished so buckle up folks, here comes the last stretch!

“Are we sure this is going to work, Brother?”

Hugo, Heath and Entrapta all crowded around a small, metal figure, propped up on the desk. Everything, supposedly, was done. *Emily’s* metal frame had been completely welded together, every piece of wiring secured inside, every piece of coding needed for the robot to complete its task finished.

"Only one way to find out," Heath mumbled.

Emily's purpose was simple in theory, difficult in practice. In short, *Emily* was designed to act as a stand in, temporary or permanent, for a support animal. Tiny but mighty, this robot was programmed to recognise any kind medical threat, whether it was physical and emotional, and then either act or distract as necessary. Panic attack, dropped blood sugar, impending stroke or heart attack, *Emily* could do it all. But, it was a lot of work.

Entrapta spent every free hour researching countless medical conditions, and resulting symptoms and alerts to watch for. While she and Hugo created *Emily's* frame and attached all the necessary wiring, Heath spent the time he didn't spend on studies tearing apart the coding and programming needed to make this project work.

Hopefully, it had all paid off.

"Well, standing here staring at her isn't going to turn her on," Entrapta stated. "That's what the 'on' button is for."

Hugo blinked once in reply, but Heath let slip a single laugh under his breath.

"They are right," he hummed, reaching over to the back of Emily, and finding said 'on' button. "Are we ready?"

“Let’s go!” Entrapta cheered, Hugo simply raising his arms in the air as if he was cheering. Rolling his eyes, Heath pressed the button.

Emily was silent for a moment, then another, before sputtering into life with a series of incomprehensible sounds far from the ones the robot was supposed to make, limbs jerking wildly before stopping as quickly as it had started. Its purple eyes lit up, flickered for a few seconds, then faded away. Not another sound or movement left the robot.

“I do not think it was supposed to do that,” Hugo spoke carefully. Entrapta remained silent, walking over to stand behind *Emily* , seeing that the ‘on’ button was no longer engaged.

“No,” they mumbled. “It wasn’t.”

Heath’s eyes narrowed ever so slightly, taking a few steps closer to where Entrapta stood. He traced their gaze to the back of the robot’s frame. He opened his mouth, closed it again, and repeated it again before he finally found his words.

“What do you need?”

Entrapta didn’t respond, staring blankly at *Emily.* This idea had been one that Entrapta had kept in their brain since they were 14.

It bounced around in their mind from the day Entrapta was diagnosed with Autism, and the doctor recommended a service animal that was later denied to them. Countless hours, days and months were spent obsessing over the idea, trying to think of any possible way to bring the idea the life, to give the option to people like her that 'didn't qualify' the stupid standards people that didn't understand set. Entrapta even named the robot after their first bunkmate in boarding school. But it hadn't worked.

Of course it wasn't likely that a project like this would ever work on the first attempt, there were too many intricacies where a mistake could go unnoticed until it was turned on for the first time. But that didn't mean it didn't hurt.

The boiling of the kettle snapped Entrapta out of her day dreaming.

Looking up, Entrapta found Heath still standing next to them, watching closely, and Hugo standing by the bench with three mugs nearby.

"What's going on?"

"Is this not what we do when something doesn't go right?" Hugo asked. "Have a cup of tea?"

Surprisingly, he was right. Entrapta, with help from her therapist, had drilled a habit into her everyday that mostly appeared during sessions in the robotics lab. Every time something went wrong or they felt overwhelmed, Entrapta would tap out, fetch themselves

a cup of tea and stop thinking about whatever was causing the stress as long as there was still tea left to drink. It had become such a habit that Hugo had joined her too. Even though Heath was a self proclaimed coffee addict, he had also joined the pair in their tea drinking whenever they were working together.

Entrapta smiled.

"You're right," she replied, moving to the bench and standing beside Hugo. "We have a cup of tea."

While Entrapta spooned the sugar to everyone's liking, Heath joined the pair in the makeshift kitchen area, pouring the boiling water into all three mugs while Hugo retrieved the milk. With the tea all made to everyone's desire, Heath held his mug aloft.

"To progress."

Entrapta knew how odd this was, celebrating something having gone wrong when they had never done it before. But almost everything these days were odd. In this makeshift kitchen, in a run down robotics lab, with two people she considered strangers only a few months ago, everything somehow fell into place. This rhythm wouldn't make sense with anyone, but Entrapta didn't want it any other way.

"To progress."

The three mugs clinked together, and the trio took a well deserved break.

-

For the first time in a while, Perfuma was nervous.

Surely it didn’t make sense to be nervous, she was doing something good for herself, and she was quietly proud of that fact. It just didn’t help that the waiting room was a lot colder than Perfuma expected.

As much as Perfuma preached self care, and always took the time out of her day for meditation, yoga and whatever else she could think of to help better herself, therapy was something that still terrified her. Keeping her heart open was one thing, laying it all bare to a stranger was something else.

She straightened her posture, and let out a long exhale. These are trained professionals, she reminded herself, there is almost nothing a patient could tell them that they haven’t already heard. It wasn’t as if Perfuma had booked in with the first therapist that had popped up in the phonebook either. Scorpia had helped her scour through countless websites and advertisements to find the right one, saying that the key to therapy was finding the right person to talk to. Sometimes they just wouldn’t click with you, and that was okay too. They had eventually found a clinic with therapists and psychologists that specialised in queer issues, and the therapist Perfuma had chosen to see seemed to have a good

energy from what she could tell in the photo. So why was she still nervous?

The bell rang once more as someone else walked through the door, walking to the receptionist just as Perfuma had done, checking in and heading into the waiting room. Perfuma couldn't tell if her heart rose or fell upon recognising the figure.

"C-Chancellor Brightmoon," she stammered in greeting. Seeing the headmistress of your university anywhere outside of campus was odd, but in a therapist's waiting room was a whole other story.

"Ah, Miss Plumeria," she replied, as if this was something that happened regularly. She entered the room without a moment's hesitation, sitting on the opposite side in another chair. Perfuma would have taken comfort in that, except the room was small, and the headmistress still close to her.

"I take it this is your first time here?"

Perfuma looked up from her lap, nodding shyly. "How did you know?"

The older woman merely smiled. "You look just as nervous I did before my first session," she explained. "That and I come here the same time each week, and I haven't seen you here before."

Perfuma was very well aware that just because Madam Brightmoon hadn't seen her here before didn't necessarily mean it was her first session, but she didn't have the energy to correct her.

"May I ask who you're seeing?" the headmistress asked again.

"E-Ella. Spinner I think her last name is? I think she may have had two last names," she replied.

"From what I've heard, she's very good. I see her wife, Nat."

Perfuma couldn't help but smile at least a little at that, but it soon fell.

"Do you think they talk about cases together?"

"Of course not," the chancellor replied. "Everything you tell your therapist stays between you and them. The only time they will ever release information is when they're worried for your safety, and that will only ever be to authorities."

Perfuma gulped back her nerves, nodding in reply. Her eyes once again fell to her lap, running her thumbs along each other and trying her best to breathe.

"If I may, Miss Plumeria," the woman spoke again, making Perfuma look up. A warm smile looked back at her. "You should be very proud of yourself. It's a big step, doing something like this, and sometimes you might feel like you're not improving. But when you look back at where you started, you'll see how far you've come."

Perfuma felt some of the weight on her shoulders lift, and smiled back.

"Thank you, Chancellor Brightmoon."

The woman thought for a moment, before her smile deepened just a touch.

"You don't need to be so formal when we're off campus, Perfuma," she replied. "You can call me Angella."

"How do you know my name?" Perfuma asked, smiling brighter than earlier. "I doubt you have the time to remember every student's name."

"No, but I do try to remember the names of people my daughter spends time with," she admitted.

"Glimmer talks about us?"

"Of course. Some more than others, but she's told me all about your bunch."

Perfuma eyebrows furrowed. "I don't mean any offence, but Glimmer always seems too focused for friendships. Even at QSA meetings, she still manages to bring up school work."

Angella chuckled once, shaking her head with a fond look.

"I'm afraid she gets that from me. She's always trying to prove herself to someone around her. I've even encouraged her to come here and talk things out, but she seems to have her own way of doing things that no one can change."

Perfuma managed to smile a little at the Chancellor.

"I think Glimmer is lucky to have someone like you looking out for her."

Angella's smile turned sad, and Perfuma could feel herself starting to ask why.

"Perfuma?"

A pale woman with magenta hair poked her head through the waiting room, her dress a myriad of pinks and purples.

"I'm Ella, it's lovely to meet you. Follow me through?"

Perfuma swallowed her question, gathering her things and rising from the chair.

"Good luck," Angella whispered. The blonde student smiled back in reply, realising as she followed Ella to her office that the crushing in her chest was gone.

-

“So why exactly did you wanna talk to me?”

When Catra had gotten a text from Glimmer, of all people, asking to meet at the Jasmine Dragon, she had absolutely no idea what to expect. But hey, Glimmer offered to buy her food. Now here they were, Catra happily munching a pork bun while Glimmer stared blankly at the table.

“Honestly? I don’t know who else to talk to,” she admitted, swallowing a sip of boba but not talking her eyes off the table.

“Aren’t you and Arrow Boy literally attached at the hip or something?” Catra asked between bites. “Seriously, I think this is the only time I’ve seen you without him being in the same room.”

“Very funny,” she huffed. “And it’s about him, so no.”

“So why didn’t you ask Adora? She knows both of you, makes sense.”

Glimmer let out another long sigh.

“That’s probably not the greatest idea, for a couple of reasons,” she admitted. When Catra only raised her eyebrows in response, Glimmer rolled her eyes and kept going.

“Well, for starters, things have still been a bit...weird, and Adora and I haven’t really hung out since her birthday, which I get even though I was just trying to help, but anyway. There’s that, and also the fact that Adora isn’t exactly the best person to talk about feelings with-”

Catra audibly groaned, even with her mouth full.

“You’re kidding me, right?” she mumbled. “Am I suddenly the resident therapist of this shitshow?”

"It's not like that!" Glimmer defended. "Besides, I *know* you can help with this."

Catra's stare turned into steel.

"What makes you so sure of that, Sparkles?"

"Because just like me, you have feelings for someone you can't have."

The clatter of the Jasmine Dragon's patrons was the only thing keeping the silence at bay. Catra took the last bite of her pork bun, sitting back in her chair and chewing slower than necessary. Glimmer, who's eyes never left Catra's, didn't budge. She didn't see any tells. No excessive blinking, no diverting her gaze, no touching her face. Glimmer was telling the truth.

"You can think what you want about me," Catra started. "But that's not important right now. Feelings for someone you can't have, huh?"

Glimmer nodded. Gathering her nerves, she took a deep breath and exhaled her admission.

"Bow."

“Wait, what? You two weren’t already dating?”

She almost choked on her boba.

“N-No! B-Bow and I were just- *are* just friends.”

Catra tried really hard to be polite, to handle this the way Adora would, but instead all she could do was laugh.

“You’re kidding me right?” she managed. “I- *whoo* - I’ve seen you two make heart eyes at each other so many goddamn times I thought you were already boning!”

“We do not *bone* !” Glimmer whisper shouted. “Anyway, that aside, what do you think-”

“Dude, you need to tell him.”

Glimmer stilled. It couldn’t be that simple, could it?

“But how-”

“Don’t think about it,” Catra interjected. “Just get him alone, and rip it off like a bandaid and just tell him before you talk yourself out of it.”

Glimmer stayed silent, watching Catra the entire time.

“Okay,” she mumbled eventually. “I-I’ll tell him.”

Glimmer, for the first time away from Adora, watched Catra smile.

“I’ve got a feeling you two are gonna be okay.”

wasteland, baby!

Chapter Summary

She wasn’t exactly an expert at the whole feelings thing, but she had eyes. The worst part was that she got it. Horrifically, Catra knew it all.
-
Adora didn't want to admit the fact she was freaking out just a little bit; but oh man, she was freaking out.
-
Glimmer was about to burst. The walk back from The Jasmine Dragon was too short and too long at the same time, but now there was nowhere to hide.
But there was nothing to be afraid of, right? What could possibly go wrong?

Chapter Notes

aaaaaa there's probably errors in here, but i'll fix them in the morning. enjoy!!!

When Glimmer left The Jasmine Dragon, Catra stayed behind.

The server guy (Lee, she’s pretty sure his name is) cleared their table, mumbled the shop’s closing time under his breath and walked away. She had an hour left. Her stomach refused to settle, and as much as Catra wished she could blame it on the pork buns, she knew that was wrong. She wasn’t upset with Glimmer, even if that conversation left a bad taste in her mouth. Catra was jealous.

Not of Sparkles, this Bow guy was cool and all but Catra was strictly into women. She wasn't jealous of him either; aside from just then, the few times she and the human glitter bomb had

interacted had been in a group setting, and even then they hadn't spoken much at all. In a weird, roundabout way, Catra was jealous of the both of them.

She wasn't exactly an expert at the whole feelings thing, but she had eyes. Half the reason she refused to go with Scorpia to QSA meetings was knowing Sparkles and Arrow Boy wouldn't stop making googly eyes at each other. The worst part was that she got it. She knew next to nothing about the purple haired politician to be, except she had a penchant for all things glittery and her mother ran the university they both went to. But with this? They may as well have been the same person. As much as she didn't want to admit it, she knew what it felt like to find yourself falling, and having to face the terror that comes with realising you might not get caught. She knew the way hearts raced and stomaches dropped. She knew the familiarity of late nights staring at the ceiling, wondering what it would be like to lay in the embrace of the person you couldn't stop thinking about. Horrifically, Catra knew it all.

Catra, like an idiot, had gone and caught feelings for her best friend, Adora. Gods, even saying it in her head sounded so stupid. But she couldn't even help it. It wasn't like it was supposed to happen, their everyday rendezvous' on the bleachers were only ever meant to be platonic, two strangers finding their way through college together. Every time Adora needed someone, Catra was there because she needed a *friend* . However, life just loved to throw spanners in the works whenever it had a chance, like a goddamn jackass; hell, if she didn't know for sure that she was alone, Catra would have sworn Sister Zylah was whispering in her ear right that second.

What in the world makes you think you could be loved by anyone, let alone someone like her?

The kids used to call Sister Zylah ‘Shadow Weaver’. Catra thought they might have been on to something, feeling the familiar shiver running down her spine. Weaver was right.

Catra knew that Adora was too good for her, always had. In the stupidest cliche Catra could think of, the closest thing she could liken Adora to was the sun. Even just the thought of her chased away Catra’s chill, not to mention the warmth that flooded her chest every time Adora smiled at her, or brushed their knuckles together when they walked side by side. Adora wasn’t perfect, and Catra knew that, but she was wonderful. And here, floating in her own misery, was Catra. A line without a hook, up a creek without a paddle, or whatever euphemism there was to describe the ‘unmotivated, ungrateful, selfish, violent, no good, piece of crap’ that she was. The worst part of it all was that Catra was okay with that.

She dug her phone out of her pocket, digging through her apps to find the quickest ride she could into the city. A few button presses later, she found one. Leaving a crumpled dollar bill on the table, Catra stalked out of the cafe the second her ride to *The Whispering Woods* was confirmed, swiping away every notification on her phone.

Was this healthy? Probably not, but oh did she need it.

-

Catra didn’t show up at the bleachers that day. Adora didn't want to admit the fact she was freaking out just a little bit; but oh man, she was freaking out.

It had been something unspoken, ever since they first met. Even when Catra found other things to draw, and Adora stopped training as often, they both still came to the bleachers. Sometimes they talked about whatever was on their minds, sometimes they sat in silence, but they were always there when the late afternoon sun began to disappear. Now Catra, like the sun or the moon, was nowhere to be seen.

She was safe, right? Surely. Catra knew how to take care of herself with stuff like this, she would just hang out by herself all the time, she’d be fine. That, unsurprisingly, didn’t help Adora feel better.

Maybe she was sick? Or napping in her dorm with her phone on silent; that sounded like a Catra thing to do. Well, maybe not, but Adora didn’t want to be alone in her worries. She exhaled heavily and began walking to F Block as quickly as she could. Her entire back began spasming not even halfway here, Adora biting down on her tongue to bear it and pressing on towards the dorms. She’d book a doctor’s appointment in the morning. It wasn’t important right now.

By the time her legs were almost numb, the brass 26 stared down at Adora. This was fine, right? It’s just Catra. That’s why she

walked all the way here, she was here for Catra. She rapped her knuckles against the door, and waited.

A moment passed, then two, a few more going by before Adora lost count. She dug out her phone, checked the messages again, checked if Catra was online, but nothing had changed from the last time she checked. The door opened.

The racing in Adora’s chest stopped before it started, seeing Scorpia standing at the threshold.

“Oh! Hello, Adora,” she greeted, her smile not as wide as usual. “What’s up?”

“H-Hi,” the blonde mumbled. “I-I’m sorry for barging in, have you seen Catra anywhere?"

Scorpia’s smile fell, shaking her head in reply.

"I thought she was with you, honestly," she admitted. "Don't you two usually hang out in the afternoons?"

Adora’s gaze became focused on everything and nothing at once, feeling herself nodding and then talking. She couldn’t get the words to stop.

"We do, but she didn't show up today, and I thought maybe she was sick or something like that, so I came here to see, but if she's not here then I don't know where she could be and-"

She finally stopped when two strong arms pulled her into a warm chest.

"Woah, hey it's alright," Scorpia hushed, holding the smaller girl against her chest, arms holding her close. She mumbled words Adora couldn't hear into blonde hair until her breathing became easier, and pressed against Scorpia's chest she couldn't help but feel protected.

"Sorry about that," she mumbled into Scorpia’s shoulder.

"You don't have to apologise for this stuff," Scorpia replied, baffled. "It's been a wild couple of weeks, you don't have to be sorry for feeling things, okay?"

Adora nodded against her shoulder, even though it didn't help her feel any better. Scorpia's hands moved, resting on her shoulders and her head angling down to meet the blonde’s gaze.

"You can hang out inside our dorm for a bit, if you like. I make a mean cup of hot chocolate."

Adora didn't have the will to tell Scorpia that it would be springtime soon, it was almost too warm for hot chocolate. Instead, she nodded again.

Scorpia swiftly moved beside Adora, the arm around her waist leading her into the dorm room, securing the door behind them. It was empty, save for the two of them.

"Entrapta's in the robotics lab again tonight," Scorpia explained. "They probably won't be back until late, so you can have some quiet time here."

The amputee began to lead Adora to their shared desk, before the athlete planted her feet as best she could, even if her legs refused to stay steady, and started shaking her head.

"No? What's up, buttercup?" Scorpia asked.

Adora exhaled a heavy breath, cinching her eyes closed. It was just a question. She could do this, besides it was Scorpia.

"C-Can I lie down?" she breathed.

"Ah crap. Uh sure, of course you can!"

Scorpia immediately changed direction, leading Adora towards her own bed.

"I washed all our blankets today so I haven't got anything like that right now," she admitted. "I can give you a flannel or something?"

"S'okay," Adora mumbled, letting herself lean into Scorpia as she clambered into bed. She lay on her stomach, arms folded underneath her head in a makeshift pillow, finally letting her muscles relax with a long exhale. The spasms kept up their onslaught, but Adora ignored it as best she could.

"Having a flare?" Scorpia asked softly, and Adora could feel the bed dip slightly.

“Uh, yeah,” Adora responded. “How did you know?”

She could practically feel the sheepish smile that Scorpia gave her.

“Catra told me,” she admitted. “Well, Mermista brought it up actually, months ago. We had a study session, I told her that Catra was my roommate, she told me she recognised Catra from bringing you to the clinic.”

Oh. That was not what Adora was expecting.

“Then Mermista and Perfuma talked for a while, and I didn’t mean to eavesdrop but they were talking about pain management stuff, and I thought I should ask Catra about it, cuz she knows you so well. So I did, and she said you had chronic pain, but please don’t get mad at her-”

“Scorpia, it’s alright,” she managed to say. “I wasn’t exactly trying to hide it from people.”

It was half the truth, but Scorpia didn’t need to know that. Adora hadn’t been making an effort to hide her pain, because regardless of how hard she tried, she couldn’t. Her gait bordered on a limp most days, and even when she was still, she fought the urge to wince when bolts of pain struck in class.

“Well, I’d hate to hear that you were hiding pain from people,” Scorpia mumbled, watching Adora move her head towards her and smiling when their eyes met. “I wasn’t lying when I said I was worried about you.”

Adora frowned, managing to find a place on her side that didn’t increase the aches, watching Scorpia carefully.

“Why were you worried?” the blonde asked. “There isn’t anything you could have done. Believe me, I’ve been to the clinic more times than I can count, and they’re stumped.”

Scorpia looked down at her prosthetics and shrugged.

“Oh gosh. Well, I’ve always been like this, I guess,” she admitted. “You know, you wanna look out for the people you care about, do what you can to make sure that they’re okay. I can’t imagine someone not wanting to do that.”

“But what if there’s nothing you can do?”

Scorpia’s smile lessened, a glassy gaze washing over her eyes. “That’s the worst part of caring about someone, at least in my opinion. You can sit by and wait, or you try what you can, and hope.”

The look the two shared brought everything unspoken to the surface. In that moment, they both had the same person on their minds, and unease in their hearts. But soon, they would have a plan.

-

Glimmer was about to burst. The walk back from The Jasmine Dragon was too short and too long at the same time, but now there was nowhere to hide. The familiar brass 11 bared down on her, Glimmer turning her keycard over and over in her palm to give her something, anything else to focus on than the heave of her breaths.

Should she knock? No, that’s stupid, this is her dorm as well. If she did that it would immediately tell Bow that something was

wrong, and if he asked her that she might chicken out and not tell him.

But there was nothing to be afraid of, right? It was just Bow. What could possibly go wrong?

Glimmer's stomach trying to escape through her throat answered her question. Fine, a lot could go wrong. Bow could hate her, and decide to never talk to her again. He might not feel the same, and promise her that they'd stay friends, but the awkwardness of her confession could drive a wedge between them, and they'd never again be as close as they are now.

Or he could feel the same. Glimmer let out a long, shaky exhale, recalling her mother's words.

The moment you confess feels like the end of the world, but as soon as there's an answer, you start all over again with that person. Either as friends or something more.

"It'll always be terrifying," she mumbled, "but it will always work out alright as well."

Glimmer gripped the handle, took a breath, and opened the door.

Bow sat at the desk, hunched over his notes, turning towards the door at the sound of the opening door. Deep eyes looked into Glimmer's, and his smile was contagious.

"Hey," he hummed, turning in the chair to face her. "How'd it go recruiting Catra for the debate team?"

Glimmer had to admit, she was slightly impressed with the cover she had managed to wrangle up for herself and Catra. Closing the door behind her, Glimmer set down her bag and flopped onto her bed.

"I think I'm making progress," she lied smoothly, moving up to sit directly opposite her roommate. "I'll have to talk to Mrs Spinner next time she's on campus though."

"Have to love college volunteers," he hummed, turning back to his notes. "Still, I'm glad you and Catra talked."

On any normal day, Glimmer would let the conversation fade into a comfortable silence, and settle for a daydream. But Glimmer was determined to make sure today wouldn't be normal.

"Speaking of talking," she started hesitantly. "Can I tell you something?"

Bow looked up from his notes, his full attention on his roommate and every expression passing over her face. She was worried about something.

"Yeah, of course you can," he assured her. "What's going on? Are you okay?"

Even after knowing him almost her entire life, Glimmer couldn't believe how kind Bow was. It was practically built into him. Even as her hands trembled, she couldn't help but smile.

"Yes! I-I mean, yeah, I am. I'm just- I guess I'm just nervous about this," she admitted, suddenly very interested at the wood grain of their dorm room floor.

"'Nervous'?" Bow repeated under his breath, rising from his chair. "Is something wrong? Do we need to tell your mom about this?"

"N-No!" she defended, standing to meet him and his gaze. "No, I promise that everything is okay, just let me talk, okay?"

Bow went quiet, his face neutral as he nodded.

"Do you remember the party we had at the start of last semester?"

“You mean, the one where we were dancing and you almost bumped into someone?” Bow asked slowly, evident confusion on his face.

“Yes! Exactly that one. A-And do you remember the one at the start of this semester?”

Bow’s face went blank again, nodding. Glimmer was really hoping he would have said something she could bounce off, but it looked like she was just going to have to keep talking.

“Right, so. I-I lied to you, when you asked me about that first party. Well, not exactly. Y-You asked me why I ran off, and I told you it was because I was overwhelmed, but it wasn’t because of all the noise, it was because of you and-”

“Wait,” Bow interjected, his face still even but his eyes growing wider, glassier. “You got overwhelmed and ran off because of me?”

Glimmer paused to catch her breath, looking back to the ground for a moment.

“Yes, but it wasn’t like that, it was because-”

“Glimmer, why didn’t you just tell me back then? We could have talked about this months ago-”

“It was because I wanted to kiss you!”

Deep brown eyes were still wide, still glassy, and Glimmer felt nothing but terror. She knew that he had heard her, she was almost yelling at this point, but she knew even if she were silent he would know what she meant. She begged her voice for an explanation to come, but she could only find four simple words directed at the ground.

“I love you, Bow.”

Glimmer stared at the ground as it started to spin. But before she fell, she was caught. Bow’s palms held her hips, and she found the courage to look up and meet his gaze. His smile was the brightest thing Glimmer had ever seen. His eyes found hers, their gazes locked together and on nothing but each other.

“I love you, too.”

The world around them fell apart, and with every breath they took, created itself all over again.

“You do?” she breathed, her cheeks beginning to ache as he kissed her forehead sweetly.

“Yeah,” he chuckled, to her and her only. “I never saw you coming, you know that?”

“The feeling’s mutual,” she giggled, circling her arms around his waist and burying her face in chest. One arm circled her back, the other cradling the back of her head. There was still a lot to talk about, something that both of them knew, but neither of them minded leaving things unspoken for a little while longer.

As everything they knew crashed down in a wasteland around them, Bow and Glimmer found themselves happily unfazed. This wasn’t an end. Instead, it was the start of all the things left to do.

perfect places

Chapter Summary

> “Can I be honest for a second?” she hummed, pressing their foreheads together.
>
> “I mean, you’ve already told me that you’re in love with me, so what else is there?”
> -
> The crossroads stared before Catra; go back outside and drink herself until death or the bar closed, or go home.

Chapter Notes

> cw; drinkning, brief mentions of vomit

“I don’t think sleeping alone is gonna cut it anymore.”

Glimmer laughed against Bow’s chest, curled against his side and listening to his heartbeat. Joy oozed from her entire being, simply laying in Bow’s arms filling her heart to limits she didn’t know she had. A dream for such a long time was now real.

“You say that like we’ve never slept in the same bed before,” she argued, tilting her head up to press her lips to his cheek, smiling against the skin. Glimmer could feel the blood rush to the surface of his skin

“Not like this we haven’t!” Bow exclaimed, somehow bringing Glimmer even closer to him. “We did awkward sleepovers where we would apologised for bumping feet.”

“You were the one apologising, Bow.”

“Yeah, because my feet are always cold!”

Glimmer rolled her eyes, nestling into Bow’s hold, and sighing with a contented smile.

“Well, for one, that’s why they’ve invented socks; to stop your feet from getting cold,” she sassed, earning a light pinch from her *boyfriend* , “and secondly, I think we’ll be able to have moments like these a bit more often now. Especially with the dorm being pretty empty recently.”

The rest of the statement went unsaid. Adora had hardly been in. She still slept here every night, but she would wait until the hour was obnoxiously late before even entertaining the idea of going into the dorm. By that time, Glimmer was either asleep or watching a show with her headphones on. The few times she was still awake, studying for their upcoming exams, Adora gave her a barely-there smile and climbed into bed without a word.

“You two still aren’t talking?”

“No,” Glimmer grumbled. “Honestly, I don’t even know where to start. Like, I understand that Adora wasn’t in a good headspace, but I was only trying to help her and-”

“Woah, hold on,” Bow interjected softly. “Before you start to spiral, let’s go over what we know, okay?”

After all her years of knowing him, Bow never ceased to surprise or amaze her with how much he knew about the people around him.Glimmer took a long inhale, sighing and nodding.

“Alright,” she started softly, “Adora had a massive emotional moment because she just found out that her adoptive mother, someone she wished she was actually related to, had been her birth mother all along. I tried to relate to the loss of a parent by telling her about my dad, and she just kind of snapped.”

“So, who do you think was in the wrong?”

It was a big question to ask, especially this late at night and about such a sensitive subject. But Glimmer found herself thinking about it. She didn’t blame Adora for blowing up in the way she did, gods knew that girl put herself under far too much pressure. Glimmer hadn’t done anything wrong by trying to help, it just wasn’t what she had needed right then. Even if it hadn’t worked out, it was still with good intentions.

“I don’t think anyone was,” Glimmer answered in a breath. “I think it was just a miscommunication that went wrong because there were so many emotions flying around.”

She looked up from Bow’s chest to see him beaming down at her.

“There you go,” he hummed, pressing a tender kiss to the crown of her head. “Now, how do we fix it?”

“Well, we can’t exactly corner Adora,” Glimmer tried to joke, but the sentiment underneath soaked through. Regardless of how much being ignored stung, she didn’t want to hurt her roommate, her *friend* , anymore than she already had. “I don’t wanna make her talk to me if she doesn’t want to, but I’m not gonna sit here and blame myself for it either. That’s not going to do any good. I just don’t know what to say to her.”

“You know, you don’t have to say anything to let her know that you’re sorry,” Bow reminded her.

“Yeah, I know,” Glimmer sighed, laying back on his chest and closing her eyes, “but I’m not gonna come up with anything good if I make a plan this late. I just wanna be with you right now.”

His body rumbled with laughter underneath her, his hand running up and down her spine.

“You say that and you’re still too chicken to kiss me,” he teased. Glimmer’s entire face flushed red.

“E-Excuse me, I’ve kissed you on the cheek plenty of times!” Glimmer retaliated, sitting up and looking down at him, the arm

around her shoulders falling to her waist.

"Yeah, but that's on the cheek, Glim," he started, eyes averted from her and his cheeks flushed. "And don't get me wrong, I really like it, and I am so goddamn happy that we finally told each other and we're finally together, but I also *really* wanna kiss you."

It was unspoken that the pair wanted to take things slow. After knowing each other practically their entire lives, their relationship shifting from platonic and romantic was something to get used to. But knowing that Glimmer's desires were mirrored filled her heart. She watched him fidget with a fond smile, her hand reaching for his shirt collar, coaxing him to sit up next to her. He did so laughing, because he would follow Glimmer anywhere she went.

"Can I be honest for a second?" she hummed, pressing their foreheads together.

"I mean, you've already told me that you're in love with me, so what else is there?"

Glimmer couldn't keep the laugh contained, laughing into the space between them and slinging her arms around his shoulders.

"I'm trying to be serious here!"

“Alright, alright,” he chuckled, arms circling her waist and keeping them close. “The floor is yours.”

Glimmer’s smile only grew, hands fiddling with the hair on the nape of his neck.

“Since we’re laying everything out on the table,” she started, “I also really want to kiss you.”

Bow’s eyes widened, then softed, the gap between them closing *slowly,* feeling each other’s breath on their lips.

“So, can I kiss you?” he breathed, feeling Glimmer’s lips brushing on his. Instead of answering, she tugged Bow closer, and kissed him.

Bow tasted like apple juice, cocoa butter chapstick and *bliss.* His hands held her steady, his lips soft and yielding, following where Glimmer led and smiling against her mouth. As they found their rhythm and fell into it together, one odd move bumped their teeth together, but Bow simply laughed.

“You okay?” he asked, resting their foreheads together.

“I’m fine!” Glimmer defended with a laugh. “You don’t have to worry about stuff like that.”

“I just wanted to check,” Bow hummed, hands moving from Glimmer’s hips to cradle her cheeks. “Can I keep kissing you?”

After she nodded, he brought their lips back together with a smile.

Somehow, Glimmer fell even more in love.

-

Catra had lost count of how many shots she had downed, but the way her stomach turned hinted it was more than she could handle. Whatever, she needed this. In terms of impulse ideas, this probably wasn’t the best one she had ever made, but man this was fun. Under the darkness, coloured lights were the only way she could see, bodies melding together on the dance floor with barely any space left between them.

She was surrounded by strangers, and while the guys took the hint to leave her alone with a sharp glare, girls of every shape were all too eager to press their hips back into Catra. and dance in a way that could only be described as sinful.

It wasn’t who Catra wanted.

“Damnit,” she grumbled, catching herself slipping once again. It was time for another shot. She squared her posture as best she

could, head held high as she stumbled through the crowd, away from the dance floor and the pounding music.

"Another round, please," she grumbled, as soon as the bartender was within earshot, stumbling the final few steps to the barstool. However, they shook their head.

"No offence, kitten," they drawled, "but I'm not serving you like this."

"Whaaat? M'not even drunk," she argued, looking the bartender in the eye and finding bright green staring straight back. Green was an okay colour, but blue was much prettier. Damnit.

"Listen, I *really* need that drink," she tried, hauling herself up onto the stall. "It's been a shit day, and I need to suppress a lot of shit, so please just get me a goddamn shot."

The bartender blinked once, conceding with a sigh.

"Fine, but on one condition," they purred, tossing their platinum braid over their shoulder.

"What?" Catra immediately asked. Hell, she would have moved mountains if it meant she could forget for at least a while.

“Go to the bathroom.”

The little remaining sobriety that Catra had thought that sounded like a stupid idea.

“Why the fuck do I need to go to the bathroom before I get a drink? I don’t even need to piss,” she whined, slamming her forehead to the wooden bar. Gods, she didn’t know if she needed a hug or someone to knock her out.

“Because you need to have a long hard look at yourself in the mirror, and figure out if this is really what you need,” they replied. “Don’t get me wrong, I am all for getting smashed and having a good time. But is that really the best option right now?”

Catra raised her head from the bar, seeing a stern but concerned expression on the bartender’s face.

“Bathroom. Go wash that pretty face of yours. I’ll have your regular waiting for you when you get back, if you want it.”

Catra knew there was no winning this one.

“Ugh, fine,” she groaned, finding her feet and trying to keep her gait steady. “Thanks, Dee.”

She couldn’t hear if they replied or not over the music, the bass rattling her chest as she walked past the speakers into the bathroom. One step, then another, keep your eyes forward, don’t look at the girls that you wish were her.

The bathroom door closing behind her kept the pounding music at bay, and Catra was faced with a sink, a mirror and the silence. This whole thing was stupid. Whatever, all she had to do was hang out in here for a few minutes, keep in the bartender’s good books and get herself fucked up.

She stumbled the remaining few steps from the door to the vanity, bracing herself on the sink and turning on the faucet. One handful, two, three handfuls of water splashed onto her face, the chill cooling her flushed skin in an instant. Wait, that was too much, she was starting to sober up. Head down, she fumbled for the tap and twisted until the rushing water stopped. The silence was back.

She could only just make out the music outside over the pounding of her heart. Catra had gotten drunk more times than she could count, and she had never freaked out like this. When was the last time she had drunk?

The revelation hit her; she hadn’t had a drink since her birthday. Her hands gripped the sides of the sink, exhaling deeply and looking up into the mirror. Catra was a wreck.

Her wild hair was lifeless and matted, her skin absent of all colour with an unnatural sheen over her face, accented by two dark circles under her eyes. She stared into her reflection, but couldn’t recognise who she was looking at. Gods, she was *fucked.* Maybe Dee was right; running away wasn’t going to solve anything, regardless of how good she felt doing it. But by gods, did it feel

good. All she had to do was close her eyes and pretend that whoever's hands were touching her were Adora's.

Catra almost hurled.

She couldn't do that to her. Adora was her friend, her *best* friend. How dare she reduce her to nothing more than a fantasy, someone to think of with one hand down her jeans and the other between her teeth?

What would Adora think of her if she could see her now?

Catra bit back any report her own brain tried to give her, eyes still looking into the mirror and imaging what would happen if Adora burst through that door. If Adora would even make it that far. Catra never told her where she was going. She hadn't shown up at the bleachers, hadn't answered any of her texts. Would Adora even care?

The mere thought of it was stupid. Of course she would.

The crossroads stared before Catra; go back outside and drink herself until death or the bar closed, or go home.

She darted into the toilet stall, dropping to her knees and yanking up the lid. Her guts emptied themselves, and despite the burn in her throat the only thing she could feel was the aching in her

chest. Catra didn't want to be alone. Not anymore. When her guts finally stopped spilling out, she slumped back against the wall, head rolling back and catching whatever breath she could through the lump in her throat.

Adora. She needed to call Adora.

Trembling hands fumbled through her pocket, finding her phone and clutching it like a lifeline. Gods, she had missed so many messages. Swiping all of them aside, she headed into contacts and clicked the first name she could find.

The phone barely dialled before Catra heard her pick up.

"Catra?"

The mere sound of Adora's voice lifted a weight from her chest.

"Hey, Adora," she breathed through the phone, her voice almost wobbly as she spoke. "Heh, I'm drunk."

"Oh crap," Adora mumbled through the phone, and Catra could hear movement through the phone, rustling. *"Where are you? Stars, I was so worried. Are you okay?"*

“M’at the Whispering Woods,” she groaned, feeling her stomach groaning and trying not to hurl. If her stomach decided to throw a riot again, Catra didn’t think she’d have enough energy to move. “ *Fuck* , I’m so drunk. And my stomach is really angry at me and- *ughhh.* Shit, I don’t feel good, Adora.”

“Hey, I’m right here Catra, okay?” the blonde assured her through the phone. *“Just tell me what you need, and I’ll do it. You’ve just gotta talk to me, okay?”*

Catra nodded, barely recognising that Adora couldn’t see her. She was on the phone, not it this dingy toilet cell with her, no matter how much Catra wished she was.

“Can you come get me?” she whispered, the words a sin that burned her lips. She shouldn’t be asking for this. Not when the entire reason she was here was to get the blonde off her mind. But her pride was gone, and Catra didn’t want to be alone anymore. “I’m- fuck, I’m sorry but please come get me, I wanna go home, I don’t wanna be in this stupid bar anymore.”

“I’ll be there really soon, Catra, I’m on my way there right now,” Adora assured her, and Catra could hear rustling from the other end of the phone. *“Scorpia’s lending me her car, I’m gonna be there in like 10 minutes, okay? Just- Just hang in there for a bit longer for me. I’m going to take you home.”*

The words left Catra before she could stop them.

“You promise?”

Silence filtered through the phone for another moment, and Catra felt her eyes welling up. Why would she even say something like that? That was so stupid, why would she even ask Adora to-

“I promise.”

Adora said it with such conviction, Catra had no choice but to believe her.

“Stay somewhere quiet for me, okay? I’m gonna be there really soon. Do you want me to stay on the phone with you?”

“Mhmm,” Catra mumbled, resting her head against the wall, using the last of her strength to keep the phone pressed to her ear. “Hey, Adora?”

“Yeah?”

Catra blinked back the welling in her eyes, releasing a shuddering breath.

“I’m sorry.”

"What? Catra, you haven't done anything wrong, what is there to be sorry for?"

"For everything."

wish you were sober

Chapter Summary

> "Why's it so cold?" she grumbled into Adora's jacket. "S'pposed to be warming up."
>
> "It will be soon," the blonde hummed. "How come you're complaining? I thought winter was your favourite."
>
> A beat of silence preceded Catra's mumble.
>
> "Yeah. You remembered."
>
> Adora couldn't help smiling at her, even if Catra's eyes were closed.
>
> "Of course I did."

The drive to The Whispering Woods was the longest of Adora's life. Her eyes refused to stop flickering to the time flashing on the dashboard of Scorpia's truck, seeing almost no change every time she checked. Catra was still on the other line, she knew from the sound of her breaths, and the calling of 'occupied' every few moments. Adora, meanwhile, was silent. Her thoughts and the truck sped faster than they should, Adora gripping the steering wheel with white knuckles. What was she doing?

She was helping a *friend,* she reminded herself. If this were anyone else, Bow, Glimmer, even Scorpia, Adora would be in the same position she was in right now; driving to them as quickly as she could justify, keeping them on the phone so she knew they were alright. But this felt different.

Adora had known for a long time that the way she felt for Catra was different. She'd had crushes before, but the way her chest ached whenever she was in Catra's presence was something entirely new. Going to the bleachers brightened her day every time because she was next to Catra. The day at the arcade had been one of Adora's favourites because she was spending it with Catra. The pain of losing her mother was easier to bear with Catra by her side. Adora was an absolute idiot.

How could she have been so stupid? Adora couldn't risk this, couldn't risk feeling this way for her best friend and expecting her to feel the same. The mere thought of telling her set Adora on fire; she knew how badly it would end, and it would burn her from the inside out until there was nothing left of her.

"Y'okay there, princess?" Catra drawled through the phone, stopping the blonde's heart. Even in a drunken slur, Catra's voice never failed to calm her racing heart.

"Y-Yeah," she mumbled, snapping back from the inevitable trainwreck of her head, "I'm a couple of blocks away now. I'll be there really soon, okay?"

"Okay," Catra parroted, voice still slurring. Adora knew Catra hadn't gotten another drink since calling her; she had been hiding in the bathroom the entire time. Catra was surely above and beyond drunk if she still felt like this after throwing up. Gods, she hoped she was alright.

The neon lights appeared before Adora, and she sighed in relief, driving into the parking lot.

“I’m pulling up right now, Catra. Can you tell me which bathroom you’re in here?”

“Uhh, the ladies’ one? You know my pronouns, dummy.” Her words faded into a snicker, and Adora’s heart should not have leaped the way it did.

“I meant which stall, but I guess that’ll have to do,” the blonde mumbled through the phone. “They’re just letting me in now, count to 30 for me okay?”

“Why?” Catra grumbled, evidently confused.

“Because I’m going to be there before you stop counting.”

The bold words sent Catra into silence. Adora knew it was a big thing to claim, but she had every intention of sticking to it. She was tired of being afraid, tired of doing little things Adora knew Catra wouldn’t understand and hoping that she would just know somehow.

The second the bouncer handed back her ID, Adora heard the mumbled count start over the phone. Standing as tall as she could, shoulders back and eyes focused, she walked through the open doors and into the bar. The quickest way to the bathroom was through the dance floor. She cut herself a path straight

through, feeling hands grabbing her and drinks being spilled but refusing to budge. Adora needed to get to Catra. When the count reached 10, Adora opened the door to the bathroom and slotted her phone into her jacket pocket.

"Catra?" she called, scanning the stalls. There. Right in the back corner, the only closed stall in the ladies' bathroom. She hurried as best she could, finding it open when she arrived, with Catra tucked into the gap between the toilet and the wall.

"Hey, Adora."

Adora's eyes welled at the sight of her, dropping to her knees and reaching for Catra, pulling her into her embrace, a child with their favourite blanket. Catra threw her arms around Adora's back, burying her face into that stupid red jacket of hers, sobbing into the fabric.

"It's okay," Adora mumbled into Catra's hair, keeping their frames as close together as she could. "I'm here now, it's okay. I'm here."

Catra mumbled something into her jacket, the same phrase over and over again, but Adora couldn't make it out. She didn't want to pry her, not when she was like this. Adora slowly shuffled back out of the stall, Catra following close behind. When she went to stand, Catra didn't budge.

“Are you alright?” Adora asked instead. “Are you gonna be okay to walk?”

Catra shook her head into her neck, hands refusing to let go of Adora’s jacket. She needed to get out of here, and Adora knew how.

“I’m gonna carry you to the car, okay? Is that alright?”

“You’re gonna hurt,” the brunette mumbled.

“I don’t care about that, not right now.”

Catra didn’t respond, slowly lifting her head from the crook of Adora’s neck to look at her. Those mismatched eyes, even glassy and bloodshot, were the most beautiful thing Adora had ever looked at.

“I told you I was going to take you home, and I meant it,” she started, “and if that means I’m a little sore tomorrow, then I’ll worry about that tomorrow.”

Adora noticed that Catra’s expressions were much more animated when she was drunk, a comically large pout on her lips. Gods, what she wouldn’t give to close those few inches between them.

“Alright,” Catra relented.

Adora blinked away the daydream and nodded.

“I’m gonna help you stand first. Once you’re up, I’ll pick you up, okay?"

As the brunette nodded, Adora’s hands found Catra’s waist, taking her weight and standing both of them upright. Even as every inch of her body protested, Adora bit back the pain, holding Catra close. Releasing her hips, Adora wrapped one arm around Catra’s back, the other hooking beneath her knees and bringing her into Adora’s chest.

“Get comfy,” she mumbled; if Catra heard her, she didn’t respond. Mismatched eyes were already closed, her head resting against her chest and hands gripping the front of her jacket. Holding Catra steady, she exhaled and kicked open the bathroom door.

The dance floor was mayhem, the flashing colours, and reflections of empty glasses the only way Adora could see where she was going. She walked through the empty bar, any patrons that weren’t on the dance floor immediately clearing the way for the blonde with fire in her eyes and a girl in her arms. When the cold night air hit them, Catra stirred in her arms.

“Why’s it so cold?” she grumbled into Adora’s jacket. “S’pposed to be warming up.”

“It will be soon,” the blonde hummed. “How come you're complaining? I thought winter was your favourite.”

A beat of silence preceded Catra’s mumble.

“Yeah. You remembered.”

Adora couldn’t help smiling at her, even if Catra’s eyes were closed.

“Of course I did.”

Adora wasn’t sure how she managed to open the passenger door while still holding Catra, but she thanked her lucky stars that she could, even if her body was going to loathe her tomorrow.

“I’m gonna put you down now,” she mumbled, feeling Catra nod into the crook of her neck. Arms straining, she set Catra down into the open seat, withdrawing her arms from around her.

“Don’t go.”

Adora froze, eyes fixed on her friend. One hand had darted out, grasping Adora’s wrist. A beat of silence passed, Catra’s hand releasing just enough to slide down into Adora’s palm fingers intertwining effortlessly.

"Please."

“I’m right here,” she breathed, squeezing Catra’s hand. “I’m just gonna grab my water bottle for you, try and sober you up a bit more before we drive home.”

Catra groaned, but relented, releasing Adora’s hand. She already missed it.

Adora dug through the backseat of Scorpia’s car, knowing she threw her water bottle in here, somewhere, in the midst of grabbing whatever she thought Catra would need. Again, a totally platonic thing to do. She had drunk around Adora before, and tipsy Catra was something she had grown accustomed to hanging around. But never like this.

Through her rustling, Adora heard a faint hum coming from the front seat. It wasn’t a video, or music, but rather Catra herself. From the off-key melody, any passerby would be able to tell Catra was drunk, but as Adora emerged from the backseat with a water bottle and medication, the dopey smile plastered across Catra’s face confirmed it.

“Oh, look!” Catra cooed, giggling to herself with a child's glee. “The sun’s here!”

Adora furrowed her eyebrows, watching Catra with a fond smile and handing her the bottle.

“Hold on, what are you talking about? The sun’s not up yet.”

Catra fumbled for the bottle, popping open the top and downing half. The sigh and dopey smile that followed was almost comical, but Adora found herself focused only on the look in Catra's eyes.

“It’s you,” she mumbled eventually. “You’re the sun.”

Oh.

“Catra, that still doesn’t make any sense,” she hummed, knowing that it was Catra’s drunkenness making her say these things. She would never if she was sober.

“Well, it makes sense to me,” Catra drawled, grin refusing to budge, “you’re the sun. You’re so warm and pretty and really annoying first thing in the morning and if I look at you for too long I think I’m gonna go blind. That’s why I got you that present, dummy.”

Adora frowned.

“Present?”

Catra blinked twice, holding her head in her hands and groaning to the point Adora thought she would vomit again.

“Your birthday present,” she admitted. “I left the damn thing in my bag. And then everything just went south and I forget to give it to you.”

“Catra, you didn't have to get me anything-"

"Are you kidding?" Catra interjected, slumping in the seat, throwing her hands up, "I've had it picked out for *months* . Of course I got you something."

The blonde didn't realise Catra had her bag with her until the artist started digging through it. In her defence, Catra never went anywhere without it. As the brunette dug through, Adora caught a glimpse of a familiar notebook inside the bag, her heart imploding when she saw the engraved initials.

"A-ha! Gotcha," Catra hummed, looking back at Adora and producing a wooden box that fit perfectly in her palm.

"Is that," Adora started, cradling it in her hand, brushing a small, winding key on her palm. "Is this a music box?"

"Mmmm, maybe," Catra cooed, words slurring together. "Why don't you find out?"

Blue eyes rolled, Adora’s hand moving to the winding key and twisting, opening the box before the suspense killed her. Adora gasped.

She recognised the song instantly, one from Nana Razz’s The Beatles vinyls that chronically played whenever she visited. Blue eyes began to well when Catra sang along.

"Here comes the sun, doo doo doo doo," she hummed, pupils blown wide and watching Adora, humming along even as the music stopped.

"Here Comes The Sun," she breathed, watching Catra hum with a smile, swaying in the front seat of Scorpia’s truck.

"You really have gone soft," was all Adora could bring herself to say.

The truck came to a stop outside of F Block, and Adora was surprised Catra was still awake. Her eyes had been closed the entire trip back and Catra's hand periodically squeezing hers was the only reason Adora knew she wasn't asleep. Now the engine was off, and they were home. The blonde slowly pulled their hands apart, her chest aching at the loss of the warmth from Catra's palm in hers. Catra stirred, but those beautiful eyes stayed hidden. Gods, Adora wondered when was the last time Catra had slept a full night. Clambering out of the truck, she darted to Catra's door, opening it and watching her friend carefully.

"Hey," she whispered to Catra, "we're home. Do you need me to carry you again?"

Catra stayed silent, blinking her eyes open before looking at Adora, smiling.

"Heh," she chuckled, low and hoarse, "you're so pretty, princess. Like, really pretty."

Adora swallowed, watching Catra haul herself upright, sitting on the edge of the passenger seat and beaming down at her. Her legs, her waist, all of her was close enough to hold, and every bone screamed for the blonde to step forward, take her in her arms. Adora balled the ends of her sleeves in her fists.

"Y-You're drunk, Catra," she tried, unable to hide the flush across her cheeks.

"Heh, maybe," she cooed in response, hands reaching for Adora and finding her shoulders. To pick her up, the blonde reasoned. Her legs surely weren't steady after dancing all night.

Adora’s hands fell to Catra's waist, but found herself unable to lift Catra; or rather, unwilling. The moonlight illuminated every inch of Catra's face and, she let herself look, really look, at her friend.

She had only known Catra for 8 months; now Adora couldn't imagine her life without her. Her shrill laugh, her witty remarks, the way her tongue poked from her lips when she drew, all of it had weaved its way into the fabric of Adora’s life. Soft as Catra’s flannel underneath Adora's palms, the athlete gravitating closer towards the artist.

Their faces were so close now, too close, and Adora could see every fleck of precious stone inlaid in Catra's eyes, feel her breath dancing over her lips. She needed to move away, but she couldn't, trapped under the guise of Catra’s eyes, her hands, then her kiss. The longest second of Adora's life passed, and she kissed Catra back.

Her lips were soft, her sighs sweet, and Adora would only ever taste bourbon again if it came from Catra’s lips. Catra’s hands fisted in the collar of her jacket, and Adora followed where she was led, kissing her deeper and gasping at the brush of her tongue against her lip. She could have sworn Catra whispered her name against her lips, and Adora's heart soared. She pulled the brunette closing, fisting her hands in Catra’s flannel, kissing her like it was all she knew how to do, all she wanted to do until she perished.

Their aching lungs pulled them away, and Adora's heart fell.

All it took was a single look from Catra for reality to slap Adora in the face. Her frame was unsteady, pupils blown wide and her smile childishly big. She was still drunk.

Adora had tasted it, even when she tried to ignore it it was impossible, the reality settling in. Catra wanted this when she was drunk, but only when she was drunk. Catra didn't see her like that, and if she did it would only ever be with bourbon in her bloodstream.

"Wow," Catra giggled, eyes blinking a few times before staying closed, and Adora hated how beautiful she looked. "Really wish I remember that one in the morning."

The artist slumped forward, her forehead on Adora's shoulder as she caught her breath. Adora took a long inhale, exhaling and loosening her grip on Catra's hips, the thought of letting go making her chest ache, even though she should.

Catra was drunk. She didn't mean it. She didn't mean to kiss her, even if Adora did.

The blonde bit back her tears.

"And I wish you were sober."

hug all ur friends

Chapter Summary

> “Something’s bothering you, isn’t it, Wildcat?” she murmured. Catra hadn’t meant to nod.
> -
> Heath watched Entrapta and allowed himself to look at the unlikely friend he had made. It was a first, and it was terrifying, but it was good.
> -
> Adora knew she should reach out, check in on Catra and make sure she was alright. She didn’t have to say much, just something. But what could she even say?

Chapter Notes

> CW; mentions of drinking and smoking, brief mention of abuse
>
> be safe friends x

Catra remembered. When morning came her head was pounding, her eyes were watering, and her stomach was churning, and she remembered all of it.

She woke up in Adora’s arms, the blonde cradling Catra to her chest and carrying her up to her dorm, but she kept her eyes closed. Catra didn’t want her to let go yet. She heard the faint murmurs between Adora and Scorpia, but couldn’t hear anything over the pounding of Adora’s heart through her chest. She felt the tenderness of Adora’s hands as she tucked Catra in. The ghost of her lips hovered over Catra’s forehead, a sigh spilling over her skin instead of a kiss, and Adora was gone.

Catra knew Scorpia was in the room with her, and she did her best to stop her shoulders from shaking, clutching the pillow to her chest and wishing it was Adora's jacket she was crying into instead. When morning came, the hollow feeling in Catra's chest stretched from her toes to her pounding head, nausea brewing the more she moved. Sunlight streamed in through the window, and her chest *ached.*

The door creaked itself open, two figures padding across the floor.

"'M awake," Catra groaned, tearing her eyes away from the window, and looking at Scorpia and the guest behind them. "Don't have to walk around like you're gonna rob me."

"Sorry," Bow gave a sheepish grin, "we weren't sure if you were still sleeping or not, so we decided not to risk it."

"Besides, I wouldn't be surprised if you have a killer headache right now," Scorpia hummed, pulling up the desk chair and perching herself at Catra's bedside. "You were, like, a whole new level of drunk last night. Haven't seen you like that before."

She had forgotten about the headache until Scorpia mentioned it again. Groaning, Catra threw an arm over her eyes, the room too bright, too warm, too much.

"I went out to get fucked up," she grumbled to no one in particular, "and fucked up I did."

Scorpia sighed quietly, shuffling closer. Her voice dropped lower, softer, and the pity in her tone almost made Catra throw up again.

"Something's bothering you, isn't it, Wildcat?" she murmured. Catra hadn't meant to nod.

"Well, what do you need?" Bow asked. The hungover artist had almost forgotten that he was here, and frankly, she was surprised Sparkles wasn't there considering they were practically joined at the hip. Why was he even here anyway? It wasn't like he and Catra hung out, and of all things, he was trying to help.

"Another drink?" she tried, immediately cut off with a firm 'no' from Scorpia. Whatever, she had been joking anyway. Half-joking at least. "Honestly, I've got nothing," Catra mumbled. "Maybe a smoke, that doesn't sound half bad."

"I think something to eat would probably be better for you right about now," Bow suggested. "Even just something small would be worth a try."

"I don't-"

"Sounds good to me, Bow," Scorpia cut Catra off. "I'll hold down the fort here, you run along and grab something. I'll send you some money through for it."

“Jokes on you, you don’t have my bank details,” he hummed, his footsteps padding towards the door. “I'll be back in a bit!”

Catra was lucky Bow knew to close the door quietly, her head threatening to explode from the sound of her heart racing. Her body could have slept for a year in peace, her mind forcing her into the hell hole of reality. Catra remembered everything.

“Something happened, didn’t it?” Scorpia asked, her voice like melted butter.

“I never said that,” Catra growled, but all of her bite was gone.

“You didn’t need to say anything,” her roommate continued. She paused for a while, opening her mouth and closing it, trying to find the right words.

“Catra, you haven’t smoked in months.”

“So?” she defended, venom weaving through her words. “I had tried quitting or whatever. Adora didn’t like the- I just didn’t like my shit smelling like tobacco anymore, okay? Didn't realise that was a fucking crime.”

The dorm room went silent. It stayed that way, even as Scorpia stood from the chair and sat on the edge of Catra's bed. From the footsteps alone, she didn't know what to expect. A slap, an insult, any kind of revenge for the way Catra had spoken to her. Stars knew she was all too used to it. She felt Scorpia's hand simply hover over Catra's crown.

"Can I play with your hair?"

Catra paused then nodded, feeling the tension leaking from her head as metal fingers cautiously danced over her scalp with near-perfect pressure. She felt welling beneath her eyelids and exhaled a shaky breath.

"Thanks, Scorp," she breathed, moving the arm from over her face, eyes still closed to keep the light out and the tears in.

"It's no trouble," her roommate assured her. "Now, do you want to vent, advice, or a distraction first?"

It was something Scorpia had always done, especially with Entrapta whenever they felt overwhelmed. In turn, Entrapta had started using it with people she knew, and the simple question became common practice in room 26. Now, even as the world caved in around Catra, was no different.

"Distraction," Catra answered, the same one as always. Maybe this time, a distraction would work.

"Need a refill? I've got the kettle going."

Heath dragged his eyes away from the laptop to see Entrapta hovering beside him, her hand reaching for his empty mug.

"Yeah. Thanks," he grumbled, eyes searching through lines of code. Everything needed to be perfect. One typing error, one thing in the wrong place could burn this entire project to the ground. The fact it was Entrapta's made that fact all the more important.

Even if Entrapta focused more on the mechanical aspect of things, they thought an extra pair of eyes on Heath's work wouldn't hurt, and he couldn't find a reason to argue. Especially after Hugo had stopped coming to the lab.

"Are you sure it's practical for you to be working on this right now?" Entrapta called. "The end of the semester is coming up, and projects will be due soon and-"

"Already handed in everything."

Entrapta didn't say a word until she returned to the table, coffee mugs in hand.

"Well, I could be wrong, but you still seem worried about something," she mumbled, handing over Heath's mug.

"It's not worth you worrying about."

He took a sip of coffee, ignoring the burn as his eyes stayed fixed on the laptop screen.

"That's not for you to decide."

Heath's hands froze, eyes finding themselves taking in Entrapta. Lilac hair was thrown up into two messy buns, grasping a mug between their hands, and looking at Heath with raw honesty in their eyes.

"We don't get to choose who worries about us, or what for," she clarified. "So, even if you think it's something silly, or you don't tell me at all, I'll still worry. And that's okay."

Heath watched Entrapta and allowed himself to look at the unlikely friend he had made. The first person to ever give him the time of day besides his brothers, and even his brothers making time for him was a stretch. The only one that saw him as Heath, not the younger brother of a CEO, or the failed older brother of a rising prodigy. Now, he was Heath. A programmer, a broke college

student with a taste for bitter coffee, and Entrapta’s friend. It was a first, and it was terrifying, but it was good.

"Thanks," he mumbled, finding himself with the slightest of smiles. If he knew a single gesture could brighten Entrapta’s entire demeanour, he would have smiled more around them much earlier.

She didn’t respond, opting for bouncing slightly in their chair with the mug still cradled in her hands, a wide smile on their face.

The pair fell into a comfortable silence. The only sounds in the lab were the slurps of coffee, the frantic typing of Heath on his laptop, and the quiet humming of Entrapta next to him. Heath’s typing slowed. The lab smelt of grease, singed metal, and old tea bags, but with his friend next to him watching him work, it felt more like home than any building he had ever been in. There was so much he wanted to talk to them about. From the simple flowers on their campus that reminded him of her, whether they used the same brand of hair dye, all the way to why Hugo had stopped coming to the lab. That wasn’t for tonight. For now, he would drink in the peace that came with being away from everything outside the robotics lab with Entrapta.

As the pair worked late into the night, scanning endless lines of code and drinking seemingly endless cups of coffee, Heath didn't say a word as Entrapta lay their head on his shoulder. But neither did Entrapta, when Heath lay his head on hers.

Adora didn't get out of bed that morning. Sleep had escaped her the entire night, and even now she was wide awake the terror of leaving her room left her paralysed. That, and the fact that every single move she made hurt.

She knew carrying Catra was going to bite her in the ass once her brain caught up with her body, and oh did the biting sting. So did the memory of Catra's lips on hers.

Adora's breath shuddered, trying to focus on anything but the way Catra nestled into her arm as she carried her back to the dorm, or how gorgeous she was, asleep and tucked under the covers. Every bone in her body had screamed to climb under the covers with Catra, to hold her as she slept, to press a goodnight kiss to her forehead. Adora almost had. Her lips were only an inch away from Catra's skin when she realised, and she had remembered. Catra was drunk. She was drunk when she kissed Adora, and that was the only reason why.

Besides, Catra wasn't going to remember; she had said so herself.

Adora knew she should reach out, check in on Catra and make sure she was alright. She didn't have to say much, just something. But what could she even say? 'Hello, just making sure you're alive after drinking enough alcohol to get a strongman's stomach pumped, and if you do or don't remember kissing me in Scorpia's truck'? No way; she couldn't do that. Not to Catra. Not to herself.

The dorm room door squeaked open, pink hair appearing in the threshold. Adora's stomach dropped.

She knew it wasn't going to solve anything, but Adora had been avoiding Glimmer even since her birthday. The guilt of snapping at her friend had kept her away. Glimmer had only been trying to help her, to ease her through the grief she was feeling, and Adora had turned around and screamed at her. So, she had stayed away. That seemed like it wasn't an option anymore.

"Hey," Glimmer said, closing the door behind her.

"Hey," Adora mirrored, managing a slight smile at her roommate, her friend. "Sorry if I woke you up last night, I know I came in late."

Glimmer blinked, walking over to the desk.

"It's alright," she replied. "Bow told me what happened."

"He did?"

Glimmer nodded, dragging the chair over to Adora's bedside.

“Yeah, he’s with Catra and Scorpia right now. They’re both looking after her.”

The tightness in Adora’s chest eased a little, her breath coming a little easier. Even if it wasn’t her, Adora was glad someone was looking after Catra right now; stars knew she needed it.

“I’m surprised you’re not with them honestly,” the blonde said, hauling herself up to sit, grimacing. Glimmer didn’t hesitate, standing and reaching for Adora, placing a hand between her shoulder blades.

“Yeah, well,” Glimmer started, gently pushing Adora forward to help her sit up, “figured someone needed to be here for you too.”

The blonde’s words fell short, watching her friend sit in the space of her bed, Glimmer avoiding Adora’s eyes and exhaling slowly.

“Hey, I-” she sighed, forcing her eyes up to look at Adora, “I wanna apologise for your birthday. Even if I was trying to help, I shouldn’t have jumped in and said what I did, not with how you were feeling.”

Adora blinked. “What?”

Glimmer paled, and Adora immediately started talking before things got even worse.

“Glimmer, I should be the one apologising to *you,* ” she murmured, “you were right, you were just trying to help me, and then I turned around and started yelling at you. It wasn’t fair on you, it wasn’t fair on anyone there that I reacted like that.”

“Adora,” Glimmer interjected. “If I’m not in the wrong, then neither are you. You had just gotten some really bad news. Like, literally life-changing kind of bad news. What happened that day was just us feeling a lot of emotion and how to get it across properly. No one blames you for feeling the way you did, or how you reacted to it. I know that I don’t.”

Grey-blue eyes dropped, fixed on her fists grasping the blanket.

“I’m sorry for what I said about your dad,” Adora mumbled. “And your so-called ‘perfect world’, I can’t imagine what it’s like with your mother being headmistress of your college.”

“Kinda like having a famous athlete as your mum,” Glimmer tried, beaming when Adora laughed just a little. “I think you and my dad would have gotten along.”

“If he was anything like you are, I think we would have too.”

Glimmer smirked.

“Simp.”

Adora rolled her eyes, pinching Glimmer’s side and laughing along with her roommate.

“Just a bit,” she defended. “But also, if your dad’s case ever reopens, I am always down to solve a mystery.”

“I’ll only let you help if you were those glasses that you’re supposed to,” the shorter girl quipped, poking out her tongue at her roommate. Adora smiled, looking back down to the blanket.

“I think Mum would have liked you,” the blonde murmured, tearing her eyes away from the blanket, smiling at her roommate. “Bow too, she always joked about adopting a boy and getting me a brother.”

“Imagine that,” Glimmer chuckled. Adora gave another smile, shuffling over on her bed and patting the space beside her. The pink-haired girl beamed, sitting beside her friend and resting her head on her shoulder. There wasn’t a lot of room on the single bed, but after weeks of short glances and avoiding conversation, this was what they needed.

“Next time something like that happens,” Glimmer hummed, “d’you think we could, you know, not wait so long to talk about it? I missed being around you.”

Adora’s chest eased a little further, resting her head on Glimmer’s. “Hopefully there isn’t a next time, but sure,” she chuckled softly. “I missed you too.”

“How are you feeling? Seemed like last night took a lot out of you.”

Adora nodded against Glimmer. “You got that one right.”

“Going to the bleachers today?” she asked. “That always seems to cheers you up.”

The memory of soft lips and sour breath returned, and Adora closed her eyes, exhaling shakily.

“Not today.”

this is me trying

Chapter Summary

> There wasn't anything wrong, it was just her body misbehaving. Adora could do this, right?
> -
> Scorpia didn't think a phone call to her mothers could make her stomach drop. Yet, sitting here clutching her phone did exactly that.
> -
> It wasn't exactly what Glimmer had expected when Catra had messaged her, but she didn't know what she could expect when the message gave nothing away. 'meet at the jasmine dragon asap."

The end of the semester approached with the speed of a whirlwind train. Assessments were handed in, exams had come and gone, and each student around campus found themselves able to breathe a little easier. All of the students, except for Adora.

She was in the same place the year had started, on an abandoned field with an empty set of bleachers, her mother's initials carved into the metal. Just like a year ago, she was alone, the high bars the only thing keeping her company. Adora hadn't vaulted in months, let alone handled a vaulting pole. She had pushed through the pain at the start, it was just her muscles getting stronger she reasoned, it would go away soon. She would get better. After dragging herself to the doctor's office, Adora's blood was sent away, the hope of an answer on the horizon. The tests came back clear. There was nothing wrong.

The pain refused to leave, so Adora went back to the doctor and asked for what options she could take, blinking back the tears.

They sent her away for an x-ray. Her hips were where the pain had started, surely a scan would uncover what was wrong and reveal an answer. The x-rays were returned no sign of abnormality. There was nothing wrong.

So, here she was, faced with the high bars, and an invisible bar placed lower than ever before. Even then, Adora wasn't sure she could pass it. She didn't have to be perfect, she didn't need to succeed. All she had to do was try.

There wasn't anything wrong, it was just her body misbehaving. She could do this, right? The athlete looked up at the bars for an eternity before even reaching for them, joints and muscle already complaining as she stretched her arms upwards. If she couldn't even train, how could she vault? She needed to try, to prove to herself that she could do this. So, Adora grit her teeth and bared it.

The routine was the same as it always was. She dangled from the bar by her arms, keeping her legs straight and bringing her ankles to the bar and back down. *Repeat it,* Adora told herself. *Do it over and over again, no matter how much it hurt.* She tucked her knees to her chest, bringing herself upside down and hooking her ankles over the bar. The blood rushed to her head and her body screamed. Adora righted herself, arms threatening to pop out of her sockets as she dangled from the bar. *Again. You have to do it again, or you won't get any better. Keep going.*

This wasn't hard, this was all she had known since the day her mother brought her to the park, Adora watching her train through the playground telescope.

"Let me try, mummy!" she had cried, and of course Mara taught her. She had held Adora by her hips until her arms had found their strength, coaxed her to swing back and forth on the bar, and never let her fall. As the years passed, her mother still stood an arm's reach away. They both knew she didn't need it; Adora was

able to vault herself high into the air on her own, and her mother couldn't have been prouder. "Just in case," Mara had told her, but she had never needed then. Now, she was slipping.

Adora shuddered out a breath, unfurling herself and dangling once more, feeling her hands sliding from the bar. *Let go*, her mind screamed. *Gods please, please it hurts, just let go. This isn't worth it, let go!* Adora's grip started to loosen, and she fell.

She managed to stick the landing and stay upright, even as knives shot up her legs and spine. Training always brought aches, but they always helped her get stronger. The pain meant her muscles were working. Even after weeks and months of ignoring it, of trying to push through the pain, her gut told her the same thing. Adora couldn't do this anymore. At least not like this. This pain wasn't going to get any better, let alone go away if she kept going the way she was. If she wanted to get better, Adora had to stop.

Stars, how had it gotten to this? A year ago Adora was at the top of her game, an unstoppable, well-oiled machine, that now had every joint riddled with rust. Back then, her trajectory went upwards as her body grew stronger. Now the curve she was ahead of circled back into a sphere, and Adora was trapped in its vicious cycle. Train too hard, grit your teeth through the pain, rest until you can stand again, then drag yourself back to the empty field, and start all over again.

Adora had tried. No, she hadn't given up yet, this was just a bump in the road. This was her trying. She, at least, was trying.

"I can come back when I get better," the blonde mumbled to herself. Her eyes flicked to the bleachers and found it empty. Not

that Adora had expected any different; she had been the only one on this field in weeks. The blonde shook the thought from her head, if *she* had cared, this radio silence wouldn't have been happening.

A pang of longing pierced her chest, and more than ever Adora wished she had someone to talk to. There was Bow and Glimmer, of course, but they wouldn't get it. Not the way that Catra did. The only person the artist came close to was Mara herself, but neither of them was an option right now. Adora sighed, grabbing her gym bag and straightening herself up the best she could. She would be okay, she had to be.

"I'll be back soon," Adora whispered to the empty field, "I just need to get better first."

Then, a familiar cry.

"Adora!"

Scorpia didn't think a phone call to her mothers could make her stomach drop. Yet, sitting here clutching her phone did exactly that. Her laptop was open, her last message of encouragement from Perfuma in the corner of the screen, the instructions to change her major filling the rest of the page.

Scorpia didn't have to ask for permission, and she knew that. She was an adult, and this college tuition was hers to pay, just like this degree was hers to use. But this didn't just concern her. Black Garnet Industries had no heir except for Scorpia.

Her mothers had never forced her into anything, but she knew deep down it was their dream to pass the company on to Scorpia. She had decided to study business to put her in a better position for it, because why wouldn’t she? Everything she had, she owed to them. But with each passing week, she found each new piece of content beginning to frustrate her. She understood perfectly well, but it wasn’t what she wanted.

Every time she walked past the music room on the way to and from the library, her eyes lingered. They scanned the span of the instruments littered inside, wondering what it would be like to hear them every day, to follow the melody with an instrument of her own. Granted, her options were limited but not impossible. So, here she sat, having to break the news to her mothers. She took a deep breath, and hit dial.

Each passing ring sent a bout of nausea to Scorpia’s stomach. It was the weekend, they wouldn’t be working, so she called the home phone and hoped they would be home to answer it. Eventually, the ringing stopped.

“Stevenson residence,” came her mother, Maeve’s, voice.

“Hey, Ma,” she exhaled.

“Oh, hey little one! How are you doing? It’s not like you to call the home phone.”

“Yeah, sorry about that,” she started, trying to keep a stutter under control. “I just need to talk to you and Mum about something, and I wasn’t sure who to call so I just tried my luck with this phone and-”

“Woah, slow down, Scorpia,” her Ma reminded her. *“Take a deep breath. We’re both here if you need to talk to us.”*

“Yes please,” Scorpia mumbled. The sound changed over the phone, and Scorpia heard two voices instead of one.

“Are you there, sweetheart?” came Veronica’s voice.

“Yeah, I’m here Mum,” she replied, rereading Perfuma’s message over and over and evening out her breath. “I-uh, I wanna talk to you both about college stuff.”

“Is everything alright there?” her Ma asked.

"What do you need us to do?" her Mum chipped in. *"You already know if you need help with assignments you only need to ask-"*

"I'm changing my major."

Silence sounded over the phone for much longer than Scorpia was comfortable with. She didn't know what they would do now. She doubted disowning her was an option her mothers would ever consider, but stars, they would be so disappointed in her. She wasn't turning her back on just a company, Scorpia was turning her back on her family name. Then, her mothers spoke.

"Sweetheart, you know that you don't have to ask us to do something like that," her Mum breathed.

"We're gonna back you in whatever you decide to do, little one," her Ma assured her. *"What major do you think you'll change to?"*

Scorpia took a deep breath. She had come this far, it was just the next step forward.

"Music."

The response was immediate.

"Oh, that sounds lovely!" her Ma cheered. *"You always did have a good set of pipes, I told your mother years ago we should have put you into lessons."*

"Well, we can make good on that now, Maeve," her Mum hummed. *"If this is what you want to do, we'll support you the whole way. We may need you to help out here over Summer, but we can talk about that when you come home, alright?"*

Scorpia blinked the tears back grinning.

"Yeah, of course, Mum," she breathed. "Thank you both."

"No need to thank us, little one. We love you so much."

Scorpia's nausea eased, and she took a full breath for the first time that semester.

"I love you too."

The tables had turned from the last time Glimmer was at The Jasmine Dragon. Of course, the grumpy teenager still served them, and the bearded old man pouring tea was as jolly as ever. But instead of Glimmer searching for answers, she was now the

‘resident therapist of this shitshow’, as dubbed by none other than Catra.

Glimmer had bought them food, just like last time. Catra had barely sipped her boba, the pork buns, which she had heard were her favourite, sitting untouched on the table. The brunette couldn’t even meet Glimmer’s eyes.

“Hey, Catra?” she tried gently, the artist tearing her eyes away from the wooden table to look up.

“What?” was the grumbled response. It wasn’t exactly what Glimmer had expected when Catra had messaged her, but she didn’t know what she could expect when the message gave nothing away. ‘meet at the jasmine dragon asap.”

The smaller girl sighed, taking a sip of boba and gathering her words as best she could.

“I just wanted to check that you were alright,” Glimmer admitted. “When I got your message I was a bit worried about you. I honestly thought you weren’t safe or something.”

Catra frowned, huffing quietly and fiddling with her straw. “I’m not in trouble. Well, at least not in a physical sense,” she groaned, shaking her head, “I just needed to talk to you about something.”

Catra watched Glimmer's eyes widen before her expression focused and her posture straightened.

"Alright. What do you need?"

The brunette could only blink at first. She wasn't that close with Glimmer. Even after the first time they talked, they didn't become fast friends by any means. Every conversation they had was when Catra would message Glimmer first, asking if a certain someone was alright. And now, that same person was the whole reason Catra was here, swallowing her pride enough to tell Glimmer, "You were right."

Glimmer's eyebrows furrowed, eyes softening and keeping Catra's gaze.

"Right about what?"

It wasn't too late to run, or even lie. She had been good at lying on the spot, had been ever since she knew it could keep her alive. But how much longer did she want to deny this? Catra took a deep breath, closing her eyes and exhaling the truth.

"I'm in love with someone that I can't have."

Catra was expecting Glimmer to do a lot of things. Laugh at her, say 'I told you so' the way only a cocky political science student

would, apologise for the pointless endeavour Catra found herself in. Instead, Glimmer smiled.

"What happened?"

"How did you know something happened?"

"Well, I'll be honest," Glimmer started, "you and Adora are not exactly the most subtle people on the planet."

Catra wanted to ask Glimmer how she knew that it was Adora, but stopped herself before the words came out. Who else could it have been? Of course, Glimmer knew it was Adora.

"So, you disappear to The Whispering Woods for a night, and Adora snuck in and out at ungodly hours of the morning to bring your drunk ass home. Now it's a few weeks later, and you two haven't seen each other since then. Something must to have happened for the both of you to go from seeing each other every day to whatever the hell this is."

That threw Catra off.

"Wait," she murmured, looking to Glimmer with curious eyes. "How do you know that Adora and I haven't been talking?"

Glimmer’s expression didn’t change.

“You haven’t been going to the bleachers, have you?”

Catra shook her head, wordlessly.

“Well, neither has Adora,” she sighed. “Even when she’s in too much pain to move, let alone, she still goes to the bleachers. And after one chat with Scorpia about you two moping, and she tells me that you would go to the bleachers at the same time every day. The bleachers were your thing, your place. And for Adora to suddenly stop that? That sends up a flare right away.”

Catra blinked twice, wondering if she was a lot more obvious than she realised, or Sparkles was some kind of super sleuth.

“You definitely did your research,” she murmured, earning a shrug from Glimmer.

“Mermista is very into mysteries,” the pink-haired prep answered, “she gave me a hand with putting all the pieces together. So, back to my original question; what happened?”

Catra’s nausea punched her in the gut. She hadn’t told anyone about that night, not even Scorpia. She could lie, make up something that would fool Glimmer, and keep the skeletons in her

closet locked up tight. But if she wanted help, she had to be honest.

"I kissed her."

Glimmer frowned. "Why is that a bad thing?"

"Because it's *Adora* . I was drunk off my ass, I didn't ask or even think about what she wanted, I just grabbed her face and kissed her. And it wasn't just a peck or something, I *kissed* her. I took advantage of her," she murmured.

"Hold on, let me guess this right," Glimmer began, "you kissed Adora when you were drunk, and then the two of you just stopped talking?" She paused to watch Catra nod, sipping her boba before starting again. "I'll be honest, that doesn't sound like Adora. She'd be awkward for like a day or two, but she wouldn't let anything go unsaid-"

"She kissed me back."

Catra's admission sent Glimmer's jaw to the ground.

"She kissed you back?" she parroted, and Catra nodded.

“I was so drunk I didn’t think I was gonna remember it. But then I woke up the next morning and I remembered, and I thought she would hate me for takin-”

“Catra,” Glimmer interjected. “I think you are the most useless lesbian I have ever met, and I have Adora freaking Greyskull as a roommate.”

“Sparkles, what you talking about?” she asked.

“People don’t kiss their drunk friends back if they didn’t mean it, especially not people like Adora. They push them off the second it becomes more of a peck, or if they don’t they talk about it, joke about it, literally anything but this!”

“What are you trying to say-”

“Do the math, dickhead!” Glimmer whisper shouted across the table. “If it was the kind of kiss you’re saying it is, why would Adora kiss you back?”

Every drop of blood in Catra’s head raced to her chest.

“She meant it,” Catra breathed.

“She meant to kiss you,” Glimmer echoed. “And now who knows what Adora is thinking now that the two of you haven’t spoken since then.”

Catra didn’t need Glimmer to spell that one out for her. Adora thought she didn’t remember. Adora thought Catra didn’t mean it when that couldn’t have been further from the truth.

“I need to go.”

Glimmer frowned. “Go?”

The look in Catra’s eyes was wild, determined.

“I need to tell her.”

She didn’t waste time on letting Glimmer respond, abandoning the table and bolting out of The Jasmine Dragon without a second glance. She thanked the universe for having the cafe so close to their bleachers. Catra didn’t know she could run as fast as she did, lungs heaving in the chill of the spring air, hoping and praying to whatever deity that was listening that Adora was at their place. The thought of texting or calling didn’t cross her mind. Adora could have blocked her by now, she would have been surprised if the blonde didn’t, and she didn’t think her heart could take that confirmation right now. So she kept running.

Adora thought she hadn’t meant it. That thought alone kept Catra drawing breath, kept her legs at a blistering pace towards the campus. When the bleachers came into view, her heart leaped and sunk as one. She was there. Adora was there, with the same stupid jacket, and just as stupidly beautiful as the last time Catra saw her. But she was walking away from the bleachers. She hadn’t seen Catra.

“Adora!” Catra cried like it was the only thing there was left to do.

Adora stopped walking and turned around.

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Chapter Summary

> "Can we talk about the other night? The one in The Whispering Woods?"
>
> "Okay. Start talking."

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Adora, wait!”

Adora was dreaming. She had to be, that was the only explanation that made sense. Catra, who hadn’t seen or spoken to Adora in weeks, was now bolting across the field towards her. She couldn't tell Catra’s expression from how far away she was, but the way she had called Adora’s name was desperate. Maybe she was in trouble. Hell, she had never seen Catra like this.

Whatever it was, it was bad. Catra always held herself tall, her stature radiating pride, her eyes and words sharp and precise. Even after months of knowing Catra, and spending every day by her side, the times Adora saw Catra with her guard down could be counted on one hand. But now, as Adora finally saw the look in her eyes, Catra was frightened.

She bit back the pain, taking one step towards her, then another, moving to Catra as fast as her body would allow her. Adora shouldn’t be doing this, she knew that. It had been weeks since they talked, there was too much that floated in the limbo between them, too many things they needed to figure out that they couldn’t just brush aside or forget. Even worse, words that Adora should have forgotten by now raced through her head, keeping time with her heart.

I’ll have the ice pack if you need it later. Did you remember to eat today? You should probably get some sleep, I’ll stay on the phone with you. We wanted to surprise you, dummy. It’s you, you’re the sun.

She needed to make sense of it all, why Catra would have said those things in the first place, why they made Adora feel the way she did, but Adora had more important things to worry about for now. She needed to make sure Catra was okay.

“Catra!” she cried, the brunette finally coming into arms reach. Before Adora could reach out for her, to check her over for being hurt, Catra’s face was buried in the crook of her neck, lithe arms locked around her waist. She froze, feeling Catra’s breath shakily exhale into her shirt.

"Catra?" Adora murmured, arms loosely wrapping around her, "what's going on? Are you okay?"

Catra stayed still, eventually shaking her head against Adora’s shoulder.

"What happened?" she asked the artist, the need to protect Catra swelling in her chest. "Are you safe?"

Catra, once again, remained silent. Anxiety began to prickle in Adora’s chest, moving her grip to Catra's hips and pulling herself away to look at the artist in her arms.

Catra watched stormy blue eyes scan her form, gaze narrowed and determined, searching for something. She watched Adora's eyebrows draw together, confused, and Catra despite it all couldn’t help but feel her lips twitch up, just a little.

"I'm safe," she breathed, Adora’s head snapping up at the sound of her voice. Blue eyes locked on hers, and Catra had to curl her hands into fists on Adora's shirt to stop herself from kissing her.

"You promise?" the blonde mumbled, and Catra nodded furiously.

"Yeah. I promise."

"Oh, thank stars," Adora sighed, drawing Catra back into her arms. The limbo of unsaid things still lingered in Adora's mind, but she didn't care for the minute. Catra was here, and she was alright. That was at least one crisis out of many averted. Catra's arms circled her shoulders, and Adora buried her face into her neck, a sigh of relief spilling over her flannel.

"I was so worried," the blonde admitted, words spilling out that she didn't have the heart to stop. "I hadn't heard from you in ages, and you looked so scared when you were running over

here, and I knew you wouldn't have gone to me unless it was really bad and-"

"Adora, slow down," Catra interrupted, pulling away just enough to meet those blue eyes, "it's not like that. I'm sorry I scared you."

"Can you at least tell me what's going on then?" she asked. She was glad Catra was safe, even if the sight of her bolting across the bleachers made her stomach drop, but nothing that was currently happening made sense to Adora. She needed to find out, she needed to know what was going on. Even if it would break her heart.

"I will, I just-" Catra sighed, letting her arms fall back to her side. "Look, I'm alright. I'm not in any kind of danger or anything like that. I just- I just need to talk to you. Please."

Catra watched her eyebrows furrow, Adora taking a step away and hugging her arms to herself. She had always been an open book, especially to Catra. Confusion swirled in the stormy blue, another look Catra could have sworn was longing, but all of it was overshadowed by a look of fear. Adora was scared.

"Okay," the blonde muttered, eyes not leaving Catra’s once. "I’m listening. Start talking."

The artist gulped, pulling her eyes down to the ground, fiddling with the rings on her hands. Stars, this had seemed so easy. Tell Adora how she felt, scoop her up, kiss her senseless, and never let go of her again. Now, it was all too real.

The fear of losing Adora was all too real. Whether or not feelings were involved, Catra had messed up big time, especially with her closest friend. Adora letting her talk at all was a miracle. Every daydream she had imagined with Adora, every possibility of having her in Catra's life relied on this. One wrong word and Adora was gone.

"Can we talk about the other night?" Catra whispered. "The one in The Whispering Woods?"

Adora blinked, watching Catra’s expression flick back up to meet hers. Her eyes were wide, imploring, her figure small with shoulders slouched forward, only an arm’s length distance away from her. Blue eyes flicked down to Catra's hands and her heart dropped. Catra only ever fiddled with her rings when she was nervous.

Of course, it was about that night, what else could it have been? What other reason would Catra had gone radio silent only to Adora for weeks without a word. Talking about the night at The Whispering Woods could only mean one thing. But, Adora needed to hear her say it.

"Yeah, what about it?"

She watched Catra take a shaky breath, eyes not leaving hers as the brunette exhaled, taking a step closer.

"I remember. Adora, I remember *everything* from that night."

Adora didn't think two words could send her whole world crashing down.

Catra had told Adora herself she wouldn't have remembered, and even in her wildest dreams Adora never thought she would, given the state of her at the time. The taste of bourbon had haunted her for weeks. In the ruins, everything made sense.

Catra remembered everything, and everything included the kiss. Adora's eyes scanned over her frame, taking in the way Catra fidgeted, the way she avoided her eyes, the softness of her usually sharp voice. Adora blinked twice, murmuring to the ground, "Catra, I'm so sorry."

The artist immediately looked up. Adora was apologising? What was she even apologising for? No, gods no, this wasn't how it was supposed to go. Adora couldn't even look at her. Maybe Glimmer had it wrong, maybe the entire thing was a giant mistake, and talking about this would only make it worse.

“What?” was the only thing Catra could mutter, her heart buried in her stomach.

Adora sniffled, raising her head to look at Catra, giving her the most comforting smile she could muster and failing. How she felt didn’t matter, it never had. Now, all Adora could do was make sure she didn’t lose her closest friend to a stupid feeling. She knew what she needed to do, no matter how much it hurt.

“It’s okay, Catra,” she started, arms curled against her chest. “I get it, you were drunk, it didn’t mean anything.”

When Adora’s eyes welled up, she missed the expression on Catra’s face. She couldn’t hear Catra’s footsteps bringing her closer over her heart beating itself to death in her ears.

“Adora, what are you talking about-”

“The kiss, Catra!” she snapped.

The silence that fell over the field threatened to choke them both. The figure haunting them for weeks on end, the words that neither of them had wanted to say had now been said, the reality of it all brought to life. Catra said nothing, so Adora kept talking.

“I know that’s why you’ve been avoiding me,” the blonde mumbled. “But, it’s okay. I’m so sorry I didn’t say anything earlier,

but I promise you what happened doesn't have to change anything You were drunk, and you didn't know what you were doing, so you don't have to explain anything, I get it."

Catra's frown deepened, watching Adora's eyes stare blankly ahead, looking right through the artist instead of at her, like whatever the blonde would say next brought her pain.

"It was just a drunk kiss, I know you didn't mean anything by it."

The moment after those words left Adora's mouth, Catra didn't have control over her limbs. But in retrospect, she didn't regret a second. Catra closed the gap separating herself from Adora and reached for the blonde's hips, fisting her jacket in her hands, and pulling their bodies flush together. Before Adora could say another word, Catra brought their lips together and kissed her with the softness of a daydream.

Adora gasped against her friend's lips, her brain unable to produce any kind of thought that wasn't *Stars above, Catra is kissing me* . Her hands found the collar of Catra's flannel, and she kissed back.

The kiss wasn't like last time. There was no rush, no fight, no tugging at each other with the fear they would slip away. This time around, they had time. Hands anchored the other close, hearts falling into sync while their lips danced together. Catra felt Adora smile against her lips, and whatever breath she had left her lungs. When they pulled away, Catra kept their foreheads pressed together, refusing to let Adora go.

“Do you get it now?” she breathed, eyes open and searching Adora’s. The blonde, as endearing as ever to the artist, stared blankly with evident awe on her flushed face, mouth slightly parted as she caught her breath and gorgeous sky blue wide with wonder. Catra’s hands cradled Adora’s cheeks, exhaling softly before laying her heart out before her friend.

“I love you, dummy,” she whispered, those words only for Adora. “I’ve kinda been in love with you for months now.”

Adora smiled brighter than the sun itself, and Catra’s heart soared.

“I kissed you that night ‘cause I’d been looking at that beautiful, dumb face of yours for months, and I’d been wondering what you tasted like since that night you took me out for my birthday,” Catra admitted, running her thumb along Adora’s cheekbone, watching the blonde lean into her touch. “And, stars, I’m sorry that it took me getting absolutely hammered to finally get the guts to do it, and I’m sorry I didn’t have the guts to say anything about it for weeks but I-”

With newfound courage, Adora surged forward and kissed Catra softly, briefly, stopping her words in the artist’s tracks. Mismatched eyes were blown wide, a dark flush decorating freckled cheeks and it was the most beautiful thing Adora had ever seen.

“I love you too,” Adora whispered, barely a breath between their lips. “And if we’re being honest, I *really* love kissing you.”

For the first time in what felt like forever, Catra's guard dropped, and she laughed into the space between their lips.

"You gonna kiss me again then?" she hummed, one hand sneaking around to brush along her undercut. Adora's eyes brightened, her palms fitting perfectly over the swell of Catra's hips.

"You mean, I can?" she asked, wonder laced through her voice. Catra rolled her eyes fondly, bringing their faces closer together.

"Of course you can, dummy," the artist chuckled, her lips coming up into a slight smirk before Adora kissed it away.

She had to admit, kissing Catra was so much nicer when she was sober. Her lips were firm and soft against her own, and pomegranate would forever be her favourite fruit now she knew it tasted like Catra. Calloused fingers on the nape of her neck sent shivers down Adora's spine, her empty lungs dragged her away with a pout. Seeing Catra, however, was worth the withdrawal.

Catra chuckled at the childish pout, watching Adora smile and pressing their foreheads together, wrapping her arms around the blonde's shoulders and feeling toned arms circle her waist, keeping her close. The almost unnatural warmth of Adora's body shouldn't have shocked her, but even if it did, it was a pleasant surprise. Every part of Adora was made from soft, morning sunlight. Her golden hair, her skin, her smile, hell she even tasted liked summertime. It only made sense for the warmth to seep

through the cracks in Catra’s walls, and warm her from the inside out.

“Wow,” Adora breathed.

“Don’t ruin it,” Catra chided playfully. They didn’t need to say anything more; they both knew this moment, regardless of what came after, was impossible to ruin.

Chapter End Notes

lil early valentine's gift for y'all. hope you enjoyed, I treasure every comment and kudo you folks leave on this little story of mine x

going home

Chapter Summary

> The three all loosened their arms and looked around them, the emptiness of the room a stark contrast to just a day ago. Strange didn't quite cover it, but it was the closest word Adora could think of.
> -
> Entrapta wasn't surprised when Heath turned up at the bus stop. As odd as it sounded, they almost expected it.
> -
> "We'll be able to see each other over the summer, right?" the blonde asked, shyness threaded through her words.

Chapter Notes

> here it is, the final chapter of this is me (trying)! thank you all for coming along with me on this journey; I hope you have enjoyed it, and will tune in to the next book - details will be in the end notes. enjoy the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For the first time in months, all three beds in B Block's Room 11 were bare. Marks had been released for every assignment and exam a student may have sat, and while some fared better than others, everyone shared the same feeling of relief. The semester was over, and summertime was here.

The energy in the air buzzed around the entire campus, students left and right packing up their things, eager to leave the campus behind them, at least for a few months. As Adora watched out the window, she felt a pang of something she couldn't place.

“You okay there, Adora?” Bow asked. Hope wasn’t able to pick Adora up until that afternoon, a self-proclaimed work emergency keeping her in the office. Coincidentally, Glimmer had to stay behind later due to her mother’s hours, and naturally, Bow had stayed behind with them, wanting to keep the pair company. Adora turned back around to face her roommates, the tightness of her chest easing a touch. They stood in the middle of the room, Glimmer tucked against Bow’s chest, his hand on the small of her back and hers around his waist. The sight of them so happy made Adora smile.

“Just peachy, Bow,” Adora hummed, walking away from the window. “I think it’s all just kind of hitting me, you know?”

“I mean, kind of. What exactly is hitting you?” Glimmer tilted her head, watching Adora with a faint look of concern. The blonde shrugged, shoving her hands into her jacket pockets and mulling over her words.

“This is basically the first quiet moment we’ve had since the start of our first semester,” she started, “and now we’re all going home again. I just got used to having everyone around again, and now who knows how often we’ll get to see each other over summer.”

Glimmer’s concern shifted into a cheeky grin.

“You think just because it’s summer that you can get away with not seeing us?” she teased. Blue eyes shifted to Bow, who immediately gave a wide smile.

“Don’t be silly, you know that’s not happening.” He outstretched his hand towards the blonde, who took it smiling. Grasping his hand, Adora let Bow drag her towards him and Glimmer, who both promptly wrapped their arms around her.

“We’re gonna see you any time we can,” Bow mumbled to her. “Which should be a lot, providing Glimmer actually manages to get her license this summer.”

“First of all, this is a slander that I will not stand for,” Glimmer mumbled into Bow’s chest, earning a chuckle from him and Adora. "And second of all, hanging out is gonna give me the motivation to get my license."

"We'll believe it when we see it," the blonde hummed, laughing as Glimmer pinched her side in response.

The three all loosened their arms and looked around them, the emptiness of the room a stark contrast to just a day ago. The bright covers had all been folded away, the lights and photographs taken down from the closet, every tangible thing linked to their memories packed away in suitcases. Strange didn’t quite cover it, but it was the closest word Adora could think of.

"Is it weird that I'm already looking forward to next year?" Bow asked.

Adora focused back into Bow’s words. "I think that depends on the reason," she offered. "Like, if you're excited about schoolwork, then you are absolutely crazy."

"Oh, gods no," he immediately replied. "If I ever have to read another whitewashed history book it'll be too soon. I just meant stuff like this, y’know. Rooming together, seeing each other every day, complaining about the communal bathrooms way too often."

"I am definitely not gonna miss the bathrooms," Glimmer grumbled. "I'd sooner pay for us all to pay somewhere else."

A faint chuckle sounded between the three of them, trickling into silence and three sets of eyes looking around the room then back at each other.

"I mean, it would be nice having a little more space," Adora started, "and we managed to spend a whole year in here without too much damage."

"You haven't had to listen to Glimmer snore every night," Bow reminded, earning another pinch from the smallest student.

"I am literally right here,” the aforementioned student grumbled. “Besides that, I think we might actually be onto something here. But even if we are, we’ll actually have to plan this out properly, unlike basically everything else we do.”

“Hey! I am fully capable of planning stuff!” Adora defended.

“Dates with Catra don’t count.”

The blonde pouted slightly, waiting in silence for a few moments before she spoke.

“I think it could work, but Glimmer’s right. We’d definitely need to sort out a bunch of things first.”

“Well, luckily we have a whole three months without classes to do that,” Bow reminded the pair. “Besides, if we can survive our first year of college together all in the same room, I think moving in together after summer would be a breeze.”

A lot of things went unspoken between the trio. They needed to figure out a way to get enough money together to pay rent, needed to convince parents and guardians that this was a good idea, and then make it all work if they managed to get that far. Even still, there was hope. Bow’s words rang true amongst the three of them; after the year they had just lived through, surely there wouldn’t be much more that could knock them down.

Adora knew she wasn’t the only one, but she surprisingly found herself already looking forward to the end of summer, when classes would begin, and she could come home.

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Entrapta wasn't surprised when Heath turned up at the bus stop. As odd as it sounded, they almost expected it. The pair of them had obviously spent numerous hours together over the course of working on *Emily* , but something had changed after the encounter with Hunter, mostly in Heath. If they finished at the robotics lab after dark, Heath would walk Entrapta to her dorm. Whenever Entrapta mentioned they were running errands, Heath always asked if someone was going with them. When the answer was no, Heath always offered his company.

It didn't bother Entrapta, but it confused her. Entrapta knew Heath enjoyed spending time with them, and the feeling was mutual, but she could never quite place why a single encounter with Heath's older brother had him keeping a close eye on them. Heck, Entrapta was not the most observant person; for her to notice meant he was making no effort to be subtle. So as he sat beside them on the bus stop, Entrapta merely smiled.

"We survived our first year, huh?" she started, removing the ear bud on Heath's side, turning to face him.

He shrugged, a hand struggling to tame his bright hair, eyes straight forward.

“I guess we have,” he relented with. “Although I’m not sure it was entirely intact.”

“Sheesh, you make it sound like someone was murdered or something,” Entrapta grumbled. Heath only gave a grunt in response.

Silence between the pair wasn’t unusual; if anything, it was the closest thing to tradition they had. With the amount of projects the pair darted between, not to mention working on *Emily* , there was never a lot of room for conversation. Entrapta was used to it, but even they knew that something was wrong.

It couldn’t have been a coincidence that the way Heath acted around Entrapta changed right after Hunter visited the lab. The change was only solidified when Hugo stopped coming all together. There had to be connection, some tangible pattern linking all of these changes together, even if Entrapta couldn’t figure it out.

“I’m not very good at the whole ‘feelings’ thing,” they admitted. “Even with Scorpia helping me, it’s still a lot. So, I’m not going to ask if you’re okay.”

Entrapta shifted her torso towards him, seeing his gaze raise up to theirs.

“But I will remind you that I am here if you need anything.”

Entrapta watched Heath's eyes soften slightly, and briefly entertained the thought of seeing him smile. If he did, she would keep it to herself.

"Thank you," he mumbled after a moment. "I... apologise for the way I've acted the past few weeks."

Entrapta frowned. "What?"

Heath's eyes went back to looking forward, looking at something neither of them could see. "I've not given you as much space. I'm not able to explain exactly why I had to do so, but I hope you can believe me when I say I had your best interests at heart."

A hand reached out for Heath, gently resting on his shoulder. His gaze followed the touch, finding Entrapta's gentle smile at the other end.

"You don't have to explain anything," they told him. "Not if you're not comfortable talking about it."

The way the faint wince crossed Heath's face told Entrapta everything she needed to know.

"Right. Well. Like I said, you don't have to tell me what's going on. Just tell someone if you need help?"

Heath paused, mulling over the words before nodding, reaching into his bag to retrieve a notepad. Entrapta's eager eyes saw no notes, only empty pieces of paper. She watched him promptly tear a corner off a page, writing down a series of numbers with his name beside it before handing it to Entrapta. One glance was all it took to see it was a phone number.

"So we can keep in touch," came his explanation. "So we can keep working on *Emily* over the summer."

Entrapta smiled, taking the paper from him, but her reply was cut off by the arrival of her bus.

"I'll see you soon?" they offered, collecting her bags ready to board the bus. The ghost of a smile appeared on Heath's lips for just a second, but it was long enough to let blood rush to Entrapta's cheeks.

"I hope so."

As the bus pulled away from the curb, Entrapta curled up in their seat with her backpack to their chest.. Pulling out her phone with Heath's number in her free hand, they tried to ignore the niggling feeling that it might be for something more.

As the afternoon sun set over the campus, Catra sprawled out across the seat of the bleachers. Her entire being was oddly warm; between the arrival of summertime and the sun's rays kissing her skin, it wasn't a hard feat to accomplish. But even then, Catra knew that most of the feeling was due to the sound of someone along the empty field running towards her.

"Took you long enough to show up," she purred, hearing the sound of someone setting down bags, then climbing up the bleachers.

"Yeah, well, I'm not exactly the quickest person in the world, cut me some slack," Adora grumbled. Sitting on the row below Catra so their heads could rest together, the blonde craned her head to press a quick kiss to Catra's forehead.

"Hey," the blonde hummed, and Catra's heart swelled.

"Hey there, dummy," she replied, laying on her side with an arm outstretched. Wordlessly, Adora reached up, and intertwined their fingers absentmindedly.

"How did all your packing go?"

Catra huffed, closing her eyes and squeezing Adora's hand. "Fine, I guess. There wasn't a whole lot to pack, most of my stuff was at Scorpia's anyway. Got some drawings done while I was waiting either way."

She didn’t need to be looking to feel Adora frown.

“Catra, you know that it’s your place too, right?”

Catra sighed, tracing her thumb along Adora’s hand, grateful for the distraction. She had lived at Scorpia’s since Winter break, almost half a year already, and the thought to look somewhere else wasn’t one Catra had often. But even then, she hadn’t been able to call it her place.

“Yeah, I know,” she muttered eventually. “I guess I thought it would feel like home by now. It’s a hell of a lot better than Weaver’s and-” Catra sighed, and Adora squeezed her hand a little tighter. “I don’t know, I just thought that it would be enough. That all it needed to feel like home was to be better than the one place I knew.”

She felt Adora turn, and surely enough when she opened her eyes, Catra saw Adora resting her head on the seat where Catra lay, watching her closely.

“I think it takes a little more than that,” the blonde started. “Obviously, a house that isn’t falling apart makes that easier, but I don’t think that’s the most important thing. It needs to be somewhere that makes you feel safe, somewhere where you don’t have to pretend to be someone else.”

The cogs began to turn in Catra's head immediately, biting her lip to hold back saying anything. After all, this was all so new. She and Adora had confessed, yes, but they hadn't said anything more. They had spent time together as they usually did, and traded soft kisses when the comfortable silence turned into a staring competition. The curiosity began to eat away at Catra, but she did her best to keep it under wraps. After all, they had time. Adora watched Catra frown ever so slightly, eyes tangled together as the artist whispered.

"Do you think home has to be a place?"

Adora's heart skipped a beat, smiling widely at her.

"No," she breathed. "I don't think so."

Catra's lips twitched up, shifting forward to capture Adora's lips gently, the taste of coconut sending her head spinning. She still wasn't used to being allowed to kiss Adora now, if she would ever be.

"We'll be able to see each other over the summer, right?" the blonde asked, shyness threaded through her words.

"Of course we will, dummy," Catra muttered, pecking her once more. "It's not like Scorpia's mums will be stopping me. Besides, you're just a bus ride away."

Adora's smiled faded a touch, but she nodded. "I know," she started. "I'm just worried Hope will say something."

"What would she even say? It's not like we did anything to her."

The blonde shrugged, fiddling with the fabric of Catra's flannel. "She's just like that. She was never super keen on anything that took my attention away from my studies."

"Adora, you literally have three months without studying," Catra reminded her. "If she tells you that you need to be studying, tell her to get that giant stick out of her-"

HONK!

Both girls whipped their heads around, seeing Hope's car pulling up next to the empty field.

"Huh, Darla's out of the shop," Adora mused.

"'Darla'?"

The blonde shrugged, standing up and slinging her gym bag over her shoulder.

"Mum's old car. She needed a bunch of repairs done, but she's been sitting in the shop for months now. Anyway," she gave a dismissive wave, "it's a long story. Maybe I could tell you over dumplings one time?"

Catra smiled, rising from her own seat to meet Adora's height. "Sounds good, princess."

The moment Adora took her in her arms, Catra dreaded the moment she'd have to let go. Face buried in Adora's neck, she breathed in the scent of summer, feeling strong hands holding the small of her back, soft lips pressing a kiss to her forehead.

"Hey, it's just a bus ride away, remember?" Adora reminded her. "You're not getting rid of me anytime soon."

Catra chuckled into the collar of her jacket, fingers carding through her undercut.

"As if I'd want to," she hummed. "You're stuck with me now."

She pulled away to see Adora's smile beaming at her, and not even the thought of Hope watching them was enough to stop Catra leaning in and kissing Adora sweetly. It was short, sweet,

and something Catra wished she could do every day. Maybe, in the near future, she could.

"You better go before Hope gets pissy," Catra muttered, coaxing a bright laugh from the blonde.

"I hate it when you're right," Adora mumbled, slowly letting her hands fall away and grabbing her last bag. "I'll see you soon?"

Catra gave a small smile, even as her spiders crawled around in her stomach.

"I'll see you soon."

Mismatched eyes watched Adora jog towards the car, throwing her bags in the boot effortlessly before climbing into the front seat. They watched as the car pulled away, delighting in the small, shy wave from Adora, before she and the car disappeared into the horizon. Catra exhaled, already missing the way Adora melted into her side. Even then the usual tightness in her chest didn't appear; instead she found herself smiling without reason. Even a small thing such as that was enough to remind Catra how far she had come. She was happy.

As her phone buzzed in her pocket, Catra thought nothing of it, thinking it would just be Adora and her sappy self, something they had both discovered now their feelings were out in the open. She

pulled it out, turning on the screen before Catra’s stomach dropped at the notification.

[Message from: Unknown Number]

Enjoy this temporary bliss while it lasts, Catarina. It won’t be around for long.

Chapter End Notes

yes, the final chapter ended on a massive cliffhanger. no, it wasn't a mistake and no, I don't regret it.
I am proud to stay that the second installment of "take my hand, wreck my plans" is under way, and the first chapter will be published in the next few weeks!
I already have the entire fic planned, but I can't guarantee how often I'll be able to post since I start studying a Master's degree tomorrow (EEEEEEEEEE!). all of the loose ends and cliffhangers that appeared in this fic will be wrapped up next book, but there will be plenty more moments and mysteries for our gang to go through.

thank you so much for all the love you folks have given this story, and I hope to see you all very soon!

End Notes

a self indulgent college au? You betcha!

want to request a fic? head over to my Tumblr and shoot me a message! (@beeeeetle)

fic playlist: https://open.spotify.com/playlist/6I2PdCcnlFFecTMPH272O6?si=vSX9PV07T7e3VXzQvJFqvA

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!